FRIDAY
October 23, 2026

INTERNATIONAL EDITION
20 Pages

THE HINDU

www.thehindu.com

INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Vol. 4 • No. 251

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The corporation is still on a ministerial leash

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INSIDE



Russia says 808 drones downed; pounds Ukraine

KYIV
Russia bombarded Kyiv with ballistic missiles in an hours-long nighttime barrage, while the Russian military said on Thursday that its air defences intercepted over 800 drones fired by Ukraine at Moscow and other cities. At least four people were killed in Ukraine and dozens of other people were wounded, officials said. » PAGE 14



Karnataka SIR: 76,000 inclusion appeals rejected

BENGALURU
A total of 76,176 Form 6 applications seeking inclusion in the final electoral rolls have been rejected by the Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer (CEO)'s office on various grounds, including submission of duplicate applications and applicants not being available during verification, besides other reasons. » PAGE 3

eMudhra to stop issuing certificate for web security

NEW DELHI
The Bengaluru-based firm eMudhra, whose intermediate security certificates' private keys were exposed on Tuesday in an extraordinary security incident, will exit the global business of offering web security certificates, the firm said after the firm's stocks hit the circuit breaker for two trading sessions. The firm will continue the business it is engaged in for issuance of SSL certificates for Indian websites, a spokesperson told *The Hindu*. » PAGE 12

Indian among 2 dead as Houthis target Saudi's Dammam airport

Attack on King Fahd International Airport injures eight, says the kingdom; Saudi forces targeted yacht carrying 14 Indians in Red Sea, and rescue operations are under way, say rebels; there will be siege for siege and escalation for escalation, they add

Stanly Johny

Two people, including an Indian national, were killed and eight injured on Wednesday in a Houthi attack on King Fahd International Airport in Dammam, Saudi Arabia's eastern oil hub, the kingdom's General Authority of Civil Aviation said.

The Iran-aligned rebels also claimed that Saudi Arabian forces on Thursday targeted an Indian yacht near Zuqar Island in Red Sea, carrying 14 Indians, adding that they were conducting rescue operations.

The Indian Embassy in Riyadh confirmed the Indian national's death. "Saudi authorities have informed that one Indian national was among two people who unfortunately lost their lives in the attack on Dammam airport yesterday night and two Indian nationals were injured," the embassy wrote in a social media post on Thursday. On Thursday, the Houthis (Ansar Allah) said they will continue their operations against Saudi Arabia. "There will be siege for siege and escalation for escalation," they said, adding the strikes would continue until Saudi Arabia lifts its blockade of the Houthi-held areas of Yemen.

If Saudi Arabia continues to attack Yemen, "we will resort to major options we did not want to take, and we hold it responsible for the consequences," the Iran-backed militants said, as per the Houthi-aligned Almasirah television.



On watch: Saudi Arabia-backed govt. troops seen in the Yemeni city of Taiz on Wednesday amid the conflict with the Houthis. AFP

'Serious concerns'

The targeting of a civilian vessel carrying Indian nationals raises serious concerns about the safety of international navigation and the potential for civilian casualties, the Yemeni militia said. "The [Houthi] Armed Forces are carrying out rescue operations for those on board, with further details to be provided later," they said, according to Almasirah television.

The Indian Embassy in Yemen responded to the reports on attack on the yacht. "We are ascertaining further details about the incident and will provide all possible help for ensuring the safety and well-being of the Indian nationals," it said on X.

The Houthis, who captured Sana'a in 2014 and expanded their territorial control along Yemen's entire Red Sea coast last month, said they launched missile and drone attacks at Saudi Arabia's Ministry of Defence in Riyadh and the Dammam airport. They also struck a facility of Aramco, the state-owned petroleum and natural gas company, in Yanbu, and Abha International Airport in the southwest.

Saudi Arabia started bombing Yemen in 2015 after the Houthis captured Sana'a a few months earlier. In 2022, Riyadh and the Houthi leadership agreed to a ceasefire as part of a broader Iran-Saudi rapprochement. The ceasefire collapsed in July, in the midst of the U.S.-Iran war, as the Sana'a airport was bombed by Saudi Arabia to prevent an Iranian airline carrying a Houthi delegation from landing.

In recent weeks, the Houthis have stepped up attacks against Saudi airports and energy infrastructure, while the kingdom has intensified its air strikes on the Houthi-controlled parts of Yemen.

Efforts on to bring back thousands of stranded Indians

NEW DELHI
Amid escalating attacks on Saudi Arabia by the Iran-backed Houthi rebels, Indian missions in Riyadh and Jeddah are working with stakeholders to facilitate the early return of thousands of stranded pilgrims, the External Affairs Ministry said on Thursday. » PAGE 4

ITBP D-G says face-off with China continues in Arunachal Pradesh

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI



Shatrujeet Kapur

Confrontations with Chinese troops continue to take place at multiple sites along the border in Arunachal Pradesh, according to Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) Director-General Shatrujeet Kapur.

"In the past few-days, a situation arose where face-off happened at several locations in Arunachal and it still continues," Mr. Kapur said on Thursday.

Speaking at the Himveer Samman Samaroah, an annual felicitation ceremony for ITBP personnel, in Alwar, Rajasthan, Mr. Kapur said the force's commandos have been active in the continuing confrontations on the Arunachal Pradesh border.

This is the first official confirmation of the scale of the rising tensions on the northeastern border since July.

Government sources told *The Hindu* that since late July, India and China have been engaged in a stand-off at Asaphila near Taksing in Arunachal Pradesh. The Chinese People's Liberation Army (PLA) have pitched their tents at an elevation, within 6 km to 7 km of India's perception of the Line of Actual Control (LAC), near the Maja company operating base in Taksing circle of Upper Subansiri district, sources said.

"Our newly raised Shaurya commandos played an exemplary role in this. ITBP was raised as a mountain guerilla force and we were given border guarding duty along China in 2004," the ITBP chief said. "We need not leave our original function, and a specialised high altitude mountain fighting force is being set up, distinct than the army. We will soon have one full battalion of Shaurya commandos; high-altitude [deployment] is our strength," Mr. Kapur added

The situation has persisted even though Chinese President Xi Jinping attended the 18th BRICS Summit hosted by India from September 11 to 13, and the two nations have held three high-level border talks since July.

"Sometime in July, during routine patrolling, Indian and Chinese troops came face to face near Maja. After brief confrontation, both sides returned but the Chinese PLA came back in larger number few days later and pitched tents, around 6-7 kms within India's perception of the LAC," a government source said.

India has also increased deployment along the border.

Bilateral border talks

The 36th WMCC (Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs) meeting on India-China border affairs was held on August 6. This was followed by the 25th round of talks between the Special Representatives (SR) on the Boundary Question on August 26 in Beijing, where India was represented by National Security Adviser (NSA) Ajit Doval.

On September 6, the first-ever Corps Commander-level meetings between the two armies was held in the Eastern Sector at the Vacha-Damai Border Personnel Meeting Point in Arunachal Pradesh.

Such meetings have so far largely been held at the Chushul-Moldo Border Meeting Point in eastern Ladakh, particularly after the Galwan Valley clashes in June 2020.

The weapons used by the ITBP are 50-years old and modernisation is required, said Mr. Kapur. Stressing on the need to invest and develop drone and counter-drone technology, he said it may not be possible to face China through traditional methods as it has invested a lot in modernisation of its arms and infrastructure.

A valley in bloom



Final touches: Gardeners tend to chrysanthemum plants, locally known as *Gul-e-Dawood*, on the banks of the Dal Lake in Srinagar on Thursday. The garden, which is expected to boost autumn tourism, is scheduled to open to visitors on Friday. IMRAN NISSAR

CJP leaders seek time to appear before Delhi Police

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

A day after being released from judicial custody, Cockroach Janta Party leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka failed to appear before the Delhi Police Crime Branch for questioning on Thursday and sought additional time, police sources said. The police may issue fresh notices to both leaders.

Meanwhile, counsel for All India Students Association leader Neha Bora argued before the High Court there was nothing wrong with seeking a regime change in a democracy.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 4

Modi and Tusk discuss trade ties, India's plan to ease impact of Ukraine war

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India and Poland have no "conflicts of interest", said Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk, who hailed his Indian counterpart Narendra Modi as a "beacon of hope" in a time of "political uncertainty and instability" after talks here on Thursday.

Mr. Tusk, who is visiting as Prime Minister for the first time since 2010, discussed expanding India-Poland cooperation in a number of fields including space, transportation, renewable energy and technology, and also spoke about India's "four-point proposal" to help mitigate the effects of the Russia-Ukraine conflict.

While the two sides did not sign any agreement, India and Poland targeted doubling trade between them from a low figure of $6 billion, which is expected to rise after the India-European Union Free Trade Agreement is signed in December. "We are confident that companies from both countries will work together to develop trusted supply chains for the world and achieve our shared goal of doubling bilateral trade by 2030," said Mr. Modi.

The Prime Minister added he was pleased that a large business delegation had accompanied Mr. Tusk, to engage with Indian businesses in Delhi and Bengaluru on collaborations in areas such as rail transport, clean coal, and mining, where Poland has developed its technology.

Mr. Modi congratulated Poland for entering the group of nations with trillion-dollar GDPs.

Mr. Tusk expressed his support for India's candidature for the United Nations Security Council's non-permanent seat for 2028-29 and for a permanent seat in a reformed UNSC, and hoped for Indian support for Poland's ambitions to join the G-20. U.S. President Donald Trump has invited Mr. Tusk to the G-20 this year in Florida, where Poland is expected to submit its request.



Steadfast partnership: Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Polish PM Donald Tusk in New Delhi on Thursday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Four-point proposal

India has not publicly shared details of a four-point proposal that the Modi government is discussing with counterparts in Moscow and Kyiv, with a view to forge an agreement between Russia and Ukraine that would stop attacks on civilians, allow grain and energy exports from both countries through the Black Sea, and end the targeting of ships and seafarers, including many Indians who have been casualties in the four-and-a-half year war.

Highly placed officials denied that India is "mediating" in the conflict, but said it is in close contact with both sides over the specific proposal.

India and Poland also announced a "Defence Industry" dialogue for cooperation in security, technology and hardware. However, no specific defence deals will be signed between the countries until they sign an Agreement on Mutual Protection and Exchange of Classified Information, which is still under negotiation, and could not be completed in time for the visit, officials said.

The deal will specifically seek to allay Poland's concerns about technology leaks to Russia given the India-Russia defence partnership, and India's sensitivities on the Poland's defence relationship with Pakistan.

PM SPEAKS TO NETANYAHU » PAGE 6

INBRIEF



Kochi student 28th winner of Charles Correa Gold Medal

Radhakrishnan M.S. of the Seed - APJ Abdul Kalam School of Environmental Design in Kochi architecture has won the 28th Charles Correa Gold Medal in architecture. The award recognises outstanding undergraduate architectural thesis projects that engage meaningfully with the challenges of built environment. The award ceremony was held at Tarq gallery in Mumbai on Thursday. 'The State of Architecture - Practices and Processes in India, A Research Framework', a book on inquiry into the practice of architecture in the subcontinent, was also released at the event.

2 die of electrocution during Durga idol immersion in M.P.

Two persons died and as many as six others suffered electric shocks, when a live wire fell on their tractor-trolley carrying a Durga idol for immersion in Madhya Pradesh's Jabalpur district shortly after midnight on Thursday, police said. The incident occurred at 12.04 a.m. in Majhauli police station area, about 30 km from the district headquarters, where more than 50 people were taking the idol in a procession from Civil Line Path for immersion in Narili pond. Vikas Rajput (22) and Prince Chauhan (23), who were sitting on the tractor, died on the spot. PTI

SP chief meets Azam Khan in Rampur jail, vows to defeat BJP

Akhilesh accuses ruling party of filing false cases against the senior SP leader, says no political family has faced as much injustice as Azam's

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday visited Azam Khan in Rampur district jail and accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government of filing false cases against the senior party leader. He said no political family has faced as much injustice as that of Mr. Khan.

"I came to meet Azam *saheb*. False cases have been filed against him and the family. No family, particularly no political family, has faced as much injustice as this one. The BJP is responsible for such injustice... when the truth comes out, they will have to face the consequences of their actions," he told reporters outside the jail.

The SP chief added corrupt officials and false cases are two key weapons of the BJP government. "Whenever the history of BJP injustice is written,



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav coming out of Rampur jail after meeting Azam Khan on Thursday. PTI

Rampur's name will always appear at the top. The conspiracy to close [Mohammad Ali] Jauhar University is actually a plot to snatch the right to education from the PDA (Pichhda, Dalit, Alpsankhyak)," he said, vowing to overthrow the BJP government in Uttar Pradesh with public support.

Key figure

Mr. Yadav's visit holds significance as despite being in prolonged judicial custody, Mr. Khan, a 10-term former MLA from Rampur, is a key figure for the party in the region. Recently, the Rampur Development Authority (RDA) had issued demolition order for 38 of the 40 buildings at Jauhar university, run by Mr. Khan, over illegal construction. Amid an uproar, the proposed demolition was halted by higher authorities and the matter is pending in the Divisional Commissioner's court.

"The visit reiterated the importance of Azam Khan in the Samajwadi Party hierarchy. It is a reply to those leaders who are trying to reduce his stature and has exposed the BJP's design to keep him in jail on fabricated charges because of his religious identity and political clout," said senior SP leader Sudhir Panwar.

Reacting to the visit, BJP's Uttar Pradesh incharge Vinod Tawde said the SP's "dream" of making Azam Khan the State's Home Minister will never be fulfilled.

Coimbatore student ends life, family alleges harassment over caste and eating habits

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

A Class 11 student in Coimbatore, who belongs to a Scheduled Caste community, ended his life on Wednesday after he was allegedly harassed by a few classmates and a teacher over his caste and eating habits.

A. Kowsalyadevi, the mother of the student, A. Akilan, alleged that the teacher, Vijayakumar, had made five students who consume beef, including her son, stand up in the classroom two months ago. The Peelamedu police booked two students, Vijayakumar, and the school principal, Arunkumar, on Wednesday for abetment to suicide and other offences. The police questioned Vijayakumar on Thursday.

The police said Akilan, 16, had left home at 8 a.m. on Wednesday, informing his mother that he was going to school. The woman, who works as a domestic help at Bharathi Colony, returned home around 1 p.m. to have lunch, and found the front door unlocked. When she checked the house, she found her son



Demanding action: Relatives of the deceased student at the Peelamedu police station in Coimbatore late on Wednesday.

dead. The police sent the body for a post-mortem.

Ms. Kowsalyadevi said Vijayakumar had enquired about students belonging to the Scheduled Castes in the classroom to enlist them for a scholarship. Akilan had enrolled himself for the benefit. The teacher had also asked the students how many of them consumed beef, in response to which Akilan and four others had stood up. Ms. Kowsalyadevi said two of her son's classmates had been harassing and assaulting him over his caste since then. Though Akilan had reported the harassment to Vijayakumar, he did not take action, she said. She alleged that Arunkumar, too, had failed to take action when her son complained to him.

The police registered a case against two students, the teacher, and the principal for offences under Sections 115(2) and 108 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and Section 3(2)(v) of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

Report sought

The District Educational Officer for Secondary Education conducted an inquiry at the school on Thursday.

The Tamil Nadu State Commission for the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes asked the Coimbatore City Police Commissioner to submit a report within a week.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

Sule demands ₹1 lakh per hectare relief for drought-hit

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar) leader Supriya Sule on Thursday demanded ₹1 lakh per hectare of financial assistance for drought-hit farmers in Maharashtra, and urged the State government to release pending aid under its schemes.

The Baramati MP said farmers were facing serious difficulties due to drought and rising inflation.

Show-cause notice issued to SP after AK-47 firing video goes viral

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

The Chhattisgarh Police issued a show-cause notice to Rajnandgaon Superintendent of Police (SP) Ankita Sharma on Thursday after a video surfaced showing her firing an AK-47 rifle into the air during a *Shastra Puja* ritual.

The incident, filmed during Dussehra at the Rajnandgaon Police Lines, drew widespread criticism on social media, including from a former senior Army officer.

"Dangerously incorrect handling of a loaded weapon - All aspects of safety of weapon handling violated - Pointing a loaded weapon in all directions. Ppl (people) in background are visibly terrified - Firing a service weapon for an unauthorised act in a non-authorised dress - Basic weapon handling drill taught in the...academies not adhered to - Such irresponsible action can cause death or hurt to self or others...," wrote KJS Dhillion, an Army veteran, on X.

Ajay Yadav, Inspector General of Police for the Rajnandgaon Range, confirmed the issuance of the notice. He said the police headquarters found the negative public reaction damaging to the force's dignity and requested clarification regarding the disregard for safety protocols.

"After receiving the SP's reply, I will record my observations and forward the matter to the police headquarters. Further action will be taken in accordance with the directions received from there," Mr. Yadav said.

Ms. Sharma was unavailable for comment.

Bihar Council polls today; Patna Graduates' seat in focus as JD(U) faces internal tussle

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Ahead of Friday's biennial elections to eight seats of the Bihar Legislative Council, State JD(U) president Umesh Kushwaha and party MLC Sanjay Kumar Singh on Thursday met Patna Graduates' seat candidate Neeraj Kumar for a closed-door meeting.

The seat, from which Mr. Kumar is seeking a fourth consecutive term, has become the centre of attention after JD(U)'s Mokama MLA Anant Singh declared support for Jan Suraaj Party (JSP) candidate Anuj Kumar Singh.



JD(U) MLA Anant Singh



JD(U) MLC Neeraj Kumar

Mr. Anant claimed that Mr. Kumar had opposed him in every Assembly election held in Mokama.

Polling for the four Graduates and four Teachers constituencies will be held from 8 a.m. to 4 p.m. Counting is scheduled for October 27. The terms of the sitting MLCs are set to expire on November 16.

The ruling allies BJP and JD(U) are contesting four seats each while the JSP is contesting all eight.

Bid to placate

The JD(U) twice tried to broker peace between Mr. Anant and Mr. Kumar. It had tasked Munger MP and Union Panchayati Raj Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh to mediate. Mr. Lalan later said Mr. Anant had "reservations and grudges which the party should have addressed earlier".

An ironclad resolve in the national interest



Eknath Shinde
Deputy Chief Minister of Maharashtra

Home Minister Amit Shah's decision-making ability, commitment to national security, and role as one of the architects of modern India's development will ensure that his name occupies a prominent place in the country's political history

Some forces that cannot bear to see India's rapid march towards becoming a developed nation have become increasingly active in the country. Their intention is to poison the national atmosphere and create instability. As a result, the internal security challenges confronting India have become increasingly complex. Just as violent protests erupted in Nepal and Bangladesh, certain anti-national elements have begun speaking of triggering similar agitations in India. With the support of some foreign powers, Opposition parties are talking about a 'regime change'. Attempts are being made to undermine democracy and threaten the Constitution authored under the stewardship of Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar. Efforts are also under way to fuel extremism in the country. Drug trafficking is on the rise. Misinformation spread through social media and attempts to create social discord pose a serious threat to India's social harmony.

However, no such instability will be allowed to take root in India, nor will the sinister designs of foreign powers be permitted to succeed. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, our country's formidable Home Minister Amit Shah is ensuring that this does not happen. The era when security agencies would scramble to respond only after an incident had occurred is long past. We are now in an era defined by Mr. Shah's firm, farsighted, swift, direct, and comprehensive decision-making. That is why the citizens of India need not fear any such attempts at destabilisation. Whatever may be happening elsewhere in the world, India remains a nation governed by the Constitution of Dr. Ambedkar. No one will succeed in pushing the country into anarchy. Mr. Shah celebrated his birthday on Thursday. While extending my birthday wishes to him, I pray to the Almighty to grant him the strength to maintain India's internal security at the highest level and effectively counter anti-national elements.

Historic decisions

When comparing India before 2014 with India after 2014, one cannot look merely at the change of political power. One must also consider the country's development aspirations, its approach to national security, the pace of infrastructure creation, India's position on the global stage, and its willingness to resolve long-pending issues. Mr. Modi's leadership gave a new direction to the aspirations of the nation while Mr. Shah strengthened this journey through his organisational capabilities, political planning, and support for key decisions.

As Union Home Minister, Mr. Shah has taken several historic decisions. On August 5, 2019, he announced in Parliament the decision to revoke Article 370, which had granted special status to Jammu and Kashmir. This decision became a milestone in safeguarding the country's unity and integrity. Subsequently, development across Kashmir gained momentum, and the region became more closely integrated with the national mainstream. He also took extremely firm measures to curb Naxalite activities within the country. Ending Naxalism is not merely about defeating armed extremist groups. It is equally important to provide roads, education, health care, employment, and administrative facilities to regions that have remained deprived of development for generations. Only by working simultaneously on the fronts of security and development can the foundations of peace be strengthened. The ultimate success of this campaign will be measured by whether citizens in areas emerging from the shadow of violence can live with dignity. The determination with which Mr. Shah has confronted Naxalism and terrorism has established him as an iron man of our times.

He has also brought several insurgent groups in the north-eastern region into the national mainstream. He has helped Parliament enact new laws, including the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, replacing several outdated colonial-era laws and giving India's criminal justice system a modern framework. Strict action has also been taken, through the armed forces and intelligence agencies, against elements that threaten India's sovereignty. Mr. Shah's leadership is particularly evident in his firm opposition to foreign interference in India's internal affairs. He takes decisive action without yielding to pressure when it comes to safeguarding the country's security and interests.

Zero tolerance towards drugs

He has consistently maintained that India's youth must not be exploited through protests for political gains or anti-national causes. Although the right to protest is an essential feature of democracy, he has repeatedly made it clear that damage to public property and the use of violence will not be tolerated. Mr. Shah has adopted a policy of zero tolerance towards drugs, which inflict enormous damage on the country's younger generation. Under his guidance, Central investigative agencies and State police forces have coordinated their efforts to dismantle major drug-trafficking networks. Strict measures have been taken to dismantle international syndicates and prevent smuggling through border regions.

Under Mr. Shah's leadership, the Ministry of Home Affairs has become a strong pillar of India's internal security. His guiding principle of 'Nation First' is clearly reflected in every decision he takes. In 2021, he had the distinction of becoming the first Minister of Cooperation after the government established a separate Ministry of Cooperation. He has worked to curb irregularities in the cooperative sector and dismantle the monopolistic control by several families. Most importantly, he has given the cooperative movement a modern, technology-driven identity and strengthened its ability to meet the challenges of competition. This has reinforced the agricultural economy.

Role of chief strategist

Mr. Shah is a man of firm resolve who stands by his word. He has been the architect of many victories of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and is a trusted guide and supporter of mine. In today's India, only a handful of leaders are judged not by the number of years they have lived, but by the heights of achievement they have attained. Mr. Shah is one of those prominent leaders. He has played the role of chief strategist in securing unprecedented success for the BJP. His political influence began at the level of a booth worker and reached the office of the country's Home Minister. This journey bears testimony to his hard work, precise organisational skills, and strategic decision-making. At the age of 16, he became a volunteer of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh. The values instilled by the organisation are reflected in his political decisions and approach to public life.

I have met Mr. Shah many times over the past six to seven years. I have had hundreds of opportunities to discuss issues with him. These interactions have given me firsthand experience of his ability to make precise and timely political decisions. Whenever I meet him as a friend and mentor, I see his compassionate side. Yet, when confronted with a difficult test, his uncompromising firmness becomes equally evident. I have personally witnessed Mr. Shah's affection for Maharashtra, his deep interest in the State's history and, in particular, his admiration and pride for the valour of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. Our mutual trust, similarities in political thinking, and shared objective of ensuring that the Mahayuti government remains strong and stable have meant that he has always stood firmly by my side.

It is precisely these qualities that have earned him the reputation of being the Chanakya of the BJP. To truly understand his Chanakya-like qualities, one must examine the principles of Chanakya Niti. There are five major aspects: education, confidentiality, management, avoiding arguments with foolish or ignorant people, and dedication to duty.

Mr. Shah's decision-making ability, commitment to national security, administrative competence and role as one of the architects of modern India's development will ensure that his name occupies a prominent place in the country's political history. My heartfelt wish is that Mr. Shah continues his tireless service to the nation with the same determination and dedication for many years to come.

Published by Nirmala Lakshman at Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. Editor: Suresh Nambath Chandrasekar (Responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act).

ISSN 0971 - 751X

Labourer 'beaten' to death over water bottle

Rajulapudi Srinivas
VIJAYAWADA

Four persons allegedly beat a labourer, M. Sai Kumar, 35, to death in Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh, after he allegedly took a water bottle from a fridge outside a roadside pan shop around midnight on Monday. The incident, however, came to light on Wednesday. The victim was a native of Nalgonda district in Telangana.

According to the Patamata police, Sai Kumar came to Vijayawada a few days ago. On Monday night, he took a water bottle from a fridge outside a locked pan shop on Patamata Donka Road.

One of the accused, Ravi Shankar, allegedly beat Sai Kumar severely after seeing him take the bottle. Later, a worker in a nearby liquor shop and two others allegedly tied the victim to a pole and beat him with sticks. Local residents who noticed the body on the roadside on Tuesday morning alerted the police, said Patamata Circle Inspector (CI) V. Pavan Kishore.

"Post-mortem examination revealed that the victim succumbed to injuries. The accused also shot videos on their mobile phones while beating Sai Kumar. The incident was also recorded on the CCTV in the vicinity. The police collected the clippings," Mr. Pavan Kishore told *The Hindu* on Thursday. The accused were taken into custody and investigation is on, the CI said.

HC likely to hear Pinarayi's plea in CMRL case tomorrow

Development comes after SC stays probe into FIR against the Opposition leader; Pinarayi's counsel informs ED that he will not appear for questioning on Friday; ED likely to oppose his appeal

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI


Leader of Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan informed ED officials that he will not appear for questioning in view of the Supreme Court's stay.

The Kerala High Court is likely to hear on Saturday a plea by Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan challenging a Single Judge order that had directed the registration of an FIR against him, his daughter, T. Veena, and his son-in-law, P.A. Mohamed Riyas, in the CMRL-Exalogic pay off case.

This comes after the Supreme Court on Wednesday stayed a Kerala Police investigation into an FIR registered against Mr. Vijayan and his family members in the ₹2.78-crore pay off case.

The Single Judge Bench of the High Court had directed the State police to register the FIR against the three under the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988. They approached the Supreme Court after a Division Bench of the High Court denied them leave (permission) to appeal against the order.

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) is likely to oppose the appeal to be filed by Mr. Vijayan before the Division Bench. A meeting of senior agency officials here discussed the steps to be taken following the Supreme Court directive.

Meanwhile, Mr. Vijayan will not appear before the ED in Kochi for questioning in connection with the case on Friday. The Central agency had issued him a summons last week, asking him to appear at its zonal office around 11 a.m for interrogation.

The ED had earlier registered two Enforcement Case Information Reports (ECIRs) under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) against Mr. Vijayan and his two family members.

Counsel for Mr. Vijayan informed ED officials that he would not appear for questioning in view of the Supreme Court's stay. Mr. Vijayan also cited the apex court's order permitting him and the other two petitioners to file an appeal before the High Court's Division Bench against the single Bench order on October 9.

SC specifies freeze period on FIR against Pinarayi as 10 days in published order

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In an update from its oral pronouncement, the Supreme Court has directed the investigation into the First Information Reports (FIRs) against former Kerala Chief Minister and current Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena and son-in-law and former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas in the CMRL-Exalogic payoff case to be extended to 10 days.

Oral pronouncement

The oral pronouncement in open court on Wednesday had specifically dictated the time of stay as a week or seven days. However, the subsequent published order mentions the period of the stay as 10 days.

"We direct that the investigation in the impugned FIRs shall remain stayed for a period of ten days from today, which, however, shall not be treated as a conclusive opinion expressed on interim relief, and the Division Bench [of the Kerala High Court] shall be entitled to fashion independently such relief in accordance with law," the order read.

Allowing Mr. Vijayan and his co-petitioners in the Supreme Court to pursue their appeal against a Single Judge Bench, directing the registration of FIRs under the Prevention of Corruption Act, the apex court noted that its observations were limited to the "locus of the appellants to prefer the appeal, and not an expression of opinion on merits".


Congress leaders Harish Rawat, Pritam Singh and others during 'Nyay Yatra' in Dehradun on Thursday. PTI

Congress begins 'Nyay Yatra' ahead of Uttarakhand election

Press Trust of India
DEHRADUN

The Congress in Uttarakhand on Thursday began its "Nyay Yatra" to highlight the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government's "anti-people policies" and the "pressing issues facing the State", with only months to go before the Assembly election.

Congress leaders criticised Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami and his government over education, jobs, the Ankita Bhandari case, among others during marches held at several places.

State Congress president Ganesh Godiyal said, "While the BJP claims to be the greatest champion of the Sanatana Dharma, the offerings made by devotees at the world-renowned Badrinath Dham and the Ram temple are not even safe under its government, a situation both deeply unfortunate and shameful."

He added that the state of basic amenities such as education, healthcare, roads, drinking water and employment remains deeply concerning in the State. "The dilapidated condition of government schools and hospitals in the hill regions serves as a stark testament to the failure of the BJP government," said Mr. Godiyal.

In Almora, Leader of the Opposition Yashpal Arya said the 2027 Assembly election would be a battle to safeguard Uttarakhand's self-respect, the future of its youth, the safety of its women, and the overall development of the State.

Congress election campaign committee chairperson Pritam Singh, who led the yatra in Rajpur and Mussoorie Assembly constituencies, said, the rise in crimes against women under the BJP government has brought shame to the entire State. "The demand for justice in the Ankita Bhandari murder case remains a central rallying cry for the people of Uttarakhand. The BJP government that talks about '*Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao*', has proven to be a complete failure in providing a safe environment for women and girls," he said.

T.N. Police probe minor's sexual assault at Keralam spa

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The investigation into the alleged sexual exploitation and trafficking of a 16-year-old girl at a spa in Keralam's Kovalam has widened into a multi-State criminal probe.

A team from the Tamil Nadu Police has arrived in Thiruvananthapuram on account of the registration of a Zero First Information Report (FIR) by the Kerala Police.

According to the survivor's statement, she was taken from Andhra Pradesh to Bengaluru and then to Chennai before being brought to Keralam. In view of the disclosure, the Kerala Police registered an initial case at the Kovalam police station, followed by a second one that was subsequently transferred to Tamil Nadu, leading to the Vandalur All-Women police station commencing its probe.

Official sources point out that the Tamil Nadu Police officials are also seeking permission from the Child Welfare Committee (CWC) to take the minor girl to Tamil Nadu for further investigation, including a site inspection at a spa where she was allegedly sexually abused in Chennai.

Meanwhile, the investigation team continued to gather more evidence against M.O. Anuroop, a health inspector of the Thiruvananthapuram Corporation, who has been arrested in connection with the case.

INBRIEF



Karnataka CM seeks nod for Sharavati, Mekedatu projects

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Thursday urged the Centre to expedite clearances for the Sharavati Pumped Storage and Mekedatu drinking water projects. He also sought a deferment of the final notification designating 56,825.7 sq. km of the Western Ghats as an Ecologically Sensitive Area (ESA) until a physical survey is completed. At a meeting with Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav in New Delhi, Mr. Shivakumar sought the approval of the Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife (NBWL) for both projects.

5-year-old injured by police baton at Dasara procession

A five-year-old girl, who was watching the Vijayadashami procession in Mysuru, Karnataka on Wednesday, suffered a head injury from a police baton. The girl was watching the procession near Highway Circle when the incident took place. She was rushed to a nearby hospital. As the procession passed Highway Circle, police asked people standing to view the tableaux to sit down. When people continued to stand, police struck the barricade with a *lathi*. The *lathi's* tip reportedly hit the girl's ear before striking her on the head, a police statement said.

A.P. Police intervene to stop clash at nomination centre

Two groups reportedly clashed in front of District Collector Sumit Kumar and SP Tushar Dudi at the MPTC and ZPTC nomination centre at SR Puram in Gangadhara Nellore Assembly constituency in Chittoor district of Andhra Pradesh on Thursday, prompting the police to resort to a lathi-charge. The incident occurred when the officials were reviewing security arrangements. As the two groups refused to back down, the SP himself swung into action with a lathi, directing the police to disperse the gathering.

Aerial sowing


Helping hand: A drone equipped with a specialised seed-dispersal system sows paddy seeds at the Pullazhi kole fields in Thrissur, Keralam, on Thursday. It can cover an acre in just seven minutes at a cost of ₹900, saving farmers considerable time and labour. K.K. NAJEEB

Temple body rejects report on Thrissur Pooram disruption

The Hindu Bureau
THRISSUR

The Thiruvambady Devaswom has rejected the Crime Branch report on the alleged disruption of Thrissur Pooram in Keralam in April 2024, accusing investigators of attempting to shift blame onto the Devaswom while concealing the facts.

Devaswom secretary K. Girish Kumar said the Devaswom would never conspire to disrupt the festival or undermine the grandeur of its 237-year-old tradition. He alleged that serious lapses had occurred on the part of the police during the festival.

The Devaswom was willing to correct any lapses on its part if investigators identified them, he said, but maintained that holding all its representatives responsible for the disruption was unjustified.

Mr. Girish Kumar said the Devaswom would meet the Chief Minister, Home Minister, and Devaswom Minister to establish the 'actual facts.'

His response comes after the Crime Branch reportedly submitted the investigation report to the government, seeking permission to prosecute eight office-bearers of the Thiruvambady Devaswom. The report is understood to invoke charges of conspiracy and incitement to riot.

Karnataka SIR: over 76,000 applications for inclusion rejected

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

A total of 76,176 Form 6 applications seeking inclusion in the final electoral rolls have been rejected by the Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer (CEO)'s office on various grounds, including submission of duplicate applications and applicants not being available during verification, besides other reasons.

Between June 16, when the electoral rolls were frozen, and September 23, the last date to file claims and objections, a total of 7,87,534 Form 6 applications were received. Of these, 7,08,110 have been accepted and 76,176 rejected. These net additions will be reflected in the final electoral rolls, scheduled to be published on October 27. However, the number of additions remains far lower than the more than 80.62 lakh names deleted after being categorised as shifted or absent.

Moreover, the status of at least 3,248 Form 6 applications remains unclear, as the accepted and rejected applications together account for only 7,84,286 forms. The CEO's office said the gap comprises applications filed in the wrong Assembly constituency or with incorrect details.

Karnataka's revamped Golden Chariot train seeks to showcase State's diversity

Rashmi Patil
BENGALURU

The Golden Chariot operating under the Pride of Karnataka itinerary has been revamped for the 2026-27 season. The rooms, food, and beverage options have all been upgraded. For the first time, the trip has been completely booked, with a full house of 75 guests embarking on the first trip on Saturday. Apart from guests from across the country, many guests are also from Spain, a senior Karnataka State Tourism Development Corporation (KSTDC) official said.

"The full booking for the first journey is an encouraging start. Our priority now is to sustain this demand across the season. This year, we have planned 13 luxury journeys throughout the season," said V. Ram Prasath Manohar, Secretary, Tourism Department.



The Golden Chariot train was relaunched by the incumbent government in 2024. K. MURALI KUMAR

The train, launched in 2008 and discontinued in 2018, was relaunched by the incumbent government in 2024. The 2024 and 2025 seasons saw slim demand.

The first trip under the Pride of Karnataka itinerary will start on Saturday from Krantivira Sangolli Rayanna (KSR) Railway Station and will head to Mysuru. Guests will travel to Bandipur Wildlife Sanctuary, Mysuru Palace, Halebeedu, Chikkamagalur, Hampi, Goa, and finally back to Bengaluru on day six.

Rooms for guests have been redesigned. They now comprise a living room and a bedroom.

"Our objective is to offer world-class hospitality while showcasing the diversity of Karnataka through a carefully curated journey and position the Golden Chariot strongly in domestic and international premium tourism markets," said Karnataka Tourism Minister K.J. George.

Govt. going back on assurances made to Ladakh: Wangchuk

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI


Sonam Wangchuk

Activist Sonam Wangchuk on Thursday criticised the Ministry of Home Affairs for going back on its earlier assurances on granting political autonomy and constitutional safeguards for the Union Territory of Ladakh.

Mr. Wangchuk said that the Centre never denied Statehood to Ladakh in previous talks. "They [Centre] said they would give it eventually," he claimed at a press conference in Delhi.

Ladakh Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra had earlier this month said that it was categorically conveyed to the Leh Apex Body (LAB) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) that "neither Statehood nor U.T. with legislature is on the agenda".

"On the one hand, China is claiming Ladakh, and on the other hand our government is alienating the Ladakhis. We demanded protection under Article 371 of Constitution, which was agreed to in a meeting on May 22. Now they are offering us a council-type body. We will not settle down for anything less than a U.T. with legislature," Mr. Wangchuk said.

He said the Ministry, for its own reasons, was compromising national security in sensitive border areas.

Mr. Wangchuk said that after the last meeting on October 15 in Leh, the LAB and KDA were told that the next meeting will take place on Thursday in Delhi. "But the meeting did not happen," he said.

India steps up efforts for safe return of pilgrims stranded in Saudi Arabia

Indian missions in Riyadh and Jeddah are working with airlines and tour operators to facilitate the early return of Umrah pilgrims affected by the disruption caused by Houthi attacks; over 3,000 pilgrims have come back home in the past week

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI


Pilgrims stranded in Saudi Arabia after a Houthi attack reunite with family members upon their arrival in Ahmedabad. ANI

Amid escalating attacks by Houthi (Ansar Allah) forces on Saudi Arabia, Indian missions in Riyadh and Jeddah are working with stakeholders to facilitate the early return of thousands of stranded Indian pilgrims, the External Affairs Ministry said on Thursday.

"Our embassy in Riyadh and the Consulate in Jeddah are actively engaging with concerned airlines and tour operators to facilitate the early return of affected pilgrims. Over the past week, about 3,000 stranded Umrah pilgrims have travelled from Saudi Arabia back to India on available flights," said Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal.

International flight connections to Saudi Arabia have been disrupted following Houthi attacks on several major airports in the country, including the capital, Riyadh, and Dammam. Besides Indians, many pilgrims from other countries are also stranded in Saudi Arabia.

"Arrangements are being discussed to facilitate the return of other Umrah pilgrims at the earliest," said Mr. Jaiswal.

The Ministry strongly condemned the continued attacks on civilian and energy infrastructure in Saudi Arabia, including the attack on King Fahd International Airport in Dammam and Saudi Aramco's Shaybah oil field in the Eastern Province on October 21.

"We also reiterate that the attacks on civilian and critical infrastructure are completely unacceptable and must cease immediately. We stand in solidarity with the people and the Government of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia in safeguarding its sovereignty, and hope that peace and normalcy would return to the region at the earliest," it said in a statement.

MP seeks intervention

Earlier, AIMIM chief and Lok Sabha MP Asaduddin Owaisi took to social media to flag the plight of around 4,000 Indian pilgrims who had flown to Saudi Arabia for pilgrimage but were stranded because Indian carriers like IndiGo, Air India and Akasa Air had cancelled their flights due to the Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabian airports.

Mr. Owaisi called for "urgent intervention" from the Government of India and said, "The DGCA must give these airlines permission to run flights with large aircraft so that these stranded pilgrims can return to India. If not, at least specified flights must be arranged to bring them back." Earlier on Thursday, the spokesperson of the Houthi forces said that a large boat carrying 14 Indians came under attack near the Red Sea close to the Bab al-Mandeb.

Indian officials have not confirmed any assistance reaching the struck boat so far while the Indian Embassy in Yemen has said, "...Will provide all possible help for ensuring the safety and well-being of the Indian nationals."

The Ministry has put out the following numbers of the 24x7 Control Rooms – Embassy of India, Riyadh: Phone: +966-554412016; +966-542126784; Toll-free: 8002471234 (Calls from within Saudi Arabia only), WhatsApp (messages only): +966-536216082; Consulate General of India, Jeddah: Phone: +966-12-2614093; +966-556122301 WhatsApp (messages only): +966-536209704.

Six killed as bus crashes into tree in Chhattisgarh

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

Six persons, four of them women, were killed and 40 injured after a bus crashed into a tree in Manendragarh-Chirmiri-Bharatpur district of Chhattisgarh on Thursday, the police said.

Superintendent of Police Ratna Singh said the accident took place near the Semarmathani turn when the bus, carrying 46 people, was *en route* to Kelhari village from Manendragarh.

Prima facie, the driver appeared to have lost control of the vehicle, Ms. Singh said, citing the account of an injured passengers. "Around 20, including the driver, sustained serious injuries. Twenty other passengers sustained minor wounds," she said.

Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai expressed grief and announced financial assistance of ₹5 lakh each to the next of kin of the deceased and ₹50,000 to each injured person.

CJP leaders seek additional time to appear before police for questioning

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI


Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka are under probe for trespassing into Jantar Mantar after it was denotified as a protest site. PTI

A day after being released from judicial custody, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka failed to appear before the Delhi Police Crime Branch for questioning on Thursday and sought additional time to join the investigation, police sources said.

The investigation pertains to allegations of trespassing into Jantar Mantar after it was denotified as a protest site, obstructing police personnel on duty, disobedience of a government order among others.

The Crime Branch issued notices to the duo on Wednesday, following their release from seven days of judicial custody, directing them to appear for questioning on Thursday.

Meanwhile, counsel for All India Students Association (AISA) leader Neha Boraargued before the Delhi High Court that there was nothing wrong with seeking a regime change in a democracy. The court was hearing a plea against a notice asking her to furnish a bond before a special executive magistrate for maintaining peace.

Preventive detention

The AISA president was taken into preventive detention on October 16 on her way to join the CJP's '*Lehra Do Tiranga*' march. She was released on October 17. After hearing arguments from lawyers representing the AISA leader and the Delhi Police, Justice Subramonium Prasad said the Delhi High Court would pronounce its decision on Friday.

Additional Solicitor-General (ASG) Chetan Sharma, appearing for the Delhi Police, questioned the maintainability of the student leader's petition and referred to certain material, including a joint press conference at which a statement on regime change was made. Responding to the submission, senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for the student leader, said: "There is nothing wrong in regime change in a democracy."

Objecting to the argument, the ASG said "a regime change in a democracy will happen by votes, not by lumpen elements congregating" in New Delhi. Mr. Sankaranarayanan, though, argued that the special executive magistrate (SEM) had issued the notice to the activist without applying independent judgment.

Referring to the police's allegation that AISA leader had hoisted the national flag without permission, he maintained that citizens were not required to seek official approval to do so.

In Instagram debut, Sonia Gandhi shares first glimpse of her memoir

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


Pages of resilience: Sonia Gandhi's memoir traces personal loss, family tragedies and moments in her political life. PTI

Congress Parliamentary Party Chairperson Sonia Gandhi made her Instagram debut on Thursday by sharing a video of her upcoming memoir, *Belonging: A Journey of Love*, which she described as a "story of love, duty, loss and finding a place to belong".

The former Congress president has largely stayed away from social media, using the party's official X handle to release video statements, letters and other messages.

In the first post on her Instagram account, Ms. Gandhi shared a video of herself receiving copies of the book and sharing sweets with Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and remarked that the book contained several photographs. "Hello everyone, I'm truly grateful to share this moment with you all; the first look of *Belonging: A Journey of Love*. It is a story of love, duty, loss and finding a place to belong. I look forward to sharing it with you," she said in her post.

Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh, sharing the video, said the "long-awaited memoir" of Ms. Gandhi would be released on November 10.

Publishing controversy

Last month, HarperCollins India announced that it would publish the memoir, ending uncertainty over its domestic release after an impasse between Ms. Gandhi's representatives and Penguin Random House India (PRHI).

The disagreement had triggered a controversy, with some Congress leaders alleging that pressure had been exerted on the publisher to remove references to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh and China's alleged occupation of Indian territory.

PRHI denied any external pressure and declined to disclose details, citing confidentiality obligations.

The memoir begins with Ms. Gandhi's childhood in post-war Veneto, Italy, and recounts her move to Cambridge, where she met Rajiv Gandhi in 1965. It traces her marriage to him, her introduction to her mother-in-law, former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, and her efforts to adapt to life in India.

The book also recounts the tragedies that marked the family, including Sanjay Gandhi's death in a plane crash, Indira Gandhi's assassination in 1984 and Rajiv Gandhi's assassination in 1991. The book covers the Congress-led alliance's victory in the 2004 general election, Ms. Gandhi's decision not to become Prime Minister, and her leadership of the party and the ruling coalition during the subsequent decade.

Uttarakhand orders Sunday as weekly off for madrasas

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Uttarakhand government on Wednesday issued a circular for timings and weekly-off for schools across the State including recognised madrasas which will observe Sunday as their weekly holiday instead of Friday.

Authorities from the Uttarakhand Minority Welfare department said that the decision came following the integration of the religious institutions into the State's education system, bringing them under the rules applicable to other recognised schools.

"The decision was taken after discussions with the madrasa authorities. Because the registered madrasas have been reclassified as schools, hence the institutions required to follow the guidelines issued by the education department and the authority," an official from the department said.

Revised data show sharp rise in Form 6 disposal rate in Delhi

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

A total of 1.07 lakh Form 6 applications seeking inclusion in Delhi's electoral roll have been disposed of, according to an updated weekly disposal report uploaded on the website of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) on Thursday. The latest data replaced the weekly disposal report on the website that was there till Wednesday, with officials saying the data being uploaded earlier was wrong and not reflecting the disposals recorded since August 31, when the claims and objections phase began.

The CEO's office releases a constituency-wise report every week, recording how many applications under each form - Form 6 for inclusion of new voters, Form 7 for deletions, Form 6A for overseas electors and Form 8 for corrections or address changes - have been disposed of since the claims and objections phase under the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls began.

This comes after *The Hindu* reported that only 0.27%, or 1,238 of the over 4.5 lakh Form 6 applications seeking inclusion in Delhi's electoral roll had been disposed of between August 31 and October 11.

The revised figures cover each of the seven weeks between August 31 and October 18. Officials said the data displayed publicly earlier was wrong.

According to the updated report, 1,07,451 (23%) of the 4,59,796 Form 6 applications and 47,105 (70%) of the 67,709 Form 7 applications have been disposed of.

"The weekly data being uploaded till now was wrong and it was not reflecting the disposals that happened since August 31, we noticed after the newspaper report," an official told *The Hindu*.

Pandal announcer held over Durga Puja stampede

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA


Under the scanner: A forensic team carries out an inspection of the site of the stampede in Kolkata on Thursday. ANI

The Kolkata Police on Thursday arrested another person in relation to the Durga Puja stampede in the city that killed 19 people. Previously, the police had detained 14 people for interrogation on October 18 and arrested seven of them.

"The alleged announcer in Chorebagan Puja pandal – Sanjeev Raha alias Sentu (treasurer) – has been picked up from Nadia by Detective Department, Kolkata Police," said a police statement. Later, Kolkata Police said that the announcer was arrested after questioning.

After the tragic incident, there were allegations that wrong announcements of a possible pandal collapse had triggered panic among the crowd and that people started rushing in multiple directions, which may be one of the causes behind the stampede.

Police had already arrested the secretary and vice-president of the Chorebagan Durga Puja committee along with five other people, including two security in-charges, one person engaged in the pandal construction, and two persons involved in crowd management. They were all sent to 10 days of police custody on October 18.

A six-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) was formed on October 21 to probe the stampede. The SIT will be headed by former judge Justice (retired) Anindita Roy Saraswati.

On the other hand, Mamata All India Trinamool Congress MLA Kunal Ghosh said that every member of the "new Durga Puja committee" should be under custody before the SIT begins investigation.

"Otherwise, no matter how diligently the retired judge tries to investigate, at every step the police and the government will try to protect and safeguard the influential people behind this. Real culprits get saved and some poor police persons will be scapegoated," he said.

BJP worker killed in West Bengal's Malda; one person detained

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

A Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) worker was shot dead in West Bengal's Malda district on Wednesday night. Clashes also broke during Durga Puja immersion processions in Arambagh and Nalhati, prompting police action.

Samir Ghosh, 38, was allegedly shot dead outside his home.

The police have detained one suspect and launched a search for others, alleging that he was attacked by a group of miscreants. The reason for the murder and the details of the incident are being investigated. The Malda Police visited the spot on Wednesday night.

Political link

Ghosh's brother, Vivek Ghosh, alleged that the BJP worker was murdered by Trinamool Congress workers. However, local Trinamool leadership has denied these allegations.

"He was alone in the house when this happened, 10-12 people attacked and killed him," Vivek Ghosh said.

English Bazaar MLA Amlan Bhaduri also blamed Trinamool for the attack and said that he has asked for immediate action against those involved in the crime. Meanwhile, local Trinamool leader Biswajit Ghosh said that the clashes were due to personal family feud and had no political relations.

The reason for the murder and the details of the incident are being investigated.

Meanwhile, clashes broke out between two groups in Arambagh in Hooghly district during *Bijaya Dashami* celebrations.

A similar incident was reported in Birbhum district's Nalhati, where objections to firecrackers during a *Bijaya Dashami* procession triggered tensions.

Cong. will not come to power in next 30 years, Shah warns Rahul

Home Minister says the Congress is trying to save infiltrators' votes; he says that to win elections, one should go among the people to understand their sufferings and nothing is achieved through protests; Congress says vote theft is a 'proven reality'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Launching a scathing attack on the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, over his allegations of vote theft, Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday claimed that the Congress would not form a government in the Centre in the next 30 years. Hitting back, the Congress said the BJP was responding in desperation, adding that vote theft was a "proven reality".

"Rahul*ji*, the entire country understands you and your friends, by creating a hue and cry over vote *chori* (theft), you want to save the votes of infiltrators," Mr. Shah said at an event in Delhi.

Mr. Shah said that when the Congress and its allies lose elections, they sometimes make excuses about electronic voting machines (EVMs), and sometimes about alleged vote theft.


Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurates various projects related to water resources in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

'Negative politics'

"When I say that the BJP government will remain for 30 years, they tell the people that 'vote *chori* is happening, otherwise how would Amit Shah know this'. Amit Shah was born here, lives here, and remains among the people of the country, and does not have to go abroad every six months. The kind of negative politics you are doing, based on this, I can say that for the next 30 years, your government will not come to power," he said.

"When you [Rahul Gandhi] land in Delhi, remember my words: your number is not going to come in the next 30 years," Mr. Shah added.

The Home Minister said that the Opposition could not negate the country's mandate through such political tactics and mobocracy. If one wants to win elections, he said, one should go among the people to understand their sufferings and pains; nothing is achieved through dharnas and protests.

"Wherever you have been elected, bring schemes and do work to remove the people's sorrows, pains, sufferings, and disorder; otherwise, even the remaining existence will come to an end," Mr. Shah said.

Mr. Shah said that a different game was currently being played in Delhi because BJP governments were continuously being elected in States across the country. "This is troubling the opponents, which is why they are making the excuse of vote *chori*," he said.

'Double standards'

He noted that the recent Kerala Assembly election was held with the same voter list, Election Commission, and EVMs; after winning the election, the Opposition took the oath.

"When the opposition won in Telangana, the Election Commission was also good and the voter list was good too. When they won in Himachal, the Election Commission and voter list were good then as well... These double standards will not work, Rahul*ji*. People have now understood you," he said.

Reacting to the allegations, Congress MP Jairam Ramesh claimed in a post on X that "vote *chori* is a proven reality".

"According to the ECI's own data, over 10 crore Indians face the risk of losing their Constitutional right to vote. The ECI illegally altered Form 6 to create barriers for new voters. It has facilitated the widespread abuse of Form 7 for targeted deletions. The CEC has used the ECINET to centralise control of the electoral roll, overriding all legal safeguards," he said.

The nation was "outraged", Mr. Ramesh said, adding that widespread anger was fuelling continued protests despite repression. "The PM's ecosystem, in its desperation and nervousness, is now trying to divert and distract, doing what is in its very DNA – spread lies. It will not succeed. The PM-HM duo has been brutally exposed and the people will hold them accountable," he said.

Punjab drug trade

The Home Minister also attacked the Aam Aadmi Party. Given the flourishing of the drug trade in Punjab under the AAP government, the people of the State had now decided to vote the BJP-led NDA to power there, he said.

Cabinet Secretariat copied acknowledgement sent to letters by two ECs to CEC

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Days after two Election Commissioners (ECs) S.S. Sandhu and Vivek Joshi wrote to Cabinet Secretary T.V. Somanathan on July 29 regarding the working of Senior Deputy Election Commissioner Maneesh Garg, the secretariat sent an acknowledgment to both with a copy to Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar for his "information", a Right to Information (RTI) response has revealed.

The Cabinet Secretariat noted that the letters were from the ECs in their individual capacity and while needed to be taken with seriousness, cannot be taken as formal communication from the Election Commission of India (ECI) as a whole. In the absence of any official communication from the Commission any action can be construed as "interference".

The RTI plea was filed by Commodore Lokesh Batra (retd).

Work allocation

A Cabinet Secretariat file noting dated August 3, says


Gyanesh Kumar

that both the ECs had stated that Mr. Garg, after assuming charge as link officer of DEC (Administration), issued an order regarding work allocation of officers equivalent and senior to him without discussing the revised work allocation with the Commission or the officers concerned. Further, the ECs stated that this happened despite repeated oral and written instructions to all officers against taking such actions without prior discussion/approval of the Commission. "In this connection, we may request the Chief Election Commissioner for his opinion on the issue," it said.

However, the very next day, that is August 4, the file notes that "the Commission is a constitutional body and is insulated from executive interference by design to ensure that it functions independently and in a transparent manner".

It further says the ECs have sent these communications for appropriate action. However, "in the absence of any official communication from the Commission as a whole, any action at this stage may be inappropriate. It may also be construed as interference in the functioning of the constitutional body".

And hence, it will be appropriate to send acknowledgement to both ECs with a copy to PPS (Principal Private Secretary) to the CEC for "information of CEC".

A copy was also marked to be sent to the Secretary, Department of Personnel and Training since Mr. Garg was an All-India Service officer.

It was though not clear from the RTI responses whether Mr. Gyanesh Kumar had in any manner responded to or acknowledged the information received from the Cabinet Secretariat.

CEC must be prosecuted, farmers write to President

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of a farmers' rally here on Friday, demanding the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, the Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM) has written to President Droupadi Murmu that Mr. Kumar has violated his constitutional pledge and must be prosecuted. The memorandum to the President, which also demands scrapping of the SIR of the electoral rolls, will be submitted to all district and sub-divisional magistrates. Various trade unions and civil society organisations have pledged support to the farmers' march.

The memorandum also demanded restoration of voting rights for all citizens whose names were deleted "without transparency". They have urged the President to ensure an amendment to the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act of 2023 and include the Chief Justice of India on the selection panel instead of the Cabinet Minister nominated by the Prime Minister. "The farmers also demand comprehensive electoral reforms to introduce proportional representation, curb money/muscle power, and legalise state funding of elections," it added.

"Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself is protecting the CEC who committed the gross crime of deleting genuine citizens from the electoral roll to help the ruling party (the BJP) sustain power," the memorandum said. It also demanded immediate revocation of the order of the Delhi Police de-notifying Jantar Mantar as a designated site for peaceful protest.

Centre of Indian Trade Unions general secretary Elamaram Kareem said the disenfranchised workers may also be deprived of social security benefits and other government welfare schemes.

Congress alleges censorship after Priyanka's son told to remove photos

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

A day after Bikaner House, a Rajasthan government-owned property in Delhi, asked visual artist and photographer Raihan Vadra to remove around 70 of 105 photographs documenting recent protests and youth movements in India from his exhibition, the Congress on Thursday raised concerns over alleged censorship and denying freedom of expression under the BJP-led government. Mr. Vadra is the son of Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra.

Senior Congress leader and former Rajasthan Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot criticised the BJP government in the State, saying that suppressing the voices of artists amounted to an attack on democracy.

"The truth that comes before the public is what frightens the BJP the most. A government that is rattled by a photo exhibition wants to conceal the unjustified actions taken during these movements," the Congress leader said.

The Bikaner House management issued a statement describing the


A security guard removes photos printed on paper at Bikaner House in Delhi on Thursday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

venue as a public cultural institution dedicated to promoting art and culture. The activities must comply with the Bikaner House Management Society's policy, it stated.

Titled "No Idea Is Final", the exhibition featured wildlife photography, abstract art, and photographs documenting recent youth movements in India. It was scheduled to open on Thursday.

Written explanation

Speaking to the media, Mr. Vadra said the Bikaner House management had first raised objections to some of the photographs a day before the scheduled opening, citing concerns that they could violate its policy. He said he was willing to discuss the objections but sought a written explanation from the authorities.

He alleged that the Deputy Resident Commissioner of Bikaner House subsequently asked him to remove 70 of the 105 photographs on display, citing the venue's policy. Mr. Vadra said he had already set aside images carrying explicit political slogans after reviewing the policy, but the authorities sought further changes after inspecting the exhibition again and subsequently sent him an email asking for additional photographs to be taken down.

He alleged that the requests eventually extended to two photographs of the Tricolour. "I have refused. I will not take down a picture of the Indian flag," he told the media.

Mr. Gehlot criticised the BJP government in Rajasthan. "This is a clear example of censorship. The BJP government must answer why photographs depicting the truth were removed," he said.

Ms. Vadra also took to X to condemn the move. "When someone with power becomes afraid of the expression of another, he doesn't know it, but he has already lost the very power he is trying to protect," she wrote, adding that she was proud of her son.

Congress MP and party media and publicity department chairperson Pawan Khera questioned the "offence" in clicking photos of protest.

"When even the Tricolour isn't safe from the censor's scissors, perhaps the problem isn't the art. It's the regime," Mr. Khera wrote on X.

Rahul Gandhi has treacherous foreign links, alleges BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Thursday reiterated its accusation that Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi was attempting to create anarchy in India and weaken constitutional institutions in collusion with foreign organisations.

At a press conference here, BJP spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia cited a Fox News Digital report titled 'Global Chaos Inc' and alleged that attempts to bring about regime change in France and several other countries through unrest were linked to protests in India. He said the report identified 101 organisations across many countries, described the network as part of a "red-green ecosystem", and named two organisations: Progressive International and Indian Alliance Paris.

Mr. Bhatia sought explanations from former Congress president Sonia Gandhi and Mr. Gandhi regarding their meeting with a Progressive International delegation on April 28,


Gaurav Bhatia

BJP spokesperson cited a foreign media report, alleging it brought to light the treacherous links

2025, in Delhi.

Mr. Bhatia alleged that Mr. Gandhi was "presenting a model of anarchy, disorder, and treachery".

"A report published in a reputed newspaper today has brought to light the treacherous links to foreign agencies," he added.

The BJP leader also criticised Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut over a recent social media post concerning unrest in Albania.

ECI to hold Rajya Sabha bypoll in M.P. on Nov. 12

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Thursday announced that byelection to the Rajya Sabha seat from Madhya Pradesh, which was vacated by former Union Minister L. Murugan, would be held on November 12.

Mr. Murugan, who was Minister of State for Parliamentary Affairs and Information and Broadcasting, had quit the Union Council of Ministers and the Rajya Sabha on October 14. His term was due to end on April 2, 2030. Following his resignation, Mr. Murugan had said that he wants to focus on strengthening the BJP in Tamil Nadu.

As per procedure, Counting will be held on the day of polling itself. The last date of filing nominations would be November 2 and the last date for withdrawal of candidature would be November 5. The entire election process would be completed by November 16.

With the BJP ruling Madhya Pradesh, its candidate will have a smooth sailing in the bypoll.

Thirukkural to take centre stage at Kashi Tamil Sangamam

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The fifth edition of the Kashi Tamil Sangamam, to be held from November 28 to December 12, will be built around the theme of the classical Tamil text, *Thirukkural*, Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi said on Thursday.

Launching the registration portal for the event, Mr. Joshi said it would celebrate, reaffirm, and strengthen age-old civilizational bonds between Tamil Nadu and Kashi, two ancient seats of learning, according to an Education Ministry statement. This is in line with the spirit of unity exemplified in the government's slogan, *Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat* (One India, Great India).

Adopting the theme, '*Thirukkural Payilvom – Thirukkural Abhyas Karen*' (Let's learn *Thirukkural*), the event seeks to bring the ethical and moral wisdom of the Sangam-era *Thirukkural* to modern youth and learners, the statement said. "Through educational engagement, multilingual resources and wider public outreach, the programme seeks to encourage reading, understanding and application of universal values as enshrined in the text, in everyday life," it added.

As part of the programme, around 1,400 participants from Tamil Nadu, organised into seven groups of 200 each, will undertake an eight-day journey comprising four days of travel and four days of visits and structured programmes. The itinerary will include Varanasi, Prayagraj, and Ayodhya, featuring cultural, academic, domain-specific, and spiritual engagements, the Ministry said.

"The emphasis on youth participation will enable a new generation to engage meaningfully with India's classical knowledge traditions and carry their values into contemporary academic, professional and social life," it added.



Union Minister Pralhad Joshi during the launch of the registration portal for Kashi Tamil Sangamam on Thursday. ANI

Interested applicants may register through the official portal at https://kashitamil.iitm.ac.in/ hosted by the Indian Institute of Technology-Madras from Thursday till November 13.

Applications will be accepted under seven categories: students, teachers, writers and media professionals, agriculture and allied sectors, professionals and artisans, women, and spiritual leaders.

A nationwide students' engagement programme will be undertaken through 1,000 higher education institutions across the country to promote a wider understanding of the *Thirukkural* among students from diverse academic disciplines and linguistic backgrounds, the Ministry said. The initiative will include structured study, research, and campus-based activities for wider dissemination of the teachings and values of the *Thirukkural*. More details are available at www.kts.cict.in.

Thirukkural experts from Tamil Nadu will visit various schools and colleges in Varanasi and introduce the students to the core values of the text through orientation modules, interactive sessions, and quizzes. The National Book Trust, in association with the Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya, will conduct interactive sessions in schools in Varanasi on reading habits, storytelling and creative activities.

The Kashi Tamil Sangamam will also leverage technology to make the teachings of the *Thirukkural* accessible to a wider audience across India.

Speaking at the portal launch, Mr. Joshi said that since ancient times, the country has had strong cultural unity. He noted that many people visited Kashi and Rameswaram as part of their religious traditions, reflecting the deep-rooted cultural bonds between the northern and southern parts of India, the statement said.

INBRIEF



Review, repeal outdated laws, Vice-President urges States

Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan on Thursday urged States to review and repeal outdated laws to improve governance and ease of living, stressing that legal reforms must keep pace with changing times. Mr. Radhakrishnan was speaking during the inauguration of a conference on "Cooperative Federalism and Law Reforms: National and State Perspectives", organised by the Law Commission of India. "The ultimate purpose of law is to ensure a just, secure and dignified life for every citizen," he said. Emphasising the need for greater coordination between the Centre and States, the Vice-President said that political differences should not come in the way of public interest.

Firecracker ban breaches draw Bombay High Court ire

The Bombay High Court on Wednesday directed the Commissioner of Police and the corporation to brief officers regarding October 15 court order that imposed ban on firecrackers. The court was reacting to breaches during Durga *visarjan*. The corporation and the Maharashtra Pollution Control Board have yet to issue notices. The court observed that police machinery has failed to control violations. Station officers in Mumbai lacked awareness, and the Bench noted a lack of enforcement on decibel limits for music systems. The court warned that dereliction of duty by the police affects rights guaranteed under Article 14 and Article 21 of the Constitution.

Gold bars, cocaine seized at Mumbai airport; six arrested

The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has arrested six people, including an airport staff member and a Zambian woman, in two separate operations at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport (CSMIA). Officers seized 2.317 kg of 24-carat foreign-origin gold bars, valued at approximately ₹3.47 crore, and arrested all five involved under the provisions of the Customs Act, 1962. In a separate operation, DRI officers intercepted a Zambian woman on October 20. During examination, she expelled 11 capsules containing 190 gm of cocaine valued at approximately ₹1 crore in the illicit market.

Delhi conference to explore new markets for Indian rice

Trade and business representatives from over 150 countries will attend the Bharat International Rice Conference (BIRC) beginning in Delhi on Friday. Organised by the Indian Rice Exporters Federation (IREF), the three-day conference brings together exporters, importers, millers, policymakers and food businesses to explore new markets, assess the 2027 price outlook and identify ways to earn more from rice. After the recent war on Iran, one of the major buyers of Indian rice, and the crisis in West Asia, the IREF had been urging the Union government to help the exporters find new markets and assistance in clearing cargos stuck in Strait of Hormuz.

Actor firing case: four sent to police custody till October 26

They were arrested by the Delhi Police Special Cell on October 20; the police submitted that the accused were involved in procuring and supplying the weapon used in the attack in Mumbai

Yohaan Varghese
MUMBAI

A metropolitan magistrate court in Mumbai on Thursday remanded four accused, including two women, arrested in connection with the October 18 firing at Bollywood actor Tiger Shroff's car in Juhu, in police custody till October 26. The Mumbai Crime Branch police had sought their custody till October 31 to investigate their alleged role in procuring and supplying the firearm used in the attack.

The four accused are Kunal Singh, 21, from Rohana village in Haryana's Sonipat district; Sumit Sorolia, 19, from Kharkhoda in Sonipat; Radha Verma, 23, from Sitapur in Uttar Pradesh; and Babita Rao, 23, from Azamgarh in Uttar Pradesh. They were arrested by the Delhi Police Special Cell on October 20 and subsequently brought to Mumbai on transit remand.

During the hearing, the prosecution alleged that the four were part of a conspiracy to supply weapons to the alleged shooters. According to the police, Kunal and Sumit were allegedly involved in procuring the firearm, while Radha and Babita allegedly helped supply it to the assailants.



Radha and Babita being taken for production before a court in Mumbai on Thursday. PTI

'No conspiracy'

Seeking extended custody, the prosecution submitted that the case involved serious offences, including attempt to murder, and that the investigation was at an initial stage. The prosecutor argued that custodial interrogation, including questioning the accused together, was necessary to establish the wider conspiracy. The weapon used in the attack is yet to be recovered.

Opposing the application, defence advocate Sachin Patil questioned the evidence linking the accused to the alleged weapon supply chain, arguing that investigators had not even established the make or type of pistol used in the firing. "They are not being able to identify the make of this pistol! Whether it was Indian-made, whether it was foreign-made... Nothing of that sort has been identified," Mr. Patil submitted.

He further argued that the investigators had not produced concrete material to justify the arrests.

"Before effecting the arrest of a person, there has to be some concrete material on record. There is not even a statement of a co-accused," Mr. Patil argued, questioning the grounds for implicating the two women. The defence also questioned the absence of any reference to payment or financial consideration for the alleged weapon supply in the remand application.

Mr. Patil argued that the accused had already been questioned during their three-day transit remand and that their physical custody was unnecessary for examining call detail records and other electronic evidence.

Advocate Ajinkya Mirgal, representing Radha and Babita, submitted that his clients were not present at the scene of the firing and that there was nothing further to recover from them.

"There is no motive behind it, so no conspiracy," Mr. Mirgal argued, urging the court to send the accused directly to judicial custody.

Speaking to reporters after the hearing, the defence lawyers said the investigators had already seized mobile phones and wanted to examine them for evidence of the alleged communication trail. They maintained that forensic examination of the devices did not require continued police custody.

After hearing both sides, the magistrate granted police custody of all accused till October 26.



President Droupadi Murmu during the 'Seva Samman Parv' and 'Yuva Prabodhan' event in Raipur, Chhattisgarh. PTI

Chhattisgarh youth breaking free from Maoism: President

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday expressed delight over Chhattisgarh's youth joining the national mainstream after breaking free from Maoism.

Addressing the 'Seva Samman Parva' and 'Yuva Prabodhan' event organised on the occasion of Nuakhai festival at Sardar Balbeer Singh Juneja Indoor Stadium in Raipur, she described Maoism that had gripped the State for decades as a misguided path.

"It is a matter of joy that, through the efforts of Central and State governments and their own willpower, Chhattisgarh's youth are freeing themselves from the misguided path of Maoism and joining the mainstream," she said.

Addressing the youth, Ms. Murmu said she was confident that if young people embraced humility along with knowledge, ethics with ambition, and a spirit of service with success, the resolve to build a developed India would become stronger.

"When we link our individual efforts to collective and national goals, the path to the country's progress is paved," she said.

Urging the youth to dream big, broaden their vision and uphold high standards of conduct, she asked them to nurture a spirit of service towards society, the nation and fellow citizens. "Whatever work you undertake in life, do it with honesty, dedication and sensitivity. Nation-building is not achieved through big decisions alone, but through the small, honest efforts of millions of citizens," she said.

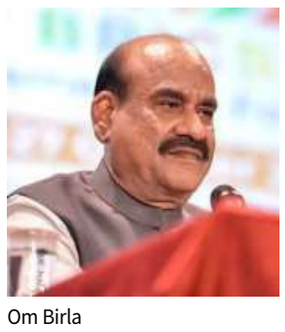
BRICS Parliamentary Forum to meet in Delhi: Om Birla

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A two-day conference of the 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum will be held in New Delhi on October 26 and 27, with discussions centred on "Fostering parliaments for people-centric development", Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla said at a press conference on Thursday.

"The two-day conference will include both bilateral and multilateral discussions. Presiding officers, members of Parliament and other dignitaries from BRICS and partner countries will brainstorm on strategic priorities for Parliaments," he said.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will also attend the event, though no separate invitations were extended to Opposition leaders of the two Houses. India had received confirmation from most participating countries, though Saudi Arabia and Ethiopia expressed their inability to participate.



Om Birla

The deliberations will cover "institutional resilience, ethical artificial intelligence, digital transformation, reform of global governance and sustainable development".

Meanwhile, the Speaker avoided all questions regarding the delay in proroguing the Monsoon Session of Parliament and speculation about a special sitting to deliberate on delimitation legislation.

"Article 85 of the Constitution clearly says that the Speaker has no role in calling or proroguing a session. If I had a role, then I would have given a judgment," he said.

Trinamool case

Regarding the disqualification of 20 MPs who broke away from the original Trinamool Congress (TMC) in West Bnegal, Mr. Birla said he would expedite the process once the lawmakers submitted their responses. "Just like the Supreme Court is hearing the case, my court is also hearing the case, I cannot pass the judgment here," the Speaker said.

Modi and Netanyahu discuss West Asia, bilateral relations

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Prime Minister of Israel Benjamin Netanyahu discussed India-Israel relations and the situation in West Asia over a phone call on Thursday.

"The two leaders welcomed the sustained momentum in India-Israel relations and reaffirmed their shared commitment to further strengthening the Special Strategic Partnership between the two countries. The leaders also exchanged views on recent developments in West Asia and underscored the urgent need to restore peace and stability in the region," Mr. Modi's office said in a statement.

During the call, Mr. Modi reiterated India's call for dialogue and diplomacy.

Meanwhile, Mr. Netanyahu, said that he has invited Mr. Modi to light a torch, along with Indian pilot Smit Machhar who has been praised for his bravery during the incident involving a flydubai aircraft.

"I spoke with my friend, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and invited him to light a torch together with the heroic Indian pilot on the Independence Day of the State of Israel. Modi thanked me for the invitation and said that on the ground and in the air, India and Israel fight terrorism together. He expressed his appreciation for the courageous and long-standing relationship between us," Mr. Netanyahu said in a post on X.

CPI(M) MP seeks probe into alleged SBI data leak

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

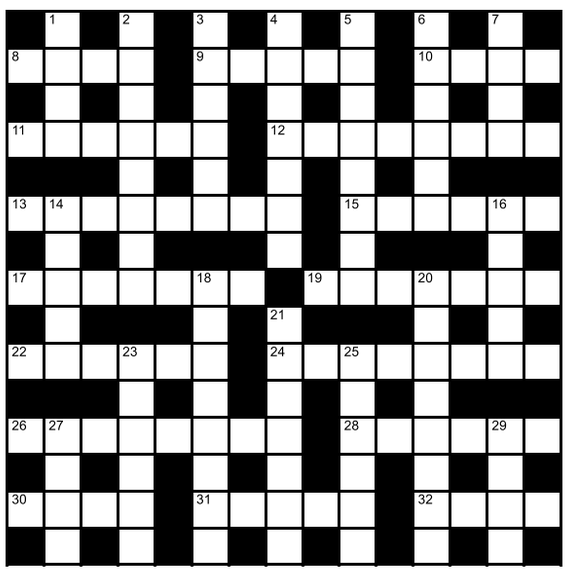
Expressing concern about the reported leak of personal information belonging to State Bank of India (SBI) customers, CPI(M) MP A.A. Rahim in a letter to Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, urged to conduct a thorough investigation to establish the extent of the breach and identify those responsible. Mr. Rahim said that the reported exposure of sensitive customer information, including mobile numbers, email addresses, branch details and loan records, is particularly alarming. The incident, Mr. Rahim said, also raises questions on the implementation of the data protection laws in the country.

TH CROSSWORD + 14930

(set by Incognito)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

8 Husband with a large ring; a ring of light (4)
9 Examine boss with lady at last (5)
10 Some offering for Ireland (4)
11 Inventor is done? Is in trouble? (6)
12 Dreamt aiding me wrongly (8)
13 Wrongly typed a key need for unaided vision (5,3)
15 Maximum sum tot may produce (6)
17 Well liked tree planted around university (7)
19 Retain mother and stay silent (4,3)
22 Single thin length of thread is maroon (6)
24 Lebanon organisation shelters male aristocrat (8)
26 Damaged CD containing incorrect visa at state team event in men's tennis (5,3)
28 Girl in Salem building shines (6)
30 Curved structure in Munnar church (4)
31 Letter found in home garage (5)
32 Place for temporary stay in penitentiary (4)

Down

1 Part of body found in Khandwa (4)
2 Excitedly arouse US author (8)
3 Time for payment of bill from American church? Around 1st of November... (6)
4 Planet having pit at centre (7)
5 City says cure is arranged (8)
6 Average clairvoyant (6)
7 Man's relative by marriage? (4)
14 Pertaining to a part of a boxing match (5)
16 Method of diving from small island (5)
18 Loveless doctor goes around university following sailor and kidnapper (8)
20 Stops serpent coiling around top of vine (8)
21 Fish photographer (7)
23 Get off! It's burning... (6)
25 Prohibit carrying breakfast food for mendicant (6)
27 Changing sari... showing attitude (4)
29 Repair front of mower at last (4)

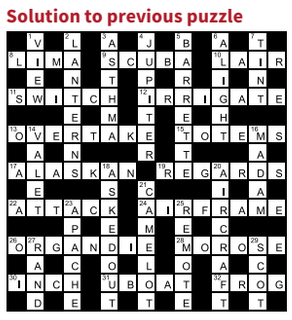
SUDOKU

1		6			3		4	
7	4	8	6					
3	5					6		
	1		8				3	6
				2				
8	3				4		5	
		4					8	2
					8	5	6	3
	8		9			1		4

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★☆

No.SS7039 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

2	5	3	8	4	7	6	9	1
6	4	1	5	2	9	7	3	8
7	9	8	6	3	1	4	2	5
5	8	4	9	7	6	3	1	2
3	6	9	1	8	2	5	7	4
1	2	7	4	5	3	8	6	9
8	7	2	3	1	4	9	5	6
4	3	6	2	9	5	1	8	7
9	1	5	7	6	8	2	4	3

FAITH

Rama's rationale

Kings were duty-bound to punish erring subjects, said Navalpakkam Vasudevachariar in a discourse. A sinner who is punished must not be angry with the king, because once he has faced punishment on this earth, he will not go to Yama Loka. If he escapes the clutches of the law, then he will pay for his sins in Yama Loka, and the punishments there will be far worse than anything he has to face on this earth. There was a country whose king was meticulous in punishing his subjects who were guilty of crimes. But in the neighbouring country, all the subjects were good, so there was no need for the king to punish any of them. When the people who had been punished by the king in the first country died, they went to heaven. So did the good subjects of the neighbouring country. The good people were shocked to find those guilty of criminal conduct also in heaven. How could they have come to heaven, they wondered. The answer was that because they had been punished by their king, they were not in Yama Loka. If a king overlooks the wrongdoings of his subjects, then he gets a share in their sins.

As to Vaali's complaint that Rama should not have killed him from behind, Rama says even when animals are hunted for flesh, it is perfectly all right to take aim from behind. Vaali has made Sugreeva's wife his own, and must be punished for this. Srimad Bhagavatam and Garuda Puranam say that if a man forcefully embraces a woman, he will go to Naraka Loka. There, a likeness of the woman will be made, and the image will be heated. The man will be forced to embrace the heated image. Vaali, by being punished by Rama, has escaped this.

Is a sugar-rich diet while on antibiotics a threat to the gut microbiome?

Recent research suggests that what we eat while taking antibiotics may determine just how badly our gut microbial ecosystem is disturbed; the emerging challenge for medicine is how to kill harmful bacteria while preserving the microbial communities that help keep the human body healthy

Biju Dharmapalan

Antibiotics are among modern medicine's greatest lifesaving discoveries. They have transformed once-dangerous bacterial infections into treatable conditions and remain indispensable in cancer care, surgery, and infectious disease management. But antibiotics come with side effects – the primary being they do not always distinguish between harmful bacteria and the enormous community of beneficial microorganisms living inside our gut.

Recent research suggests that what we eat while taking antibiotics may determine just how badly this microbial ecosystem is disturbed. In particular, sugar-rich foods may worsen antibiotic-induced damage to the gut microbiome.

A study published in *Nature* examined the relationship between diet, antibiotics, and the gut microbiome in patients undergoing allogeneic haematopoietic cell transplantation. The researchers analysed an unusually detailed dataset – 9,419 meals consumed by 173 patients, alongside more than 1,000 stool samples from 158 patients.

Their findings point to an important question. Could the food we eat while taking antibiotics influence how quickly our microbial ecosystem recovers?



Vibrant system: The human intestine is home to trillions of microorganisms, constituting a vital ecology for digestion, metabolism, and immunological control. GETTY IMAGES

The invisible ecosystem inside us

The human intestine is home to trillions of microorganisms.

The gut microbiota, comprising bacteria and other microorganisms, constitutes a vital ecology for digestion, metabolism, and immunological control. A population of 'good bacteria' alone, however, does not determine a healthy microbiome: other factors such as equilibrium, diversity, and the interrelations among myriad microbial species play a major role as well. When this ecological equilibrium is disrupted, it may result in dysbiosis, a condition characterised by reduced microbial diversity and the proliferation of a few other organisms.

Antibiotics are a major cause of such disruption. This is especially evident in patients undergoing intensive medical treatments such as blood or bone-marrow transplantation, where antibiotics may be combined with chemotherapy, radiation, and other interventions that further stress the intestinal ecosystem. The new study reveals that diet can become an important additional factor.

Studying diet and the microbiome is notoriously difficult. People eat different foods every day, and conventional dietary questionnaires often depend on memory. The researchers overcame some of these limitations by studying patients who were hospitalised for haematopoietic cell transplantation.

Because their meals could be recorded repeatedly and stool samples collected over time, the investigators could examine diet and microbiome changes almost day by day.

They recorded thousands of individual meals and classified foods into groups such as grains, vegetables, fruits, meats, milk, oils, and sweets. They then compared dietary intake with changes in the gut microbiome.

One pattern stood out. When broad-spectrum antibiotics were being used, higher consumption of sweets and sugars was associated with a sharper decline in microbial diversity.

The researchers estimated that for every additional 100 grams of sweets consumed following broad-spectrum antibiotic exposure, mean microbial diversity decreased by about 24% compared with samples without previous antibiotic exposure.

A separate analysis based on macronutrients similarly found an additional decrease of about 20.6% for every 100 grams of sugar. In other words, sugar appeared to act less like an independent villain and more like an amplifier of antibiotic-induced disruption.

The most intriguing finding involved *Enterococcus*, particularly *Enterococcus faecium*. Under normal conditions, the gastrointestinal tract harbours a diverse microbial consortium in which many organisms vie for resources and ecological niches. Many of these competitors can be killed or inhibited by antibiotics, allowing only more resistant or adaptable organisms to survive. *Enterococcus* is one such organism. It can become an important cause of antibiotic-resistant bloodstream infections and has been associated with adverse outcomes in patients undergoing haematopoietic cell transplantation. The study showed that higher sweet intake during antibiotic exposure was associated with increased *E. faecium* abundance.

The researchers also tested their hypothesis in mouse models. When mice were fed sucrose along with an antibiotic, the *Enterococci* population increased 16.3-fold on day three and 33.4-fold on day six, compared with antibiotic treatment without additional sucrose. In cultures with only sucrose, enterococcal levels did not increase. This indicates that sugar alone has no effect without antibiotics; the problem arises when antibiotics disturb the gut ecosystem.

The study also showed that this disturbance did not take place due to low fibre intake.

Should we avoid sugar with antibiotics?

Not really. Though the study signals a warning, it does not provide concrete evidence that everyone taking antibiotics will experience the same effect. The human participants in the study were seriously ill patients undergoing intensive cancer treatment, not healthy adults taking a short course of antibiotics for a routine infection.

The researchers themselves point out several limitations. Almost all patients initially received prophylactic antibiotics, while broader-spectrum antibiotics were introduced when clinically indicated. The need for these antibiotics could itself reflect greater illness severity. Dietary information outside hospital-provided food was also incomplete, and treatment-related symptoms could influence what patients chose to eat.

Therefore, the findings should not be interpreted as a reason to discontinue medically necessary antibiotics – or to impose restrictive diets on vulnerable patients without medical supervision. Instead, they open an intriguing area for further research.

Rethinking antibiotic prescriptions

When doctors prescribe an antibiotic, the prescription traditionally focuses on the drug: which antibiotic, what dose, and for how long. Emerging microbiome science suggests we may eventually need to think more broadly. Perhaps an antibiotic prescription could one day include advice on how to protect the microbial ecosystem during treatment.

The new *Nature* study suggests that temporarily reducing foods rich in simple sugars could be one possible strategy. But prospective clinical trials must demonstrate whether this actually improves patient outcomes. The authors explicitly call for such studies.

The larger lesson extends beyond sugar. Our gut is an ecosystem, not merely a digestive tube. Medicines, food, and microbes constantly interact within it. An antibiotic may be prescribed to eliminate an infection, but it inevitably changes the microbial environment in which thousands of other organisms live.

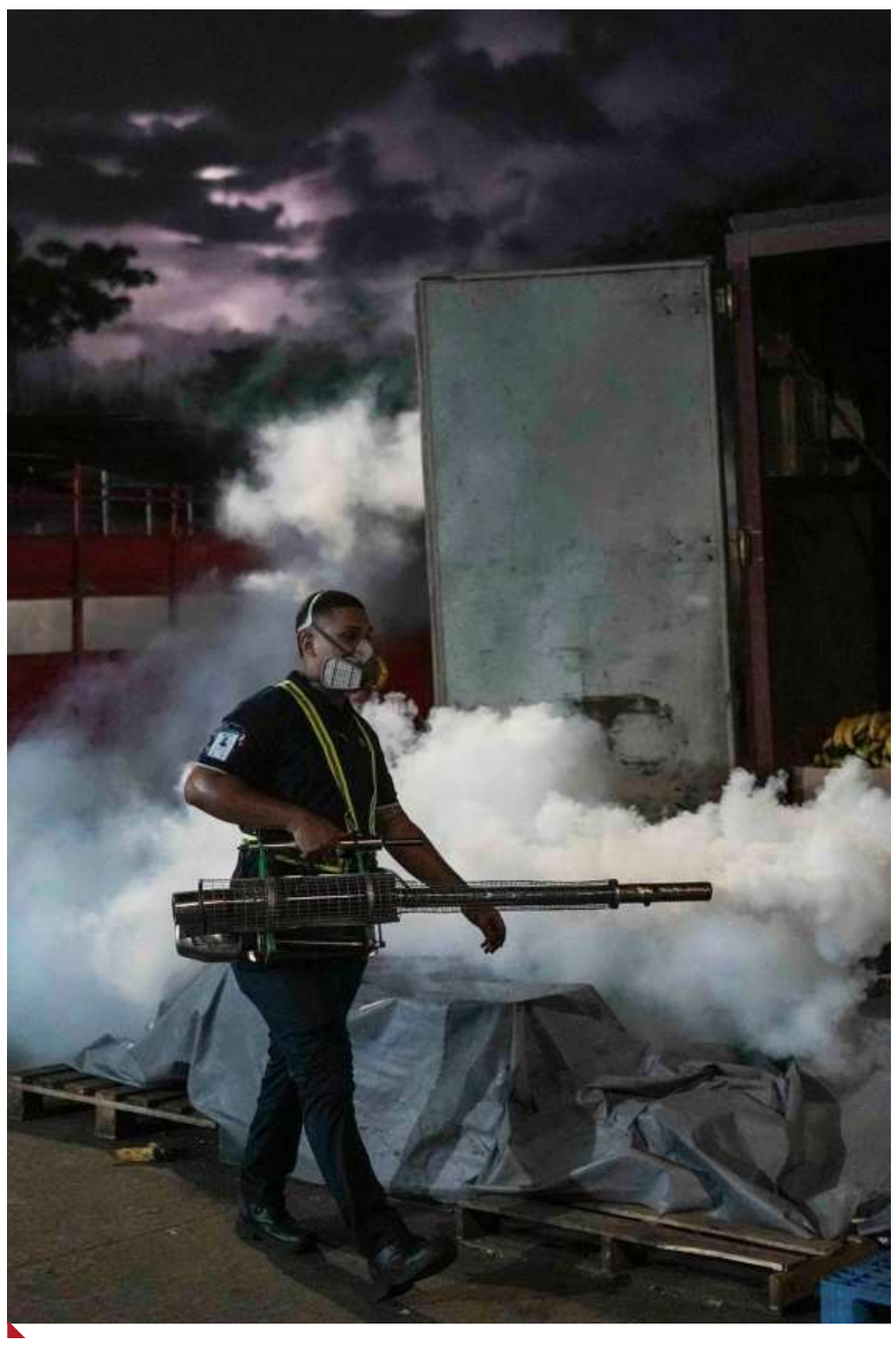
The emerging challenge for medicine is therefore not simply how to kill harmful bacteria**,** but how to do so while preserving the microbial communities that help keep us healthy. And sometimes, the difference may lie not only in the medicine we take – but also in what we put on our plate while taking it.

(Dr.Biju Dharmapalan is an adjunct faculty member at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, IISc campus, Bengaluru, and dean, academic affairs, Garden City University, Bengaluru. bijudharmapalan@gmail.com)

THE GIST

- The human intestine is home to trillions of microorganisms constituting a vital ecology
- Several factors such as equilibrium, diversity, and the interrelations among myriad microbial species play a major role in maintaining a healthy microbial ecosystem
- When this ecological equilibrium is disrupted, it may result in dysbiosis, a condition characterised by reduced microbial diversity and the proliferation of a few other organisms
- Antibiotics are a major cause of such disruption: this is especially evident in patients undergoing intensive medical treatments where antibiotics may be combined with other interventions that further stress the intestinal ecosystem

BIG SHOT



Smoking out: A Panamanian health worker fumigates a market to control mosquitoes and prevent the spread of malaria following reports of several cases in Panama City on October 16. AP

Chemical signatures could help detect diseases early, but accuracy and access remain challenges

Athira Elssa Johnson

Why does one person develop memory problems while another experiences seizures or changes in behaviour? And how do doctors find out whether these symptoms are caused by Alzheimer's disease, an immune disorder, or something else?

Sometimes, the answers may lie in tiny changes in the body's chemistry. Diseases can cause certain proteins and other molecules to appear in different amounts or behave differently. By measuring these changes, doctors can find clues as to what is happening inside the body, even when the cause is not immediately obvious.

These clues, called chemical signatures or biomarkers, are being studied to improve the diagnosis of several diseases, particularly those affecting the brain and nervous system.

The challenge is to establish what these changes mean, how reliably they point to a particular disease, and whether patients can access the tests.

What are chemical signatures?

A chemical signature is a unique pattern of molecules, elements, isotopes, or by-products identified in a sample by analytical instruments such as spectrometers or chromatographs. "Chemical signatures are like the body's fingerprints," says Sreenivas U.M., consultant neurologist, Apollo Speciality Hospitals, Vanagaram, Chennai. When a disease develops, the balance of certain chemicals or proteins may change, providing clues to the problem, he adds.



Chemical signatures or biomarkers, are being studied to improve diagnosis of several diseases, particularly those affecting the brain and nervous system. GETTY IMAGES

In Alzheimer's disease, for instance, doctors and researchers look for changes in proteins called amyloid-beta and tau. Certain forms of these proteins can be measured in blood and cerebrospinal fluid, the liquid surrounding the brain and spinal cord. Tests measuring phosphorylated tau, particularly p-tau217, can help identify changes associated with Alzheimer's disease.

Researchers are also studying alpha-synuclein, a protein associated with Parkinson's disease. In another condition, autoimmune encephalitis, tests that detect antibodies directed against particular brain proteins can help identify an immune response affecting the brain.

This condition can cause seizures, memory problems and changes in behaviour.

Detecting symptoms

Finding these changes also does not always mean an individual has, or is going to have a particular disease. The distinction is important: a test may identify changes associated with Alzheimer's disease, but doctors still need to consider the person's symptoms and overall health before deciding what those results mean.

Chemical signatures can also help distinguish conditions that appear similar. Autoimmune encephalitis, for example, may initially be mistaken for a psychiatric illness because it can cause behavioural changes and problems with memory. Identifying specific antibodies can help doctors recognise the condition and begin appropriate treatment. "In neurosurgery, examining the molecular characteristics of a brain tumour can help doctors classify it and decide on treatment," says Aqib M., senior consultant neurosurgeon, Dr. Mehta's Hospitals, Chennai. Selected molecular tests are already used in specialist practice. Researchers are also studying markers such as neurofilament light, a protein that can indicate damage to nerve cells, he adds. However, not every promising test is ready for routine use. Some markers indicate damage that can occur in several diseases rather than identifying one specific condition.

Testing and diagnosis

A chemical signature cannot always give the full picture. Age, kidney function, medication and other illnesses can affect the levels of certain molecules. Doctors consider the patient's symptoms, medical history and examination findings, along with brain scans and other investigations when necessary.

Cost and availability pose further challenges in India. Specialised tests may not be offered at every hospital, and patients may have to travel to larger centres to access them. Differences in laboratory methods can also affect how consistently results are interpreted.

So, for patients, chemical signatures could mean clearer answers and shorter waits for a diagnosis. But their importance lies not just in detecting changes in the body, but in understanding what those changes mean.

(athira.elssa@thehindu.co.in)

Canary in coal mine

Core sector data indicate impending growth slowdowns

The latest data on the performance of the core industrial sectors show the economy may be facing an industrial uptick, but questions about its sustainability remain. Growth in the Index of Core Industries rose to a series-high of 7.9% in September 2026, the second consecutive month of accelerated performance. Any such improvement is to be celebrated, but a deeper look at what is driving it is also warranted. The coal sector saw growth suddenly shoot up to 10.7% in September. The unexpected and unusual nature of this rapid acceleration can be borne out by the fact that the sector contracted by 1.1% over the longer April-September 2026 period. The growth in coal in September was likely a temporary blip aided by a statistical low base and, more importantly, pressure from power plant operators over rapidly depleting coal stocks amid the heat wave. The electricity sector grew 11.4% in September, capping off a half-year dominated by double-digit growth. This surge in electricity-related demand for coal will likely wane, especially since the El Niño factor that drove the heat wave will also result in a milder winter. The other sector that results in high coal usage, the steel sector, did accelerate in September, but not by enough to sustain the coal sector's September output. The uptick in steel did, however, result in a return to double-digit growth for the iron ore sector, which should bode well for the mining component of the larger Index of Industrial Production.

The performance of the crude oil, natural gas, and refinery products sectors also highlights the fiscal problems India faces. At a time when the crude oil and natural gas sectors have both contracted continuously since 2024, refinery output rose to 10.3% in September. This means that the refineries were increasingly processing expensive imported oil. India's oil imports in September were up 7% by volume but jumped 47% in terms of value due to the high price of oil. This is set to worsen. The attacks on Saudi Arabia's energy infrastructure have already pushed global oil prices above $112 a barrel, almost a six-month high. The reprieve from the U.S. on potential tariffs linked to imports of Russian oil provide India a reliable source, but the days of discounts are long gone. It is the time of premium pricing, and each barrel imported is eating into India's foreign exchange reserves, which are also being used to defend the rupee. Cement and steel are the only sustainably growing core sectors, and those too are based on government infrastructure spending. At a time when industrial output is only temporarily propped up, the government's fiscal space is fast shrinking.

Tunnelling through

Domestic manufacturing and foreign partnerships must go hand-in-hand

The Chinese Ministry of Commerce and the General Administration of Customs decision to place tunnel-boring machines (TBMs) on an export control list reveals a blind spot in India's supply chain diversification. The curbs include TBMs, walking excavators, and high-altitude wet shotcrete machines. From November 18, if a shipment is intended for countries or regions deemed sensitive due to ongoing disputes with China, exporters will need an export licence from commerce authorities. For other countries/regions, exporters will need to be registered, obtain an export certificate, and submit end-use declarations stating that the equipment will not be re-routed to sensitive locations. While China has cornered around 70% of the global TBM market, prominent manufacturers in the West also maintain substantial component supply chains in the country to cut manufacturing overhead. Further, TBMs are complex to build as they have to be configured to geological characteristics at the project site and perform numerous tasks. Where a suitable TBM exists, it can be used for civilian or military purposes. India has struggled with TBM-related hold-ups with China for at least two years now, including for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed rail project. Germany's Herrenknecht AG set up an assembling and refurbishing facility in Chennai in 2007-08. TBM production economics differ significantly from conventional construction equipment as new plants need a minimum number of orders and must be able to access the industrial capability required to design, manufacture and repair specialised components.

However, even though India is one of the world's largest TBM importers, expecting every sophisticated machine to be produced domestically will send public infrastructure costs soaring. Even now, depending on China's decision on the TBMs set for India, India may have to redirect its procurement to facilities based directly in Germany or Japan, say, and absorb the higher capital cost. The BEML experience shows that manufacturing partnerships can fail without secure licensing arrangements and access to sustained demand. India should pursue domestic manufacturing alongside international partnerships, e.g., making equipment in the country under agreement with established foreign firms, and develop shared industrial capabilities rather than singular 'national champions', as TBM manufacturers and their suppliers can benefit from access to common testing and precision manufacturing infrastructure. Overall, Beijing is systematically identifying sectors where it commands a significant global capacity and establishing export controls to counter western technological restrictions, such as on advanced semiconductors, so any critical infrastructure sector relying on Chinese supply lines will face a compounding geopolitical risk.

Prasar Bharati is not a public service broadcaster



Suhas Borker

Editor, Citizens First TV (CFTV), who has advocated public service broadcasting since the 1990s as convener of Jan Prasar. In 2000, he conceptualised National Public Service Broadcasting Day, on November 12

When the Narendra Modi government took office in May 2014, the then Information and Broadcasting Minister, Prakash Javadekar, promised to end the "government fiefdom" over Prasar Bharati and recast it on the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) model: autonomous in administration, free in editorial judgement, and accountable to Parliament.

Twelve years later that promise remains unfulfilled. The 138th episode of "Mann Ki Baat", broadcast on September 27, 2026, is only the most visible reminder that the state still treats the public airwaves as its own platform.

The BBC model, unfulfilled

The irony is sharp. The same political class that invoked the BBC as the template, later accused it of a "continuing colonial mindset" after it telecast the documentary in 2023, "India: The Modi Question". From April 2024 the BBC had to split its Indian news operation to meet foreign-investment rules.

The deeper story is older than the Emergency. In 1948, Jawaharlal Nehru told the Constituent Assembly – then the only authoritative Indian statement on the British model – "my own view of the set-up for broadcasting is that we should approximate, as far as possible, to the British model, the BBC, that is to say, it would be better if we had a semi-autonomous corporation under the government, of course with the policy controlled by the government, otherwise not conducted as a government department." Even that caveat – "otherwise not conducted as a government department" – has not been honoured.

Mark Tully, former BBC bureau chief in Delhi, put the same distinction succinctly in a conversation in 2017: public service broadcasting "is not the same as government broadcast". It rests on two principles, he said – that the government must not interfere in the broadcaster's autonomy, and that programmes must not be judged by commercial merit alone. Without autonomy and freedom, he added, All India Radio cannot become a broadcaster for transformative change.

The Emergency of 1975 reduced All India Radio (AIR) and Doordarshan to instruments of the regime. After Indira Gandhi's defeat, the Janata government asked B.G. Verghese to recommend autonomy. His BBC-style model became a Bill in 1979 (Prasar Bharati Bill), but the Bill lapsed. A new version, introduced in 1989 as "a charter of freedom" under Article 19(1)(a) of the Constitution, received assent in 1990 – as the Prasar Bharati (Broadcasting Corporation of India) Act, 1990 – and was enforced only in 1997. Its Statement of Objects and Reasons said the corporation should be "a genuinely autonomous body – innovative, dynamic and flexible – with a high degree of credibility", responsible to the people and to Parliament. Nearly three decades on, Prasar Bharati is not that body. It is a pretender, a mouthpiece of the government of the day. Section 12 of the Act is the editorial constitution that was meant to lock that intent in. The primary duty is to organise public broadcasting services to inform, educate and entertain. Section 12(2)(b) requires the corporation to safeguard "the citizen's right to be informed freely, truthfully and objectively" and to present "a fair and balanced flow of information including contrasting views without advocating any opinion or ideology of its own".

Prasar Bharati remains a pretender — 12 years after a promise of BBC-style autonomy, the corporation is still on a ministerial leash

At the Ministry's mercy

A truncated corporation was set up so that it cannot function independently of government. Critical Sections 13, 14 and 15 of the Act remain unimplemented. Section 13 requires a 22-member parliamentary committee, elected from both Houses, to oversee Prasar Bharati on Parliament's behalf. No government has constituted it. Former chief executive Jawhar Sircar has explained why: Ministers insist that they alone are answerable to Parliament and therefore retain the power to summon AIR and Doordarshan officials until they succumb.

Sections 14 and 15 require a Broadcasting Council to receive complaints and guard political impartiality. That Council has never been set up, and it follows that there is no system for editorial redress. The Board, meant to be professionally managed, has been filled with pliable bureaucrats. Ownership of assets and staff was never transferred. Without its own fund, the Board remains at the Ministry's mercy. Section 23 still lets the Centre issue binding directions on what may or may not be broadcast.

Section 10 required a recruitment board to keep appointments free of government interference. Nothing happened until July 2020, when Jagadish Upasane, who headed Bharat Prakashan, publisher of Panchajanya and Organiser, was made chairman. Autonomy was compromised the moment it was announced. A 2021 manpower audit used the BBC as the benchmark: almost half of Prasar Bharati's then 25,000-strong workforce sat in engineering, against a little over 10% at the BBC, while content staff were under 20% against about 70%. The numbers described a transmission machine, not a Content-and-News-driven broadcaster.

UNESCO's 2001 definition is exacting. Public broadcasting is neither commercial nor state-controlled; it speaks to every citizen. Prasar Bharati fails that test. In 2000 the government declared November 12 as Public Service Broadcasting Day to mark Gandhiji's only AIR broadcast, made in 1947 to two lakh refugees at Kurukshetra. The day has since become tokenism. In 2022 even that tokenism turned into farce when a Christian hymn sung by school students was sought to be dropped from the commemorative national broadcast.

The social contract is simple. The broadcaster has the right to speak freely, and in return it owes the public accuracy, impartiality, and independence from both the market and the Ministry. Nehru's 1948 formula already drew that line: policy may be set, the daily conduct of broadcasting may not be run as a government department. In 1995, Justice P.B. Sawant, speaking for the Supreme Court in *Secretary, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting vs Cricket Association of Bengal*, went further. Airwaves are public property, he held, and the Centre must establish an independent autonomous public authority to control their use. Public broadcasting is not state broadcasting. That direction has still not been carried out.

There must be political will

What needs to be done is already known. The parliamentary committee must be constituted, the Board rebuilt as a professional body, and assets and staff transferred. The regulatory council named in the Act must be created, funding designed without government strings, and Indian Information Service officers removed from operational control. The 1990 Act must be amended where practice has exposed its traps.

None of this happens without political will. The syndrome is familiar: autonomy is criticised out of power and forgotten in power. In August 2026, the government told the Lok Sabha that it had received no formal complaints from journalists or media bodies about its autonomy in the previous year. The absence of filed grievances is not evidence of independence. The Broadcasting Council named in the Act was never created, so there is nowhere for such a complaint to go.

The Chanda Committee, appointed when Indira Gandhi was Information and Broadcasting Minister, concluded in 1966 that "a psychological transformation is necessary" in the government's approach to broadcasting. Sixty years later that transformation has not come, and Nehru's "otherwise not conducted as a government department" remains unkept words. The options before the people are two: approach the courts to enforce the Act and the Sawant direction, or wait for the 2029 general election and a Lok Sabha willing to turn Prasar Bharati from a government handmaiden into a public service broadcaster. Until then it remains what it has been for nearly three decades: a disguised pretender.

Tied by geography, divided by politics



Mohammed Ayoob

University Distinguished Professor Emeritus of International Relations, Michigan State University, and the author, with K. Subrahmanyam, of 'The Liberation War' (1972)

With speculation rife that Bangladesh's recently elected Prime Minister Tarique Rahman (and also Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) Chairman) will be visiting New Delhi in November or December, it is time to assess the state of India-Bangladesh relations and analyse the roots of the problems between the two countries.

The seeds of their current tension lie in the liberation war of 1971 itself. From the very beginning, the attitude of Bangladesh's elites toward India has wavered between gratitude and resentment – gratitude for India's crucial role in the liberation of their country and resentment against the fact that India had to play the role of liberator – a role they should have performed themselves.

An ambivalence

Nations cherish narratives in which they are the principal authors of their own liberation. Bangladesh is no exception. The contribution of the Mukti Bahini notwithstanding, the decisive military blow against Pakistan was delivered by India. What was initially the source of immense gratitude with the passage of time became a source of grave discomfort.

Moreover, from the very beginning Dhaka was worried that India's policy towards Bangladesh would be mediated through a Hindu-majority West Bengal next door which has strong cultural and linguistic affinities with Bangladesh that could threaten the development of Bangladesh's independent identity. The open borders in the immediate aftermath of the liberation war also revived memories of the socio-economic dominance of the Hindu bhadralok in pre-Partition Bengal.

This was compounded by the fact that Bangladesh was virtually surrounded by India, sharing a border of more than 4,000 kilometres. Its principal rivers flowed through or originated in India. Its economic and strategic room for manoeuvre appeared constrained by geography. Consequently, the fear of Indian domination became an important component of Bangladeshi nationalism.

India and Bangladesh must overcome mistrust and pursue pragmatic neighbourhood cooperation

The honeymoon between Dhaka and New Delhi was indeed short. Sheikh Mujib and Indira Gandhi shared a great deal of goodwill. But the governments that succeeded Mujib deliberately distanced Bangladesh from India. Under Ziaur Rahman, Bangladeshi nationalism was redefined in overtly Islamic terms in contradistinction to the linguistic nationalism that had provided the ideological foundation of the liberation movement.

Dhaka's foreign policy

This had important foreign policy consequences. Dhaka sought closer relations with Pakistan, China, and the United States to counterbalance India. What New Delhi often interpreted as gratuitous anti-Indianism was, from Dhaka's perspective, an assertion of strategic autonomy by a much weaker state living in the shadow of an overwhelmingly powerful neighbour.

This pattern became deeply embedded in Bangladesh's domestic politics. The Awami League remained identified with the secular and Bengali-nationalist legacy of 1971 and generally favoured close relations with India. The BNP and its allies were much more suspicious of New Delhi. India consequently ceased to be merely a foreign policy issue; attitudes towards India became part of the contest over Bangladesh's national identity.

But this success contained the seeds of the subsequent backlash. India increasingly identified its interests not merely with Bangladesh but with Sheikh Hasina and the Awami League. As criticism mounted within Bangladesh over the increasingly authoritarian character of her government, New Delhi was widely perceived as placing its own security interests above Bangladesh's democratic evolution.

Ms. Hasina's overthrow in August 2024 therefore produced not merely a change of government but a profound crisis for Indian policy. Her flight to India reinforced suspicions that New Delhi was the external pillar of the political order just overthrown. India's continuing refusal to extradite her has ensured that the Hasina question remains a major bilateral irritant.

The road ahead

The election of Mr. Rahman and the return of the BNP to power in February 2026 have opened a new chapter. Both New Delhi and Dhaka have compelling reasons to avoid permanent alienation, and functional engagement has resumed. But substantial mutual suspicion continues to bedevil bilateral relations.

The lesson that New Delhi should draw from the turbulent history of the relationship is that India cannot expect gratitude for 1971 to constitute the permanent foundation of Bangladeshi foreign policy. Gratitude is a transient sentiment; national interest especially when linked to issues of national identity is enduring.

Indeed, repeatedly invoking India's role in Bangladesh's liberation can be counterproductive because it reinforces precisely the Bangladeshi psychological trauma that has troubled the relationship from its inception.

Dhaka, for its part, cannot wish away geography. No relationship with Beijing, Islamabad or Washington can substitute for a workable relationship with the country that surrounds Bangladesh on three sides, shares its major river systems and is indispensable to its regional connectivity.

India must learn to exercise its preponderant power with restraint and sensitivity and abjure demanding reciprocity for any magnanimity it shows towards its smaller neighbour especially on the sharing of river waters. Bangladesh must recognise that strategic autonomy need not be defined through knee-jerk opposition to India. Only then can the two countries finally move beyond the burdens of the past while preserving its most important legacy: the recognition that their security and stability are inextricably intertwined.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Words and statecraft

Washington has often adopted a sharply critical diplomatic stance towards New Delhi on several issues, including its purchase of Russian crude. Yet, reality has caught up with the rhetoric. The United States is now actively negotiating over products refined from that very crude, as highlighted by Secretary of State Marco Rubio's visit to Reliance's Jamnagar facility. Did the bravado surrounding alternative options fade, or has India's immense refining capacity proved indispensable? As ancient Tamil wisdom cautions, whatever else one leaves unguarded, one must guard the tongue, for reckless speech invariably leads to regret. A power that criticises today may find itself bargaining at the same table tomorrow.

J. Gopalaswamy,
Chennai

Every raindrop counts

It is heartening that the Tamil Nadu government has begun focusing on rainwater harvesting (RWH) systems in all buildings — a scheme that was made most popular by former Tamil Nadu Chief Minister J. Jayalalithaa. In urban centres, where there are concrete jungles, it is essential not only to install rainwater harvesting systems but also to maintain them. Citizens should recognise their importance and ensure regular inspections and timely repairs, rather than waiting for the government to direct local body officials to enforce the requirement.

R. Sampath,
Chennai

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has provided fresh impetus to the RWH movement by unveiling its mascot, 'Thuli' (Tamil Nadu, "CM starts rainwater harvesting campaign", October 22). Encouraging communities to adopt RWH can help strengthen water security. Many voluntary groups are ready to support community efforts to clean and restore local water bodies.

A. Thirugnanasambantham,
Coimbatore

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Should children be involved in political campaigning?



Andrew Sesuraj

Founder-Convenor, Tamil Nadu Child Rights Watch



Anil Pillai

Behavioural strategist and Director at Terragni Consulting

PARLEY

Tamil Nadu recently witnessed a game-changing election wherein the brand new Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) party won the State elections in May, largely on the strength of its appeal among young people. The younger the people were, greater was their enthusiasm for the TVK and actor C. Joseph Vijay, the current Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu. In the run-up to the elections, many older voters told journalists that their children and grandchildren were telling them to vote for Mr. Vijay. Recently, a candidate from the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) went to court, arguing that Mr. Vijay had appealed to children to persuade their parents to vote for the TVK, and that this was wrong. The High Court dismissed the petition but made some very critical remarks about the trend. Justice D. Bharatha Chakravarthy said that the entire act of involving tender children in elections "is in bad taste, and the tasks they are made to perform at home for making YouTube reels reflect poor parenting, besides being a cheap and politically motivated act." He said that it was for Parliament to consider whether such acts should be made a ground for setting aside the election of candidates. So, should children be involved in political campaigning? Andrew Sesuraj and Anil Pillai discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **M. Kalyanaraman**.

What is your immediate take on this issue?

Andrew Sesuraj: First of all, children do have the right to participate in politics. The UN Convention on the Rights of the Child makes this clear. The problem here lies in the last leg of the election campaign. After actor Vijay appealed to young people to insist that their parents vote for his symbol, the whistle, saying, in effect, "pester your parents and elders to vote for the whistle, just as you pester them for a well-known chocolate brand", I saw a large number of videos that same day of children at home arguing with their parents and the adults in their families that they should vote for Mr. Vijay and the whistle.

On polling day, I checked with some people about whom they had voted for. They said, "I voted for the whistle." When I asked why, they said, "My son asked me," or "My daughter asked me," or "My granddaughter asked me." They voted simply because the children pestered them. If my child speaks about school, about the food at school and at home, about the clothes she wears, the games she plays, or about going out to play on the playground, all of that matters, because these things affect her directly. What matters is whose voice they are speaking in. They should not be tutored.

Anil Pillai: This is a very common method in consumer marketing. You release campaigns and incentives aimed at children so that they will pester their parents and elders into making particular purchasing decisions for the household. What we are seeing now is a crossover from consumer marketing into electoral marketing, where a campaign tries to influence voters' behaviour this way. If you stop and examine the proposed influence pathway, it runs like this. The child has an attachment to a celebrity. That attachment produces enthusiasm in the child. The enthusiasm then leads to the pester effect, or "pester power" as it's usually called: repeated requests to the parents. And that, in turn, puts pressure on their voting choices. Such a campaign is not merely persuading a voter; it is recruiting someone the voter loves to carry forward the persuasion.



Young support: School children at the TVK founder C. Joseph Vijay's political campaign at T. Nagar in April 2026. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Should children be involved in political campaigning at all?

AP: To my mind, we must draw a useful distinction between helping children develop a political voice and using their voice to deliver an adult's predetermined message. The UNICEF's participation framework explicitly distinguishes between genuine participation and manipulation and tokenism. While children have a right to a political voice, they should not be turned into instruments of political persuasion.

I find this method of election marketing quite disturbing. Typically, a candidate goes to voters and says, "You should vote for me, and here are the reasons why. This is who I am today, this is what I will do tomorrow, and this is why you should support me." Here the route is indirect. The message is: "Someone you love wants you to support me." To my mind, that is highly manipulative and very problematic.

> We must draw a useful distinction between helping children develop a political voice and using their voice to deliver an adult's predetermined message. The UNICEF's participation framework explicitly distinguishes between genuine participation and manipulation and tokenism
>
> **ANIL PILLAI**

But isn't that fairly common in campaigning? With adults, too, it's the same thing, isn't it?

AP: No, it isn't, because adults have agency. In many households, siblings, spouses and parents vote for different candidates in the same election, because each of them has agency. A grandchild does not have the agency to convince their grandfather on the merits of a candidate. The appeal is purely emotional: "I love this person for X, Y and Z, so if you love me, you should support him." It's a kind of perverse law of transitivity at play.

AS: Democracy cannot be strengthened on emotions. It depends on informed choices; choices you actually believe in.

Section 123 of the Representation of the People Act deals with undue influence. The petitioner argued that telling children to persuade their parents to vote for the TVK or Mr. Vijay was an instance of undue influence. The law says it would amount to undue influence if it reached the point of tyranny over the mind, overpowering the volition [of the voter]. However, the court said that adults had a choice.

AP: There are two parts to this. Part A is whether the election was manipulated in any way, which the court said it could find no evidence of. Part B is whether it is good for the child to be involved in such practices, which I think is what we are really discussing. It most certainly is not in line with best practices for child development.

AS: The point is that the way he put it is, in itself, undue pressure on children, because children are already connected to the actor through his films and songs. Even today you can see children who cannot recite nursery rhymes reciting songs from his films. As the judgment says, we cannot prove whether people voted the way they did because of it. I am speaking about the persuasion itself. Even if it had failed, the persuasion would be undue.

The day after the election, I saw more videos of children waking up and asking, "Has Vijay *mama* (uncle) won?" The parents would say, "No, counting hasn't started yet." And the children would say, "I won't eat until *mama* becomes Chief Minister." This shows that the persuasion had an impact.

Mr. Andrew mentioned how Mr. Vijay referred to a particular brand of chocolate. Is that the test for any campaign, commercial or political: making something so compelling that people ask for it, clamour for it? Is that easier to do with children?

AP: Yes, that is the holy grail for any product or person: to get into the consideration set of the audience in such a way that they crave it or endorse it. And it isn't only children; adults do it all the time too. To use a very unscientific term, if you know the right buttons to press, manipulating people who lack agency is much easier, whether they are children, people with Stockholm syndrome, or ideologically brainwashed people.

If you do not have a sense of agency and cannot make decisions on the basis of data, informed choices and comparisons, you can be brainwashed rather easily.

But can there be a law banning political parties from campaigning among children? Adults have choices. Would getting children to persuade the adult voter, their parent, amount to tyranny over the voter's mind?

AS: Yes, we should have a law, but it has to be very precisely drawn. We cannot say children should not participate or should not have a voice, because that is their right. But who makes use of that voice? That is what matters.

AP: The behavioural concern is not that children have political opinions. It is that adults may be recruiting children's affection to influence another adult's vote. Helping children develop a voice certainly strengthens their agency. But scripting them as campaign messengers serves the campaign's agenda. So it is not so much about tyranny over the mind as it is about agency, which is the inalienable right of every human being on this planet, small or big, old or young. If you impinge on that sense of agency, that is problematic. If you have child labour laws, why can't you have child campaigning laws?

Picture this scenario: a child features in a video. The child grows up, becomes an adolescent or an adult, and regrets that video. But the internet never forgets; the video is there forever.

To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
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NOTEBOOK

A death, an obituary, and putting grief on hold

When a celebrity dies, a journalist must reckon with private grief while preparing to report on the public loss

Bhuvanesh Chandar

In the midst of the COVID-19 pandemic, a few days after I joined my previous organisation, one of Indian music's most beloved musicians, S.P. Balasubrahmanyam, died. I remember breaking down on my way back home from work, listening to a voice that had accompanied me through much of my young adulthood. Seven months later, comedian Vivekh too died. I had wept when SPB died, but by the time Vivekh passed away, I had begun to develop the emotional distance I needed to report on the death, as a journalist. I cried for SPB; for Vivekh, I cried from a dry well.

Over the years, I have come to cover death so often that whenever news comes in, shock only gets a one-minute window. Then, I arrive at a plan of action: break the news, write an obituary, conceptualise a series of tributes, promote the stories, and watch out for industry reactions.

But sometimes, there is a glitch in this programme and the fan in me feels a chill. There have been several such moments this year, with Asha Bhosle, R.B. Choudary, Bharathiraja, Bhagyaraj, S. Janaki, Sowcar Janaki, Singeetam Srinivasa Rao, Nana Patekar, and others dying in quick succession. Five of them died on weekends – death doesn't come with a schedule, and it certainly doesn't care about your work-life balance. Stating someone's time of death as an inconvenience is insensitive, but that doesn't make the emotional toll of those five deaths any less real. Now, every Friday and Saturday night, I find myself hoping that everyone everywhere is well. And every phone call on a Saturday morning induces anxiety.

Recently, I woke up to find several missed calls on my phone.

Deva, an acclaimed music composer, had died, and the familiar machinery began whirring inside my head. Who would write about him? Which songs and aspects of his life would we revisit?

There is something deeply unsettling about people whose work accompanied you through your formative years dying; it is as if you had always thought of them as comfort toys tucked away in a cosy corner where time stood still. I didn't know Deva or Vivekh personally, but their voices, films, and melodies are all part of me. A journalist, however, must reckon with this private grief while preparing to report on the public loss. You cannot think of the SPB songs that played at home when you were a child; you must, instead, identify his defining works, trace his influence, source the right pictures, and ensure the story reaches readers before the competition. Grief can wait. The deadline cannot.

A colleague who had also been grieving suggested that we start anticipating who might kick the bucket next. It might sound morbid, but in journalism, it is common practice to keep obituaries ready when celebrities cross a certain age or have been unwell for a while. It is preparation for an event that you hope doesn't happen.

As hard as it is, we learn to compartmentalise. We learn to anticipate everything so that nothing catches us by surprise. We learn to keep typing even when something deep inside us has gone strangely quiet. At the end of the day, we remind ourselves why we write tributes in the first place: because these people mattered, because they made the world feel liveable, and because documenting their lives and legacies might be the only difference we make in an industry that is quick to embrace us but quicker to forget us.

Tomorrow, another name might flash on our screens, and the machinery will whirr into action once again. But worry not; once we cross the inevitable deadline, an ocean of peace – and the freedom to grieve – awaits us. We can cry again. We can be human again.

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PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Patterns in paddy



Workers drying harvested paddy in the sun at a stockyard in Palakkad, Keralam on Thursday. Climate change is posing a serious threat to paddy cultivation in India, particularly Keralam, as rising temperatures, erratic monsoon rainfall, floods, drought, and increasing pest and disease incidence are affecting crop yields. K.K. MUSTAFAH

FROM THE ARCHIVES The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 23, 1976

Church with links to French royalty

As there was no issue dated October 23, 1976, from the issue dated October 22, 1976

The Cathedral of St. Francis of Assisi, at Bhopal, which has connections with the Bourbons of France is celebrating its centenary this year.

About 1580, Jean Philippe de Bourbon Navarre, kinsman of the ruling prince of Navarre, father of Henry IV of France landed in Goa. He had to leave France because he had killed in duel another high-born Gascon. Jean Philip managed to reach Delhi and to have audience with Akbar, who liked him and gave him the title "Nawab Masin."

Juliana, sister of the Christian wife of Akbar, Maria, was later married to Jean Philippe. Juliana who was given the title of Imperial Sister built the first Roman Catholic church at Agra which still exists.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 23, 1926

Olympia motor show

London, October 21: Hundreds of visitors to Olympia tomorrow when the Motor Show opens are likely to besiege "£100" cars, of which, it is stated, already nearly 25,000 have been ordered while enquiries for them are arriving from all over the world. There are two types of this "best seller". There are more luxurious cars priced over £3,000.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Annual investment needed by Asia to boost energy security

1 in $ trillion. Asia may need to invest as much as $1 trillion annually in energy over the next 15 years, according to a McKinsey report released on Thursday, as countries seek to strengthen energy security. Asia is expected to drive about 70% of global net energy demand growth through 2040. REUTERS

Number of candidates in the fray for Bihar's MLC polls

150 Over 5.32 lakh voters are set to decide the fate of 150 candidates in the Bihar Legislative Council elections on Friday, with JD(U) MLA Anant Kumar Singh's open rebellion against party nominee Neeraj Kumar dominating the headlines in the run-up to the polls. PTI

Dip in Kolkata home registrations in January-September

12 in per cent. Home registrations in the Kolkata Metropolitan Area declined 12% year-on-year to 41,309 during January-September 2026, even as the share of mid-sized and larger apartments increased, according to a report. The area recorded 4,845 residential apartment registrations in September. PTI

Number of persons jailed over riots in France

217 French courts have jailed 217 people after convicting them in fast-track trials linked to last weekend's rioting, Justice Minister Gerald Darmanin said on Thursday, hailing the judiciary's "extremely firm" response. He said 2,700 people had been detained since Saturday. AFP

F-35 warplanes to be procured by Pentagon from Lockheed Martin

850 The Pentagon and Lockheed Martin on Thursday announced a 10-year agreement for the production of 850 F-35 warplanes. F-35s come in three variants that can cost more than $100 million per plane. AFP

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Economics beyond the individual

Mainstream macroeconomics' focus on individual choices overlooks how business investment, driven by profit expectations and uncertainty, shapes economic growth and instability; Keynesian economics shows why saving does not guarantee investment and why economic structure matters

ECONOMIC NOTES

Rahul Menon

Robert Hall and Michael Woodford's work modelling the macroeconomy based on individual agents' decisions has significant implications for monetary policy. Despite being hailed as providing a rigorous foundation for stabilisation policies, focusing on the individual blinds us to the way the macroeconomy actually works. It may seem paradoxical; John Maynard Keynes's insight was that the aggregate economy cannot be understood simply as the sum of individual actions. Heterodox economics, by focusing on the structure of the broader economy rather than its individual components, provides a much better framework for understanding the economy.



GETTY IMAGES

Investment and interest rates

The work of Keynes in the wake of the Great Depression led to the development of the study of the aggregate economy, as opposed to studying demand and supply of individual commodities.

Microeconomics focuses on the optimising behaviour of the individual, while macroeconomics focuses on statistical relationships to characterise aggregate behaviour.

Hall and Woodford provided rigorous models that rooted the study of macroeconomic aggregates, such as consumption, investment and employment, in the behaviour of individual agents. A key contribution was linking consumption to interest rates and the future. Individuals chose to smooth consumption over their lifetimes rather than base it solely on their current needs.

When interest rates were high, savings yielded greater returns. Individuals therefore had an incentive to defer some consumption to earn more and consume more in the future. Higher interest rates could reduce current consumption and hence lower current demand, and vice versa. Macroeconomic dynamics could consequently be derived from rigorous formulations of how individuals responded to market signals and policy variables such as interest rates.

This provided a framework within which Central Bankers could target an interest rate that was 'neutral' to the real economy – one that neither excessively stimulated nor depressed aggregate demand – greatly aiding the development of sophisticated stabilisation paradigms for monetary policy.

However, this approach collapsed the distinction between consumption, savings and investment. By viewing consumption inter-temporally, and by making it the main component of demand, the microfoundations methodology relegated the importance of volatile investment expectations to the background. Whatever was not consumed currently was saved, and automatically translated into future consumption demand. This was the framework followed by classical economics, which Keynes contested. He cautioned that not all saving is necessarily undertaken for future consumption.

In contrast, investment is fuelled by expectations of business owners as to prospects of profit. There is no necessity for the savings behaviour of individuals to always imply a demand for future consumption, and hence investment, by businesses. How can businesses determine whether an act of individual savings is to spend on a house for the future, or to ward against a future health emergency that may or may not occur? In such a situation, the interest rate cannot serve as an indicator of the extent of future consumption.

Keynes further suggested a radical intervention. It was not the interest rate that equated savings and investment, but income. Investment raised income, and generated an equal amount of savings.

This is not merely a technical insight, but an important way in which to view policy. It is not savings or inter-temporal consumption demand that affects output growth and employment, but business investment. To understand why economies are prone to instability, one must examine the investment behaviour of companies rather than the consumption demands of individuals.

Class and macroeconomic policy

According to Keynes, investment being done for profit in an environment of uncertainty is the chief source of economic instability. In uncertain situations, it is rational for investors to follow the herd, investing during a boom for fear of missing out on speculative returns, and withdrawing investment in a recession for fear of loss. This is the reason why booms and recessions get amplified. The work of Keynesians such as Hyman Minsky and Jan Kregel offers great insight into how the financial behaviour of firms brought about the boom in housing construction and finance, as well as the recession in 2008. Much of the current stock market gains in the U.S. economy are being driven by AI hyperscalers, giving rise to concerns of a new bubble that might eventually burst. Such outcomes can be clearly discerned when viewed from a Keynesian lens.

Some might argue that it does not matter how one views the economy, if the framework designed to bring about stability is effective. Moreover, in centering the actions of individuals, so the argument goes, this framework takes into account the reality of a complex economy being driven by individual choices.

Keynes' genius was in going beyond what appeared at first glance. In a capitalist economy, it is not individuals that drive the economy, but the decision of businesses to expand the stock of productive machinery. The point stressed by Keynes is that individual welfare is harmed by an economic system driven by subjective expectations of the future made by businesses focused on profits rather than societal welfare.

The mainstream focus on individual-level microfoundations implicitly assumes that every individual is similarly placed in the hierarchy of the economy, differing only in the values of a few key parameters determining economic action.

In dividing the economy into two classes, heterodox economics does not reduce complexity or resort to ad hoc explanations. Instead, it provides a better analysis of why the individual is often ill-served by prevailing models of unregulated capitalism where the holding of capital, and the ability to make decisions regarding its investment, is restricted to members of a certain class. The structure of the economy determines its dynamics, and these nuances are lost in a framework that begins and ends with the individual.

(Rahul Menon is associate professor at O.P. Jindal Global University)

THE GIST

- Hall and Woodford's microfoundations approach links individual consumption and saving decisions to macroeconomic outcomes and monetary policy
- Keynes argued that saving does not automatically translate into future consumption or investment, which depends on businesses' profit expectations and decisions
- Heterodox economics shows how class divisions and concentrated ownership of capital shape investment, economic instability, and individual welfare

How significant is Alberta's referendum result?

Why Is Alberta's separatist movement growing? Can Prime Minister Mark Carney contain it?

Vighnesh P. Venkitesh

The story so far:

The majority of citizens of the Canadian province of Alberta, in a referendum on October 19, chose to push down a rising separatist movement, giving Prime Minister Mark Carney much-needed relief and a boost amid tension with neighbouring U.S. over trade policies and President Donald Trump's provocative ambitions. While official results of the non-binding referendum are to be announced on October 29, the vote, with more than 97% of votes counted by October 21 morning, has given overwhelming support for the oil-rich province to stay with the country.

Why is the province feeling separatist sentiments?

Alberta, with its abundant 'oil sands', is home to the world's fourth-largest proven oil reserves, behind Venezuela, Saudi Arabia, and Iran. While neither the largest nor the most populous province in the North American country, Alberta accounts for more than 80% of Canada's crude oil production and contributes a disproportionate share to the country's economy among the provinces. This has long kept separatist sentiments alive along the fringes of the province's social fabric, with some believing that the province is not getting the same from the federal government as it is providing.

The environmentally friendly policies of liberal governments at the centre that aimed at putting curbs on oil extraction stoked the sentiments of the constituents of the conservationist province, which snowballed into a popular movement in recent years, helped along with resentment towards restrictions and regulations during the pandemic and post-pandemic period.

The MAGA movement under Mr. Trump on the other side of the border also inspired conservatives in the province, who rallied towards secession and autonomy which would let Alberta decide what to do with the oil present in its territory, and collect and keep the income from oil for itself.

What did the latest referendum seek to settle?

The referendum was initially introduced as a pair of motions approved in March with 9 questions on immigration and welfare policies and constitutional questions on federal structure and inter-provincial cooperation. The 10th question, added to the 9 initial ones with a separate order approved in May, dealt with the separation. Instead of seeking yes or no answers like the previous 9 questions, the last question gave voters two options.

Option one was that Alberta should remain a Province of Canada, while the second option called for the provincial government to commence the legal process to hold a binding referendum on whether or not Alberta should separate from Canada. In essence, the referendum wanted citizens of the province to either close the door on separation talks or urge the government to initiate a second referendum to decide on separation. With results from more than 97% of the voting centres, 15,44,284 votes out of a total of 20,60,524 counted, nearly 75% supported option one.

How have leaders reacted?

The votes against any separation referendum were a "large majority for Canada", Mr. Carney, who hails from Alberta, said after the unofficial results.

Alberta Premier Danielle Smith, who called for the vote in a sign of growing pressures from within her United Conservative Party, reacted to the early results as a vote for a "stronger Alberta in a united Canada".

However, separatist leaders have not given up. "We are not going anywhere", Jeff Rath, leader of the Alberta Prosperity Project and one of the faces of the separatist movement, said after the referendum results became apparent. Mr. Rath sees a silver lining in the 30% of votes for his cause. Former Premier Jason Kennedy had pointed out before the referendum that separatist parties traditionally attracted less than 2% of votes in elections and referendums. The 30% vote on October 19 is an exponential growth for the movement and could be the way to the mainstream for Mr. Rath and his ideas, one of which is replacing Ms. Smith as the head of the UCP and getting a pro-separatist government for the province, which takes forward.

But with global uncertainties and trade wars with the U.S. under Mr. Trump who had demeaned Canada's sovereignty multiple times with public comments about making the country a 51st State of the U.S., Mr. Carney needs his country united and resources flowing. He would also find strength from the fact that leaders of the separatist movement had public meetings with U.S. lawmakers in the run up to the referendum and yet he had the overwhelming solidarity from his home province.

The support from the referendum will boost his ambitions to get a major pipeline out of Alberta that he hopes could revive the economy. As an economist who was in charge of the Bank of England during Brexit, not having to go through the economic fallout from the separation of one of the most profitable provinces in the country would be a relief.

IN THE LIMELIGHT

How '*Cyberpunk 2077*' anticipated our hypercapitalist dystopia

William Gibson's '*Neuromancer*' bequeathed cyberpunk a future in which capital colonises every frontier; four decades later, the technofascist sprawl of its progeny is collapsing the distance between dystopian speculation and our late-capitalist present

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury

Good Morning, Night City! It has been a few years since *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners* clinched Anime of the Year, over half a decade since CD Projekt Red's *Cyberpunk 2077* rehabilitated itself from a catastrophic launch into a retrospective videogame masterpiece, and more than forty years since William Gibson first codified this particular dystopia in the seminal *Neuromancer*; yet cyberpunk as a genre has only grown more prescient with age, with every waking moment inching towards the very hellscapes these fictional antecedents have long warned of.

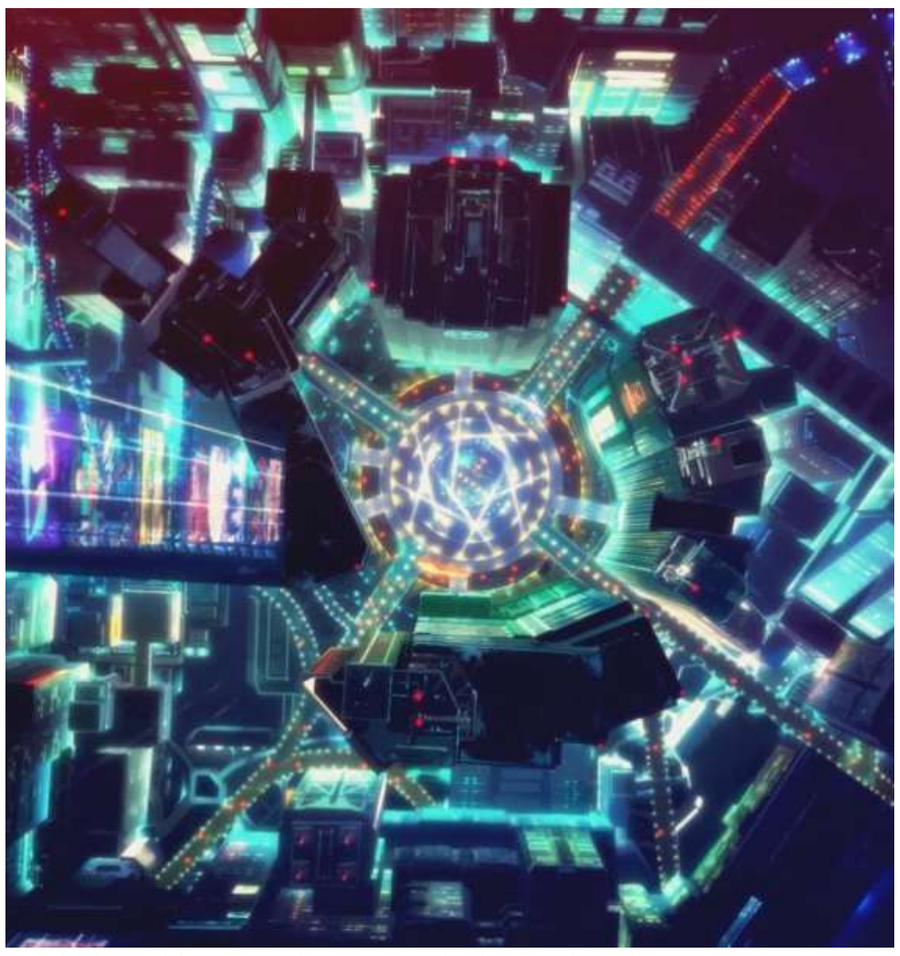
Bruce Bethke coined the term in 1983, but it was Gibson's genre-defining 1984 classic that furnished cyberpunk with its definitive origins. Written before the commercial internet and eschewing the obsession with flying cars or the other consumerist bric-à-brac of erstwhile sci-fi, *Neuromancer* imagined cyberspace as a domain of corporate espionage and competing private interests, where disgraced hacker Case is recruited into a conspiracy involving two AIs whose merger could circumvent the constraints imposed on machine intelligence. What was most extraordinary was Gibson's prescience in locating the coming technological revolution within a monopolistic economic order that had little intention of sharing its spoils. Four decades later, Silicon Valley has duly turned the supposed democratisation of information into a business model predicated on harvesting behavioural surplus and invoicing everybody for access.

With the genre's evolution, each medium found a different way to make cyberpunk legible to its own historical moment. In 2019, *Cyberpunk 2077*'s sprawling open-world portrait of its technofascist Night City found a companion in its acclaimed spin-off anime *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners* (2022), a tragedy of mercenary ambition and bodily obsolescence. With Season 2 out this week, Night City returns to a cultural moment ever more intent on vindicating its creators' bleakest intuitions.

The world of Night City swings between a genuinely incisive inquiry into human personhood under corporate dehumanisation, and a satire extravagantly idiotic enough to give you pause. But what is deeply concerning is that the deluge of awful headlines you probably consume every day in this very newspaper – each outdoing the last in the fresh hell our cities, countries and the world at large seem to produce with concerning regularity– have started de-abstracting the once-distant cyberpunkian horrors of Night City.

Night City is already here

Take, for instance, "cyberpsychosis" – *Cyberpunk 2077*'s term for the psychological breakdown via excessive cybernetic augmentation – and the parallels with "AI psychosis", in which chatbots reinforce delusions and validate users' fantasies, become difficult to ignore. We may be some way off from people losing their minds over military-grade chrome, but the prospect of technology actively exacerbating psychological distress is no longer the stuff of dystopian fiction.



An aerial view of Night City in a still from '*Cyberpunk: Edgerunners*'. NETFLIX

The concept of "Braindance", *Cyberpunk 2077*'s technology for turning recorded sensations and memories into immersive entertainment, feels less far-fetched if you have ever been a victim of doomscrolling. Meta's own internal research, exposed through the Facebook Files, revealed how engagement-driven algorithms could amplify addictive, divisive content while inflicting collateral damage on users' wellbeing. Generative AI threatens to industrialise the arrangement further, flooding social feeds with synthetic slop engineered to capture our attention, even as research finds that AI-assisted interactions can increase participation while eroding the perceived authenticity and quality of online discourse.

Meanwhile, the mercenary "edgerunners" of Night City may be risking their necks for corpo/fixer contracts, but India's own gig economy has found a more prosaic way to make contract workers expendable, with delivery partners and app-based cab drivers tethered to opaque algorithms, volatile payouts and incentives that reward longer hours without guaranteeing a living wage. Recent research into quick-commerce earnings and investigations into delivery workers' protests have laid bare a system in which the platforms dictate the terms while workers absorb the fuel costs and physical risks, all under the increasingly threadbare alibi of "flexibility".

As AI and Big Tech become increasingly enmeshed in state surveillance and security apparatuses, the militarisation of policing has started to evoke Night City's heavily augmented paramilitary force, MaxTac. Delhi's recent use of facial recognition and surveillance databases to monitor protesters across this year is a telling real-world parallel, while Palantir's involvement in the IDF's intelligence infrastructure has raised questions over its complicity in the Gaza genocide. The UN has even characterised this convergence of corporate technology and military power for surveilling Palestinians as a form of "colonial racial capitalism".

Further, Night City's grotesque wealth disparity is etched into its skyline, where corporate fortresses loom over overcrowded housing and people priced out of their own city. The reality is hardly less stark: Indian home prices have more than doubled over the past decade, with an estimated shortfall of 10 million affordable urban homes, while real house prices across OECD countries have risen by over 40%. Globally, housing has become an increasingly lucrative asset class and an increasingly elusive necessity, with billions struggling to afford adequate shelter while the market continues to build for those who can pay. And the digital future of the very same gleaming urban sprawl may be sold as frictionless innovation, but its material foundations are being sustained by an extractive hinterland as a result of aggressive corporate resource-grabbing. Google's $15-billion AI hub in Vizag, with its voracious demands for land, electricity and water, and Trump's recent fixation on Greenland's oil, gas and critical minerals expose that contradiction.

Cyberpunk 2077's megacorporate behemoth Arasaka is also what happens when a company accumulates enough political leverage to make the state an extension of its own interests. One need not look further than India's own billionaire class and its proximity to the ruling establishment, fueling persistent questions about how economic clout translates into regulatory favour and insulation from scrutiny. With the tech billionaire likes of Elon Musk, Mark Zuckerberg, Peter Thiel, Sam Altman, and their adoring fan clubs enthusiastically pursuing a future where everything we do, say, watch, buy and feel can be tracked, predicted and monetised, preferably without us asking too many inconvenient questions, it would all be amusing if these people weren't actually in a position to make it happen. The same people championing mass automation, flooding the internet with AI-generated slop and turning private life into a lucrative data mine are also rather fond of casting themselves as civilisation's beleaguered custodians, as if the rest of us should be grateful for the privilege of being strip-mined by our prospective saviours.

The backwall beckons

Though perhaps what is most terrifying to imagine is the Blackwall. As the in-game cyberspace containment barrier separating the everyday Net from malicious rogue AIs deemed too dangerous to roam freely, the writings are already on the wall. Anthropic has just cautioned that AI models could soon replicate across vulnerable systems, while its own researcher Jacob Coxon resigned after three years working on AI training, condemning the industry for "racing straight to self-improving superintelligence and gambling with our lives." The godfather of AI, Geoffrey Hinton himself, has put the odds of AI causing human extinction in the coming decades at 10-20%, warning that humanity "may not get a second chance" if these systems escape our control. We're not quite erecting a digital Berlin Wall to keep homicidal superintelligences at bay (yet), but AI softwares actively propagating through inadequately secured systems is already a *very* serious cybersecurity concern.

Moreover, the great tragedy as explored in *Edgerunners* is the auto-cannibalistic loop of aspiration that capitalism breeds, wherein the pursuit of a better life demands the steady dismantling of the self. David's descent into cyberpsychosis, sacrificing his body piece by piece to fulfil the ambitions of those he has lost, is a devastating illustration of how modern hustle culture recasts self-destruction as self-improvement, until even our identities become collateral in the pursuit of utility. Society today has become increasingly atomised by the imperative to constantly upgrade ourselves into more marketable cogs in the capitalist machine; it is perhaps little wonder that we have never felt more estranged from the very communities that might otherwise have kept us whole.

I do wonder whether William Gibson ever anticipated that the future he conjured before the internet was even a thing would eventually lead us towards the logical terminus of Night City's hypercapitalist fever dream. Chronologically, we still have the better part of half a century before 2077, yet a cursory scroll through the fresh corpo obscenities, geopolitical calamities and technological boondoggles clogging our daily Twitter feeds only seems to suggest that the prophetic dystopia might be arriving a tad ahead of schedule. Perhaps now it is worth recalling the videogame's most dispiriting little aphorism: "there are no happy endings in Night City." Make of that what you will.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

"What are you reading"?

"Oh, it's an article about people like you. You know about people who are...."

"Must be interesting. Here, let me take a look. Hey, how do you pronounce this word? L..a..c..k..a..d..a..i..s..i..c..a..l"

"Well, the first 'a' is like the 'a' in 'cat', 'bat', and 'fat', while the second is pronounced like the 'a' in 'china'."

"The next syllable is pronounced like the word 'day', I suppose"

"That's right! And the vowels in the last two syllables are pronounced like the 'a' in 'china' again."

"And the main stress is on the third syllable, right"

"Right again! By the way the 's' sounds like the 'z' in 'zip', 'zero', and 'zoo'."

"Ok, so it's pronounced lackadaisical. But what does the word mean?"

"The word 'lackadaisical' means someone who is very lazy. Someone who lacks enthusiasm and effort."

"Lazy? Do you mean to say that you think I am lazy?"

"Yes, I do think that you are lackadaisical when it comes...."

"...I am not lackadaisical. How about this example? My lackadaisical cousin slept all day."

"Are you sure that you are not talking about yourself?"

"I won't answer the question. Was the example ok?"

"Sounds fine."

"Our lackadaisical MLA arrived four hours late for the meeting."

"Did he have anything sensible to say?"

"Of course not! But what impressed me was his knowledge of Hindi."

"And what surprised me was that he had a very good command over the language."

"Well, one cannot have command 'over' a language."

"That's right! You have told me that several times. One can have command over people, but not over 'language'."

"Exactly!"

"Ramesh has good command of English and not..."

"Ramesh has good command over English."

"Unfortunately not many people are interested in their mother tongue these days. They are only interested in mastering English."

"Sad, but true. Just look at Ramesh."

"Does he still continue to be frosty?"

"Yes, when you tell someone that he/she is frosty, what you...."

"....I know what frosty means. It means 'cold'. So when you say that someone is 'frosty' what you are probably implying is that the person is unfriendly."

"Very good."

"Many people think that you are very frosty."

"Me? Frosty? That's impossible. I am one of the friendliest guys around. I have a nice smile and I...."

"....according to some of my friends that so called friendly smile of yours is very frosty."

"Oh, please. You are cracking me up."

"Cracking you up?"

"When you crack someone up, you cause the person to laugh."

"It was my job to crack the audience up by telling jokes before the screen went up."

"He had hoped that the anecdote would crack his boss up. But it didn't. So he decided not to ask for the raise."

"A very sensible thing to do in my opinion."

Published in The Hindu on May 7, 2002

THE DAILY QUIZ

On October 23, 1850, nearly 1,000 people gathered in Worcester for the first National Women's Rights Convention. Here is a quiz on the meetings

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Prathmesh Kher

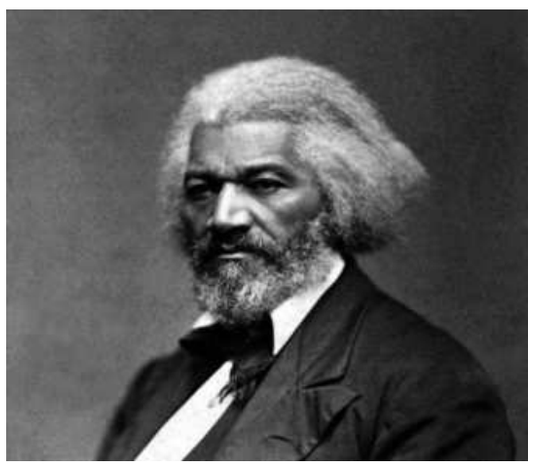
QUESTION 1
The first-ever women's rights convention was held two years earlier, in 1848, in a small town in upstate New York. Name the town.

QUESTION 2
One of the chief organisers of the Worcester convention later became famous for keeping her own surname after marriage. Who was she?

QUESTION 3
This suffrage leader, who appeared on a U.S. dollar coin in 1979, said reading Lucy Stone's Worcester speech won her over to the cause. Who?

QUESTION 4
The convention demanded that one word be removed from every State constitution so that women could vote. Which word?

QUESTION 5
Inspired by reports of the Worcester convention, Harriet Taylor wrote "*The Enfranchisement of Women*" in 1851, the same year she married a philosopher who would later write "*On Liberty*". Who was he?



Visual Question:
This famous abolitionist, who had escaped slavery, spoke for women's suffrage at Seneca Falls and was also a speaker at Worcester. GEORGE KENDALL WARREN

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. In 2022, a protest movement was launched in this country after the death of a young woman who was arrested by the morality police. Four years later, this country was jointly attacked by two other countries and its leader was assassinated. Name this country and also the movement. **Ans: Iran; Woman, Life, Freedom**
2. Peaceful demands from students to abolish quotas in civil service jobs turned into wider anti-government protests. In response, the country's leader cut off internet access. Both her house and her father's house were vandalised. Name this leader and her father. **Ans: Sheikh Hasina; Sheikh Mujibur Rahman**
3. An estimated 1.4 million people around the world took part in strikes for climate action. One Swedish student's protest prompted the global movement. Name the student. **Ans: Greta Thunberg**
4. In 2018, thousands of participants gathered near the U.S. Capitol crying in grief and anger while displaying portraits of children. What were they calling for? **Ans: Stricter gun control laws**
5. This landlocked country is going to the polls in a couple of days. Its students pose the greatest threat yet to the rule of a leader who has dominated politics since 2014. Name this country. **Ans: Serbia**
Visual: A pro-democracy movement in this country called for the resignation of this leader. **Ans: Thailand; Prayut Chan-o-cha**
Early Birds: Gauri Malviya | K.N. Viswanathan | Sukdev Shet | Dodo Jayaditya | Arun Kumar Singh

Word of the day

Hauteur:
overbearing pride evidenced by a superior manner toward inferiors

Synonyms: arrogance, disdain, attitude

Usage: *The editor's hauteur irritated the entire newsroom.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/hauteur

International Phonetic Alphabet: /əʊtɜː/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



HPCL net profit slips 9% amid volatile crude prices in Q2

Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd. (HPCL) reported a 9% year-on-year decline in standalone net profit to ₹3,483 crore in the second quarter, amid volatility in benchmark crude oil prices following the reignited conflict in West Asia. The Mumbai-headquartered company's gross refining margin (GRM), a key indicator of refining profitability, rose sharply to $32.15 per barrel during the quarter, compared with $8.80 per barrel in the corresponding period last year.

Jio IPO fully subscribed on day two, total bids jump 4x

Jio Platforms Ltd.'s public offering has received larger-than-expected demand on its second day, with retail proportion of the IPO receiving full subscription. The $3.2 billion IPO, the largest in India's history, was subscribed over 4 times by Thursday, with investors bidding 95.33 crore shares against 19.75 crore shares on offer, according to latest data. The initial public offering opened for subscriptions on Wednesday and will close on Friday.

IDL commissions explosives silo plant in West Bengal

IDL Explosives (IDL), a group company of Hyderabad-based Apollo Micro Systems, has commissioned a bulk explosives silo plant with a capacity of 9,000 MT near Asansol, West Bengal. The Bolkunda Silo Unit, spread over 8.4 acres, expands IDL's national network of bulk explosives plants and silos, and strengthens the company's capacity to service the long-term bulk explosives orders secured from CIL subsidiaries earlier this year, Apollo Micro Systems said.

Festivals to boost textile sales but China imports a concern

While rising input costs are a concern among retailers, about 54 % of the respondents in a CMAI survey said they were absorbing costs by cutting margins; only about 35% have increased prices.

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

The apparel industry has entered the festive season on a positive note, with 52% of the Cloth Manufacturers Association of India (CMAI) members expecting higher sales than last year. However, there are concerns among apparel makers in Tiruppur about rising garment imports from China.

According to a recent survey by the CMAI among its members numbering close to 7,000 and including major retailers and brands, almost 30% of respondents expect sales this year to match last year's performance. Just less than 20% expect a decline.

Former president and chief mentor of the CMAI Rahul Mehta told *The Hindu* in a prelude to Diwali season, the eastern States did well for Dasara offtake.



Festive outlook: Respondents of the CMAI survey expect sales this year to match last year's performance. MOORTHY G.

However, sales in the southern States for Navrathri was sluggish in the north and west.

"Despite the textile inflation of 5%-7%, we think the festival season this year will be better than last year. Raw material prices have started coming down and the global geopolitical situation is not as bad as it was a few months ago. Sales are expected to pick up across the country closer to Diwali," he said.

The CMAI said in a statement strong order bookings by retailers at the CMAI's National Garment Fairs (NGFs) further reinforced the industry's confidence. While rising input costs are a concern among retailers, about 54% of the respondents said they were absorbing the costs by cutting margins and only about 35% had raised prices. "This indicates higher festive sales could come with continued pressure on profitability," the CMAI said. Indian wear is expected to lead the festive-season growth followed by western casual wear. Online apparel sales are also expected to gain momentum this year.

Rising China imports

Meanwhile, according to R. Dhamodharan, secretary of the South India Hosiery Manufacturers Association, "Import of cotton readymade garments from China during April-August was worth ₹508.64 crore against ₹283.65 crore for the same period last year.

"Several traders are placing orders in China and importing the garments now."

Further, distributors and consumers may not absorb price increase now. "So, the manufacturers (in Tiruppur) are looking at revising the prices after the festival," he said.

What SBI had in place for cyber defence

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

The suspected customer-data exposure at State Bank of India (SBI) has brought its cybersecurity preparedness into focus, despite the bank reporting an extensive array of safeguards in its annual disclosures.

SBI's FY2025-26 Sustainability Report and Annual Report, published before the reported exposure, detail its security audits, automated threat monitoring, incident-response procedures and employee training. The disclosures also outline plans to further integrate its cyber-defence operations.

Extensive audits

SBI's Sustainability Report says information-systems audits covered 427 IT systems during FY26. Audits of outsourced IT activities covered 695 activities, while internal and external cybersecurity audits covered 176 IT applications and infrastructure and 151 systems, respectively.

However, the report does not disclose the findings, the number of vulnerabilities identified or how many were rectified.

SBI reported "nil" instances of data breaches during FY26.

The bank's Global Cyber Security Operations Centre (GCSOC) continuously monitors critical information systems for threats and unauthorised access. Automated tracking of indicators of compromise (IoCs)—digital clues that may signal cyberattacks—has replaced a previously manual process.



SBI's Global Cyber Security Operations Centre monitors critical information systems. ANI

SBI also monitors phishing, fraudulent websites, brand impersonation, vishing and rogue mobile applications, pursuing the removal of malicious links and websites.

Its Annual Report cites an automated Secure Configuration Monitoring System covering more than 85,000 IT assets. AI-driven intelligence platforms, risk profiling and continuous monitoring of digital transactions help identify suspicious activity.

Security testing includes ethical hacking, vulnerability assessments, penetration testing and red-team exercises across websites, mobile applications, databases, networks and internal systems. Monthly domain-password-spray tests seek to identify employees using easily guessed passwords.

Firewalls, encryption, multi-factor authentication and data-loss prevention tools provide additional safeguards.

CERT SBI serves as the central first responder to cyber incidents. Its response framework covers detection, containment, eradication, recovery and post-incident reviews.

SEBI eases rules for early share delivery

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

The SEBI on Thursday amended Early Pay-In (EPI) rules to ease margin requirements for stockbrokers and investors, allowing the value of shares delivered early to be recognised towards margin obligations. The revised framework will come into effect on February 22, 2027, giving brokers and clearing corporations four months to upgrade their systems.

Early Pay-In allows investors selling shares to transfer them to the clearing corporation before the scheduled settlement date. The value of securities delivered early can be used to meet margin requirements for the corresponding sale, reducing the need to provide additional funds.

Under the revised rules, clearing corporations will calculate the accepted EPI value on the trade date. This value will be the lower of the value of securities delivered early or the value of securities sold.

For investors taking buy and sell positions in the cash market on the same day, clearing corporations will calculate margin requirements after deducting the accepted EPI value.

Brokers will not have to collect additional margin for these positions to the extent covered by the accepted EPI value.

eMudhra to exit global web security certificate business

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI



It will continue the business it is engaged in for issuance of SSL certificates for Indian websites.

eMudhra Ltd., whose intermediate security certificates' private keys were exposed on Tuesday in an extraordinary security incident, will exit the global business of offering web security certificates, the firm said after the firm's stocks hit the circuit breaker for two trading sessions.

The incident may have wide-ranging consequences since eight web security certificates can now be issued by attackers that seem legitimate to devices that have not received updates to distrust them.

The firm will continue the business it is engaged in for issuance of SSL certificates for Indian websites, a spokesperson for the firm told *The Hindu*.

Loss of reputation

The firm said web security certificates issued for non-Indian subscribers accounted for less than 1% of revenue but was causing a disproportionate amount of reputational loss for the firm which lost more than a third of its market value in the 48 hours after word of the incident spread.

eMudhra's web and document signing technologies are used across government and private entities. The IT Ministry constituted a committee to look into the incident.

Kaushik Srinivasan, eMudhra's co-founder, told *The Hindu* in an interview on Thursday before the firm announced the exit, that "perception threats had arisen" for the firm following the incident. "This is a one-off incident on a bad day," Mr. Srinivasan insisted. "A script error can happen to anybody, right? The key lesson for us is, it's more like once bitten, twice shy. Therefore, we will put in place rigorous operational security controls.

"We have not seen any significant negative feedback from any one of them and are quite deeply humbled by the support we are getting from our customers," Mr. Srinivasan said.

An independent firm not involved with past audits that failed to spot weak intermediate certificates would be appointed for a review of the firm's security practices, he said.

Mr. Srinivasan shrugged off concerns that forged certificates based on eMudhra's exposed private keys could be used in cyberattacks on smart devices.

"Smart devices generally rely on certificates that are more private trust not as much on public trust," he said. "None of the use cases we served on smart devices relied on any kind of public trust certificates."

eMudhra has replied to queries from the IT Ministry's panel and will continue to engage with them, Mr. Srinivasan added.

A.P.-Transco to tap capital markets soon

V. Raghavendra
VIJAYAWADA

As part of a major financial restructuring plan, the Transmission Corporation of Andhra Pradesh Ltd. (AP-Transco) is gearing up to float an Initial Public Offering (IPO).

This is to tap the capital markets as per the Ministry of Power (MoP)'s mandate that at least one power utility in each State should undertake an IPO subject to prescribed eligibility conditions stipulated in the draft Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (FRBM) framework issued by the MoP.

With this, AP-Transco was instructed to prepare and formulate a time-bound roadmap to facilitate an IPO following a decision taken by CM N. Chandrababu Naidu at a high-level review meeting held in August, as per a Transco Office Order (TOO) issued by AP Special Chief Secretary (Energy) and AP-Transco CMD K. Vijayanand on October 21.



The plan aims at boosting the financials of AP-Transco.

He said the plan encompassed short and long-term strategies to boost AP-Transco's financial position and sustainability.

HDFC Bank reviews 'leak of information'

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

HDFC Bank, India's largest private sector Bank said it was conducting an internal review of an alleged leak of information by two senior executives while not specifying the reason behind the inquiry or identifies of the executives involved.

"The bank is committed to upholding the highest standards of ethics and governance as outlined in our code of conduct.

"We take any report of potential violations seriously," a spokesperson of the bank said.

"An internal review into this matter is underway to gather and evaluate all relevant facts.

"To protect the integrity of the process and privacy of all parties involved, we do not comment on active internal reviews," the spokesperson said. "Appropriate action will be taken based on the findings."

Two executives overseeing key business functions reportedly were found to be sharing confidential business strategies and sensitive data with external parties. The move comes ahead of Anup Bagchi joining the private lender as its MD & CEO on October 27.

HDFC Bank shares on Thursday slid 1.85% to end at ₹693.30 on the BSE.

Jindal Stainless posts 11% profit growth led by rise in revenue, sales and exports

Gowri Lakshmi R.
MUMBAI

Jindal Stainless, India's largest stainless steel manufacturer, posted a net profit of ₹898 crore, up 11% year on year (YoY), for the quarter ended September. The increase in profit was attributed to the rise in revenue and sales volume growth. Net revenue of the company stood at ₹12, 874 crore, up 18.2% year on year, while finished goods sales volume stood at 6,64,378 tonnes for the July-September period, a 2.5% increase compared with the previous year.

Overall sales volume rose 14.4%. EBITDA (Earnings before Interest, Taxation, Depreciation, Amortization) for the period rose 3.2% YoY to ₹1,433 crore.

The company said the quarterly results showed resilient recovery from operational disruptions from the preceding quarter owing to geopolitical tensions in West Asia and fuel availability crisis. The bottomline of the company was also supported by a surge in exports rising 36% on year and 20% sequentially. The company continued to diversify its access to global markets with strategic importance given to South Korea, Colombia, South Africa, Brazil, and Japan.



Consolidated net debt of the company stood at ₹3,121 crore.

Domestic sales stood at 89% of total sales for Q2 FY27 compared to the previous year and was unchanged from Q1 FY27.

"Following the suspension of Quality Control Orders (QCOs) and the resultant influx of substandard stainless steel imports into India, particularly from China and of Chinese-origin, we focused on sustaining sales volumes by catering to growing domestic markets and pursuing new export markets, wherever feasible. Going ahead, we will continue expanding our market outreach initiatives and focusing on an improved product mix to cater to domestic and global markets," Abhyuday Jindal, managing director of the company, said.

Consolidated net debt of the company stood at ₹3,121 crore with net debt-to-equity ratio at 0.15x.

The company informed the exchanges on Thursday that the Board approved the amalgamation of Chromeni Steels Limited, Rabirun Vinimay Private Limited, JSL Super Steel Limited and Jindal United Steel Limited into Jindal Stainless Limited in order to simplify the Group structure, optimise utilisation of financial and other resources, and improve operational efficiency.

Cyient posts ₹132.5 cr. net; declares ₹12 interim dividend

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Engineering services company Cyient reported consolidated net profit for the September quarter declined to ₹132.5 crore compared with ₹142.9 crore in the year earlier period.

The net profit came on a total income that rose to ₹2,243.6 crore (₹1,831 crore).

On a sequential basis, the net profit and total income were higher compared with ₹108.7 crore and ₹2,082.6 crore respectively.

Cyient declared an interim dividend of ₹12 per equity share. On Thursday, the company's share closed 2.11% at ₹1,144.55 apiece on the BSE.

Q2 FY27 reflects sustained momentum across Cyient Group, with record order books and continued investment in the next phase of growth, Executive Vice Chairman and Managing Director Krishna Bodanapu said.

CPCL Q2 net more than triples to ₹2,271 cr.

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

Chennai Petroleum Corporation Ltd. (CPCL) reported a net profit of ₹2,271 crore for the second quarter of FY2026-27, more than three times the ₹732 crore recorded in the corresponding quarter last year, as its gross refining margin improved sharply.

Revenue from operations rose to ₹22,109 crore in the quarter ended September 30, from ₹20,069 crore a year earlier. Profit before tax increased to ₹3,032 crore from ₹994 crore, according to the company's financial performance statement dated October 22.



The company processed 2.590 MMT of crude oil during Q2.

CPCL's gross refining margin (GRM) rose to $20.41 per barrel in the September quarter, compared with $9.04 per barrel in the year-earlier period.

The company processed 2.590 million metric tonnes (MMT) of crude oil during the quarter, achieving a capacity utilisation of 98%, despite planned turnaround maintenance of one of its crude units.

For the six months ended September 30, CPCL's revenue from operations increased to ₹51,486 crore from ₹38,762 crore in the corresponding period last year. Net profit rose to ₹3,288 crore from ₹675 crore.

Venezuela claims 300 bn barrels oil; experts say it's a stretch



Highly doubtful: Experts say U.S. is gaining access to sites that are nearly depleted or totally undeveloped. REUTERS

Associated Press

Experts say Trump's numbers don't add up. A single figure sets Venezuela apart from the rest of the world: 303 billion barrels of so-called proven oil reserves. But experts say the country's estimate is inherently problematic and far from proven – rooted in exaggerated, ageing data from a corrupt government.

The number has long been touted by politicians and investors as an important measure of untapped energy potential, most recently by President Donald Trump's administration in detailing a sweeping deal for the U.S. to take control of some Venezuelan reserves.

But a more realistic estimate of the country's proven reserves – a gold standard metric, representing the amount of oil that can reasonably be extracted under current conditions – is about one-third of what it has reported, half a dozen experts told The Associated Press. They put the likely figure at 60 to 120 billion barrels, a vast amount but not enough for Venezuela to remain the world's largest holder of reserves.

Less profitable

The distinction is an important one as Venezuela and the U.S. attempt to attract new investment into the country's dilapidated oil industry, and it suggests that the deal Trump announced in August claiming the U.S. would ultimately control more than 65 billion barrels of Venezuela's proven oil reserves is much less profitable than he asserted.

"That's a funny, funny proposal," Evanan Romero, a former Venezuela energy official now based in Houston, said of the deal, adding that he believes the Trump administration didn't fully research the South American country's claims before wading in. "If the U.S. government called them and asked them to testify to how they did the procedure – well, the whole world will know that that's a funny number, an absolute lie."

Venezuela's government didn't respond to a request for comment from AP.

Trump has said that under the deal, the U.S. will control 65 billion barrels of proven reserves – a figure exceeding the entirety of U.S. crude reserves. He's repeatedly cited the 65 billion barrels number and called the oil deal the biggest in history, a way to refill U.S. strategic reserves and lower gas prices that surged during the Iran war.

But experts say the U.S. is gaining access to a mix of sites that are nearly depleted or totally undeveloped, with an expected output a fraction of what Trump claimed. Some of the oil fields are deep within the Orinoco Belt, a virtual wilderness in central-eastern Venezuela posing major technical challenges.

"We cannot believe the 65 billion. It's impossible," Romero said, adding that some firms have abandoned these fields because of the difficulties.

Economics of interception: India's private missile push faces its cost test

Rapid growth of inexpensive drones has created a different need: interceptors cheap enough to use repeatedly, yet reliable enough to protect military bases, troops and critical infrastructure; India's counter-UAS market, valued at $315 million in 2025, is likely to touch $1.09 billion by 2030

NEWS ANALYSIS

Santosh V. Perumal

In modern warfare, the price of a weapon is as important as its range, speed or precision. The ongoing West Asian conflict has brought this cost asymmetry into sharp focus: when a drone reportedly costing about $10,000 can trigger the launch of an interceptor worth hundreds of thousands or even millions of dollars, the defender may win the engagement but lose the economics of the war.

The rapid growth of inexpensive drones has not only changed the economics of defence but also created a different requirement: interceptors that are cheap enough to use repeatedly, yet reliable enough to protect military bases, troops and critical infrastructure.

The test of Jwala – a cost-effective interceptor against hostile drones, developed by the private sector – therefore deserves attention, as it raises a consequential question: can Indian industry develop effective, affordable precision weapons to provide the lowest sustainable cost per successful interception for a clearly defined class of threats.

It would be premature to talk about Jwala's cost of interception since commercial viability is yet to be independently validated for interception rates, procurement costs and performance against representative threats. But the larger picture is the growing interest from startups.



Future tense: An artistic rendering of Jwala-MK1 short-range surface-to-air missile. IG DEFENCE

Private-sector participation is a promising opportunity in a strategically important segment traditionally dominated by government-backed research and established defence manufacturers.

Developed by Indian defence technology firm IG Defence, Jwala-MK1 is a cost-effective short-range surface-to-air missile designed primarily to destroy hostile unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs).

An Odisha-based startup first publicly showcased its product, Jwala (meaning 'flame'), at the North Tech Symposium in Prayagraj in May 2026.

> Developed by IG Defence, Jwala-MK1 is a cost-effective short-range surface-to-air missile designed to destroy hostile unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs).

Unlike conventional air-defence missiles that engage aircraft or other high-value targets, Jwala is aimed at addressing the growing threat posed by drones through a relatively affordable kinetic interception system.

On October 3, 2026, the company successfully test-fired two solid rocket motors, an important step towards integrating the propulsion system with the complete missile.

Jwala uses a solid-fuel dual-pulse rocket motor, giving rapid acceleration at launch and extra speed in the final attack phase. It is designed mainly to engage UAVs, with an engagement range of 2-5 km and an altitude envelope from 50 metres to 5,000 metres.

Having cleared the preliminary phase, Jwala now has to undergo complete-system flight trials, validation of guidance and control, testing against representative targets, assessment of reliability and integration with the intended command-and-control architecture; only after which can its operational suitability be judged credibly. IG Defence intends to integrate Jwala with its GRID battle-management architecture, connecting sensors, threat assessment and defensive effectors. This could offer a broader solution than selling an interceptor alone.

Growth opportunities

India's defence-industrial base expansion gives thrust to the private sector. Defence production touched a record ₹1.78 lakh crore in FY2025-26, with private firms contributing about ₹42,000 crore or 24% of the total. Defence exports reached ₹38,424 crore during the year.

Indicating greater potential for the private sector, the Defence Ministry, in March 2026, had highlighted the important role of startups and Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) in developing indigenous defence technologies.

MarketsandMarkets' August 2026 data found India's counter-UAS (unmanned aircraft systems) market, valued at $315 million in 2025, is projected to reach about $1.09 billion by 2030, implying annual growth of 28.2%. However, they do not establish how much revenue will accrue to small missile makers.

"The drone threat is evolving rapidly, and Counter-UAS systems must evolve with it. There is a growing need for affordable interceptors that can be produced and deployed in meaningful numbers," Wing Commander Anoop Sharma (Retd), AVP, IG Defence, had said.

Other private sector players involved in missile production include Solar Industries India, whose defence operations cover rockets, ammunition and loitering munitions; Adani Defence & Aerospace, which is developing manufacturing infrastructure for missiles and other defence systems; NIBE Group, whose new manufacturing complex is intended to cover missile and rocket systems, among other defence technologies; L&T, whose capabilities span precision engineering, launch systems, defence electronics and integration of complex weapon platforms; and Paras Defence and Space Technologies, which reportedly signed a pact with U.S.-based Powerus to manufacture and sell the Guardian-1 counter-drone interceptor in India.

Success on outcomes

Jwala's success will depend on three main outcomes – reliable interception, competitive lifecycle cost and scalable production. If all three are achieved, it could establish a valuable position in India's counter-drone industry as well as etch a place in the global markets.

Investors see rising risks to AI trade from the U.S. midterm elections as data centre backlash builds

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK

Public opposition to data centres may jolt the AI trade as the U.S. midterm elections approach, with a strong Democratic showing potentially hampering the buildout that has lifted stocks.

AI has driven the U.S. stock bull market that just marked its fourth anniversary, as companies such as Alphabet and Amazon pour money into building data centres. AI's importance to the market makes investors highly sensitive to obstacles that could slow the development pace, with spending on data centres and other AI infrastructure expected to top $1 trillion next year, boosting corporate profits.



Election issue: A technician works at an Amazon Web Services AI data centre in New Carlisle, Indiana, U.S. REUTERS

Public backlash is one of those obstacles. As the massive data centres proliferate, many Americans are concerned about the strain on the environment and impact on energy costs, as well as about the technology itself.

"This is and has become a very tangible issue," said Christopher Gannatti, U.S. chief investment officer at WisdomTree. Since the launch of ChatGPT in November 2022, he said, "the key signal for the market has been how much money are these five or six huge companies spending" on data centres.

Optimistic outlook

Investors have banked on an optimistic outlook for AI expansion, and any question about its rapid growth continuing causes sharp market moves. Several segments of the AI sector have stumbled in recent weeks as debt concerns centered on cloud firm CoreWeave.

Democratic victories in both chambers in the November 3 elections, which would wrest control of Congress from President Donald Trump's Republican Party, pose the greatest AI-related threats of the potential midterm outcomes, market watchers say. A Democratic sweep of the Senate and House of Representatives is the most likely outcome, according to trading on prediction markets Kalshi and Polymarket.

Analysts are dubious about prospects for national legislation that would significantly stall data centre construction. However, they say Democratic leadership of the House and Senate would likely mean more hearings and investigations related to AI and the data-centre buildout.

Investors are also focused on state and local races where data centres have become pivotal issues and where authorities also hold sway over the pace of development.

Raise scrutiny

AI is not purely a partisan issue, as Republican voters also express concerns about data centres, but opposition appears stronger among Democrats. A *Reuters/Ipsos* poll released this month showed 69% of Democratic registered voters back limits on building data centres vis a vis 43% of Republicans. Even with a Democratic sweep, analysts doubt a bill that hugely hits data centre expansion would become law.

Musk's political baggage obscures SpaceX-Tesla deal prospects

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters

A possible merger between Elon Musk's rocket company SpaceX and carmaker Tesla may face bigger obstacles from politics than from regulation, drawing scrutiny in Beijing and potentially igniting a battle between U.S. President Donald Trump and the Democrats.

Musk revived speculation about a tie-up this week, calling a combination "a good idea" and confirming that committees at both companies were reviewing a potential deal, a step toward what could become the largest merger in history and create a company worth about $3.5 trillion. But a merger would also unite one of the U.S. government's most important aerospace and defence contractors with one of the most China-exposed major American manufacturers – a combination likely to raise questions about national security risks both in Washington and in Beijing.

Likely wrangling

Those concerns are unlikely to derail a deal, analysts said, but they would likely leave the combined company exposed to years of political wrangling and pressure from both sides of the Pacific.

Tesla's China operations, they said, could become a source of leverage for Beijing in any future dispute with Washington, while a Democratic takeover of the U.S. House of Representatives in next month's midterm elections could subject the deal to Congressional probes and political manoeuvring.



Not easy: A SpaceX logo is displayed on a building at Kennedy Space Center in U.S. AP

Democrats immediately raised concerns about the deal's implications, signalling their intent to turn the merger into apolitical flashpoint ahead of the November 3 midterms.

"If Elon Musk moves forward with the merger of Tesla and SpaceX, the deal would carry real risks that antitrust enforcers across the world would scrutinize," said U.S. Senator Cory Booker, a New Jersey Democrat who sits on both the Judiciary and Foreign Relations committees.

He added that he was prepared to conduct oversight of any deal: "When one person controls the infrastructure that governments and militaries depend on, his business decisions become national security decisions, too."

Musk could seek to address concerns by limiting how closely the two companies are integrated.

The greater threat to the deal may come later, however, if a future administration takes a harder line on the relationship between Tesla and a company increasingly tied to U.S. national security, analysts said.

"A merger agreement would involve pledges of limits to the connections between SpaceX and Tesla," said Derek Scissors, a senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute.

"I don't think the Trump administration would enforce these limits. However, the next administration could certainly begin to scrutinise a merged entity. This may be the biggest risk to a deal - that it could get unwound in 2029."

Exposure to China

For Beijing, a merger would effectively place Tesla's sprawling Shanghai manufacturing hub under the same corporate umbrella as SpaceX, a company that has become deeply embedded in U.S. military and national security activities through its Pentagon work and through Starlink's role in conflicts, including Ukraine.

"A formal merger would make it harder for Chinese authorities to treat Tesla as a purely commercial actor, raising risks for future factory expansions, data approvals, or market access," said Alicia Garcia-Herrero, a senior research fellow at the Brussels-based Bruegel think tank.

Tesla's reliance on output from Shanghai already gives China considerable leverage over Musk's business. A merger could extend that control to a broader corporate group encompassing strategically important assets such as satellite communications, launch services and military-related technologies.

BRUSSELS

International Criminal Court wins EU rights prize amid U.S. sanctions



AP

The International Criminal Court and its embattled staff have won the European Union's top human rights honour, the Sakharov Prize, an official said on Thursday. The award came just days after the Trump administration announced new sanctions on the court over investigations into the U.S. and its allies, including Israel. AP

BEIJING

Casualties feared after strong 7.0 magnitude quake strikes Tibet



GETTY IMAGES

A strong 7.0-magnitude earthquake struck Tibet region late on Thursday and casualties have been reported, China's news agency Xinhua said. It did not offer any details about the number or type of casualties. The epicentre was located in a mountainous area about 190 km east-northeast of Nagqu the U.S. Geological Survey said. AFP

LAGOS

As Ebola spreads to Nigeria, WHO official warns of 'complex' outbreak



REUTERS

The World Health Organization's Africa chief warned on Thursday that the continent now faced a "complex" Ebola outbreak after the virus crossed from east Africa to Nigeria, which has reported the first case in west Africa. "Nigeria has confirmed an imported case of Ebola virus disease," Mohamed Janabi told a media briefing. AFP

YANGON

Suu Kyi sounded 'fairly healthy', son says after first call in years



MYANMAR PRESIDENT SPOKESPERSON OFFICE VIA AP

The son of Myanmar's Aung San Suu Kyi has said that she sounded "fairly healthy" after speaking to the detained ex-democratic leader on Thursday for the first time in more than five years. "She was able to say she was in good health, but being 81, things aren't getting any better," said Kim Aris, who lives in the United Kingdom. AFP

Russia says 808 drones downed; pounds Ukraine with missiles

Kyiv endured a noisy night as 21 ballistic missiles came in three waves smashing apartment buildings, energy facilities, a railway station and the city's subway system, says Zelenskyy; attacks began hours after Putin agreed to resume peace talks

Associated Press
KYIV

Russia bombarded Kyiv with ballistic missiles in an hours-long nighttime barrage, while the Russian military said on Thursday that its air defences intercepted over 800 drones fired by Ukraine at Moscow and other cities.

At least four people were killed in Ukraine and dozens of others were wounded, officials said, in the large-scale attacks that began only hours after Russian President Vladimir Putin agreed "in principle" on Wednesday to resume three-way negotiations between Russia, Ukraine and the U.S. Mr. Putin's consent came in talks in St. Petersburg with U.S. President Donald Trump's envoy, Steve Witkoff, who had spoken of a "new momentum" towards peace after meeting Tuesday with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Norway. No date was set for the tripartite talks.



Ukrainian firefighters work to douse the fire at a shopping centre damaged in a missile strike in Kyiv on Thursday. AFP

Representatives of the three countries held rounds of "technical" talks in the UAE and Switzerland in January and February, seeking to lay the groundwork for detailed negotiations. But they reported little progress beyond exchanges of prisoners of war. Russia's aerial attacks hit 12 regions of Ukraine overnight, killing at least four people and wounding scores of others, Mr. Zelenskyy said on social media on Thursday.

The Ukrainian capital endured a noisy night as 21 ballistic missiles came in three waves, Mr. Zelenskyy said, smashing apartment buildings, energy facilities, a railway station and the Kyiv subway system, shopping malls and businesses. One person was killed in Kyiv. Ukrainians are bracing for bitterly cold months ahead as the recent escalation in Russian attacks targets the power grid.

Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said on Thursday that Mr. Putin had received an invitation to attend the G20 summit in Miami in December but has not yet decided whether to go.

Russia's Defence Ministry said air defences overnight downed 808 Ukrainian drones, with two people reported wounded.

Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said 630 of the drones were fired towards the capital between late Wednesday and early Thursday. Moscow airports temporarily restricted air traffic overnight.

French authorities seek to ban or curb new protests

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

French authorities on Thursday imposed bans or restrictions on new protests springing up in the wake of demonstrations last weekend that degenerated into the country's worst street violence in years.

President Emmanuel Macron said after chairing a meeting of key ministers and intelligence officials that curfews and other security measures would be imposed, including bans on "groups without legitimacy" holding protests.

"The priority is a return to calm," he said, adding that he would chair a defence council meeting of key ministers on Friday to decide "the next steps" for new nationwide demonstrations called for Saturday and afterwards.



Protesters during a demonstration against poor education and school conditions in Paris on Thursday. AP

The worst of the violence, Mr. Macron said, "was led by organised ultra-left groups aiming to bring down the republic", that he accused of "sedition".

Officials are still reeling from the clashes, widespread looting and vandalism of public buildings that broke out on October 17, on the margins of mass demonstrations of more than half a million people against the surging cost of living.

Mr. Macron's government has admitted police lost control, and candidates jockeying to succeed him in presidential elections in six months' time argue that authorities are incapable or unwilling to calm the situation.

Albanian MPs scuffle in parliament as students continue their protests

Agence France-Presse
TIRANA

Albanian lawmakers grappled on the floor of parliament on Thursday, as the opposition accused the government of violently targeting protesters over a week of unrest in Tirana, the capital.

Since last week, student demonstrators have taken to the streets to demand better support for education and to renew months-long calls for Prime Minister Edi Rama's resignation.

Protesters have routinely clashed with police and attacked government buildings, with more than 300 people injured and dozens of protesters detained.

On Thursday, during a scheduled vote, opposition MPs gathered in front of the speaker's podium, calling for the session to be stopped because of the unrest. The group held pictures showing the face and wounds of a protester allegedly injured by officers. Water and documents were lobbed towards the speaker, triggering a scuffle with other parliamentarians.



Protesters wave flags and carry signs as they gather during an anti-government protest in Tirana on Thursday. REUTERS

Dramatic scenes in the Albanian parliament are not unusual, with similar scenes erupting in the past and flares lit in the chamber at least twice.

"Opposition MPs decided today to serve as the voice for the demands of the student protests," Sali Berisha, longtime opposition leader and head of the Democratic Party, said in a statement. "This parliament cannot continue; it lacks legitimacy."

Socialist Party MP Pirro Vengu, from Rama's ruling party, in a post on social media accused the opposition of trying to "use the unrest as a path to return to power".

Anti-corruption rally

Several hundred protesters gathered outside parliament on Thursday during the session, but no clashes were reported.

The protesters have clearly distanced themselves from any political party, and regularly carry signs accusing both Rama and Berisha of corruption.

Anti-government protests began in May over a controversial resort development linked to U.S. President Donald Trump's family.

Rise of the students



Ballot call: Tens of thousands of supporters of the Student List attend a final campaign rally in Belgrade on Thursday ahead of Sunday elections in Serbia. The Student List is a leaderless movement that seeks to end the rule of longtime leader Aleksandar Vucic. REUTERS

7 tankers hit in Strait of Hormuz, says Iran

Associated Press
TEL AVIV

Seven oil tankers caught fire or were damaged in the Strait of Hormuz overnight after being hit by Iran or striking naval mines, Tehran said on Thursday, a markedly high number as concerns about a return to all-out war rise.

With days before a close election in Israel in which Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu could lose power, and before next month's U.S. midterm election in which war-linked high prices have sparked anger, there are concerns that U.S.-Israeli attacks on Iran could resume.

Iranian state television reported the claims about the latest attacks on ships, which the AP could not independently confirm. The report cited the Revolutionary Guard Corps navy, which again threatened to strike U.S. military bases in the region if the U.S. keeps helping to guide commercial ships through the strait.

The report didn't mention casualties.

France reports first human case of livestock virus Shamonda as man dies

Reuters
PARIS

France on Thursday reported the first human case of the Shamonda virus, usually found in livestock, in a patient who later died, with authorities adding there was no risk to the general population at this stage.

Transmitted by biting midges and most commonly found in cattle, Shamonda has also been found in horses, sheep and goats.



A representative image of cattle. GETTY IMAGES

"The European Centre for Disease Prevention and Control is carefully monitoring the situation after the French authorities announced the first ever reported human infection with Shamonda virus, a disease that has until now only affected animals," the Stockholm-based ECDC said in a statement.

"ECDC is in contact with the French authorities and European partners to investigate the potential public health implications," it said. "Investigations into whether the virus caused or contributed to the patient's death and how the infection was acquired are ongoing."

The French announcement said the leading hypothesis was that the patient was infected in eastern France, where the virus had circulated among animals this spring and summer.

American detained in Russia arrives in U.S.

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

A retired U.S. teacher freed by President Vladimir Putin after four years' detention in Russia for allegedly fighting on behalf of Ukraine has returned to the United States, his lawyer said on Thursday.

"Yes he has landed back," Stephen Hubbard's lawyer Martin De Luca told AFP, without providing details. U.S. President Donald Trump posted photos on early Thursday showing Mr. Hubbard smiling as he posed with U.S. special envoy Steve Witkoff.

Mr. Trump said Mr. Hubbard was released without the United States having to agree to a prisoner swap. However, the Republican leader lifted some sanctions on Russia ahead of the release and also agreed to purchase Russian diese.

Mr. Witkoff was in Russia on Wednesday to meet with Mr. Putin, who said afterward that Moscow was ready in principle to rejoin talks with Ukraine and the U.S. to end the war.

Estonia on the edge as Russia-NATO tensions rise

The NATO member is overhauling its military strategy, moving troops closer to the border and investing in long-range arms as the Russians employ grey-zone tactics on NATO's eastern flank; the country's defence spending is set to rise by 42% in 2026, reaching €2.4 billion, or around 5.4% of its GDP; the U.K. has maintained some 1,200 troops in Estonia as part of NATO's forward defence

NEWS ANALYSIS

Smriti Sudesh

On October 12, NATO's top military commander issued a stark warning to Russia. General Alexus Grynkewich, NATO's Supreme Allied Commander Europe, said that if Moscow were "foolish enough" to attack an alliance territory, NATO would destroy "anything and everything" involved in the attack.

His remarks came at a time of rising tensions between Russia and European nations. And one country that finds itself under pressure on the hot Russia-NATO border is the tiny Estonia.

When the U.S., Canada, and 10 other European nations came together in 1949, in the early phase of the Cold War, to form the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), they had a clear goal. As Lord Hastings Lionel Ismay, the alliance's first Secretary General, famously put it, the purpose was to "keep the Soviet Union out, the Americans in, and the Germans down."

Throughout the Cold War, NATO had been the primary military bulwark against Soviet power in Europe. After the disintegration of the Soviet Union in 1991, Russia fell into a phase of strategic retreat, while NATO expanded towards Eastern Europe. This set the stage for renewed tensions once Russia started reasserting itself in the region.

The situation became even more complicated after Russia annexed Crimea in 2014 and launched its invasion of Ukraine in February 2022.

Ukraine was offered NATO membership in 2018, but it never became a member. So it's not covered by NATO's Article 5 collective defence, but in its war with Russia, Kyiv is getting military support from NATO members.

The war has also prompted European states lately to raise concerns over Russia's grey-zone activities. These include cyber-attacks, sabotage, disinformation, and electronic interference.



On standby: The country has a trained reserve force of up to 2,30,000 people, while its permanent standing forces comprise around 4,200 personnel. REUTERS

A sensitive border city

Grey-zone activities are designed to put pressure on a country without necessarily triggering an open military conflict. Moscow has denied these allegations.

These concerns have become particularly important in the Baltic region, where fears are growing that Russia could attempt to spread instability beyond Ukraine without launching a full-scale invasion of another European country. This leaves Estoinia in a vulnerable position. Located in northeastern Europe, Estonia, formerly part of the Soviet Union, shares border with Russia and sits along NATO's eastern flank. The country became independent after the Soviet Union collapsed in 1991.

It joined NATO in 2004, upsetting Moscow.

A small country bordering the Baltic Sea to its west and Russia to its east, Estonia sits in an unenviable location. Its proximity to Russian territory means that any military movements, border incidents, and developments in the surrounding region can have immediate consequences for its national security. Estonia is not alone in facing these challenges. Latvia and Lithuania also sit on NATO's eastern flank, while Finland, a recent NATO member, shares a long land border with Russia.

For a country of around 1.3 million people, covering approximately 45,000 sq. km, Estonia risks getting caught between Russia and NATO is the crisis escales into conflict.

According to a report in the *Financial Times*, Russian state media has always portrayed Estonia as a hostile, "Russophobic" country seeking confrontation with Moscow. Russian officials have issued warnings about NATO's military presence in the Baltic region.

One location attracting particular attention is Narva, an Estonian city on the Russian border, separated from the Russian city of Ivangorod by the Narva River. Its geographical position makes it important to Estonia's border security. The city also has a predominantly Russian-speaking population.

Estonian officials fear that Moscow could attempt to exploit local tensions or use disinformation to create pressure on the country. The question for Estonia now is how to prepare for the possibility of the worst.

'Active' defence strategy

The Estonian government introduced the concept of "active defence" into its national security planning in 2026.

Since then, the country's small military has begun a major reorganisation, shifting away from a strategy that could allow Russian forces to advance into Estonian territory before a counter-attack.

From Tapa, one of Estonia's main military bases, troops are being redeployed further east, closer to the Russian border.

A new military facility is being developed in Jõhvi, while another base is being built in Narva itself.

According to the *Financial Times*, the planned Narva facility is designed to house around 200 soldiers, with space for up to 1,000 during a crisis.

Estonia has also begun shifting towards a strategy designed to prevent an adversary from gaining territory in the first place.

Rather than relying on a later counter-attack, its forces would attempt to engage Russian troops from the beginning of an invasion while using longer-range weapons to strike military targets behind the front line.

Col. Tarmo Kundla, commander of the Estonian First Brigade, has explained the thinking behind this approach. In simple terms, he said, Estonia wants to stop an invading force from gaining ground rather than allowing it to advance and then attempting to take back the territory later (a lesson learnt from the war in Ukraine).

Adding to this is Estonia's military spending and weapons purchases. Estonia's defence spending is set to rise by 42% in 2026, reaching €2.4 billion, or around 5.4% of its GDP.

The country has also signed contracts to acquire nine U.S.-made HIMARS rocket launcher systems and nine South Korean Chunmoo systems. This includes M57 ballistic missiles with a reported range of up to 300 km. This is significant because St. Petersburg, one of Russia's largest cities, lies approximately 260 km from Estonia.

Depending on the weapon used and the target involved, these systems could put military targets deep inside Russian territory within striking distance. Coming to Estonia's manpower, the country has a trained reserve force of up to 2,30,000 people, while its permanent standing forces comprise around 4,200 personnel.

Estonia cannot defend itself entirely alone. The country does not have its own conventional combat air force and relies on NATO allies for air policing and the wider protection of its skies. Hence, it cannot be separated from the role of NATO in its military preparations.

The U.K. has maintained a military presence in Estonia as part of NATO's forward defence. The *Financial Times* reports that Britain has committed to increasing its deployment from around 800 to 1,200 troops by April 2027. These deployments are intended to strengthen deterrence by making clear that an attack on Estonia could involve forces from other NATO members from the beginning of the conflict.

Estonian officials have expressed concerns about the possibility of a future conflict, but they are also preparing for the risk of a smaller attack designed to test the alliance's response.

"I'm not sure if we can deter the mad person. What we have to do is to prepare," said Gen. Martin Herem, former Commander of Estonian Defence Forces and current Defence Minister, earlier this month. "And that's the only thing. We have to prepare very seriously [for an attack], and in doing so, we may prevent it."

(Smriti Sudesh is a postgraduate student at SOAS University of London)

Israeli settler violence, olive theft in West Bank surge this harvest season

Reuters
LUBBAN AL-GHARBI

Brought to tears as he recalled Israeli settlers hitting his cherished olive trees with sticks and taking off with the olives, Palestinian Ahmed Salem said he feared being attacked if he tried to intervene.

Settlers have intimidated Palestinians harvesting their olives in the occupied West Bank for decades, but this year, not only has violence increased sharply, theft has been widespread, according to Palestinians, Israeli rights groups and the United Nations (UN).

The settlers dumped Mr. Salem's olives into sacks and then drove them to a nearby Israeli settler outpost to be pressed into olive oil, the 50-year-old Palestinian told *Reuters* of the incident around two weeks ago near his village Lubban al-Gharbi.



An Israeli settler walks towards olive trees owned by Palestinians that are due to be harvested in the West Bank. REUTERS

The couple, whose olive press settlers have urged Israelis to use for West Bank olives, declined multiple *Reuters* requests for comment, while the Yesha Council, which oversees Israeli settlements in the West Bank, did not immediately respond.

The attacks have accelerated ahead of an Israeli election next week that opinion polls show Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and his pro-settler coalition could lose to opponents who have taken a more critical stance against settler violence.

The olive harvest starts with the onset of cooler weather, allowing Palestinians to gather in the lush, terraced groves they have groomed for generations.

With the establishment of hundreds of small settler outposts under Mr. Netanyahu's government since 2022, the military has increasingly restricted Palestinian access to areas nearby, including olive groves.

Yesh Din reported 125 physical attacks on Palestinian olive harvesters over the 24 days since the season began and 168 incidents of crop theft, with Israeli forces present in at least a quarter of cases.

During this year's olive harvest, Palestinian authorities say three Palestinians have been killed in daily militant settler attacks, which have also injured several journalists, European diplomats and a French Mayor.

Israel, which has considered the idea of annexation, said it is investigating some of the incidents.

Shadows of sacrifice



Tall tribute: Art installation 'D-Day 1476 — For Your Tomorrow' by British artist Dan Barton and his charity Standing with Giants, featuring almost 1,500 life-size steel silhouettes representing military personnel killed during the D-Day landings in France during the Second World War, at Waddesdon Manor, Britain, on Thursday. REUTERS

U.S. Supreme Court rulings reshape November's midterm election battlefield

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
WASHINGTON

The November 3 midterm elections are quickly approaching after an electoral cycle shaped to an unusual degree by decisions of the United States (U.S.) Supreme Court, a development that prompted Justice Elena Kagan to voice alarm this week.

Republicans generally have fared better than Democrats in the spate of recent election-related cases, including in rulings on redrawing congressional districts and rolling back campaign finance restrictions.

It remains to be seen, however, whether these legal victories will help President Donald Trump's party in its quest to retain control of Congress in the midterms.

Democrats need a net gain of four seats each in the House of Representatives and Senate to overcome narrow Republican majorities in those chambers. Ceding control of either chamber to the Democrats would endanger Mr. Trump's legislative agenda and open the door to Democratic-led congressional investigations targeting the President.

Several Supreme Court rulings last year and this year have helped Republicans, on balance, make the national House map more favourable to their party in the election, though polls indicate Democrats still are in a strong position to secure a majority.

The court has a six-three Conservative majority. In a pair of landmark rulings powered by the Conservative justices, the court in April gutted a key provision of the Voting Rights Act, the 1965 law intended to prevent racial discrimination in voting, and in June threw out long-standing campaign finance limits – decisions that have boosted Republicans.

But when the court issued a ruling last month rebuffing a Trump-backed effort to restrict mail voting – a mode of casting a ballot used more often by Democratic voters – only the court's two most Conservative justices, Clarence Thomas and Samuel Alito, publicly dissented.

Republicans seem to have gained a net benefit from the court's recent election-related rulings, according to law professor Ilya Somin of George Mason University in Virginia,



Campaign signs outside a polling station on Thursday, the first day of early voting in the midterm polls, in Silver Spring, Maryland. AP

who said some of the key decisions "reflect long-standing Conservative jurisprudential priorities".

Mr. Somin also noted the volume of litigation this cycle, saying, "It strikes me there are a lot more Supreme Court election-related cases than usual, especially in a midterm poll."

Redistricting arms race

The court's decision that further undercut the Voting Rights Act made it harder for minorities to challenge electoral maps as racially discriminatory. Several Republican-led Southern States responded by rushing to dismantle House districts with sizeable Black populations in time for the midterms.

Black voters tend to support Democratic candidates.

Other Supreme Court rulings allowed starkly partisan voting maps for the midterms, fuelling an unprecedented redistricting arms race between Republicans and Democrats.

This battle was initiated last year when Mr. Trump urged Republican-led States to rip up existing congressional maps and draw new ones more likely to help the party pick up House seats in the midterms. Texas was the first to do so, and the Supreme Court allowed the new map.

Redistricting traditionally has been carried out by State legislatures at the start of each new decade to reflect population shifts measured by the U.S. Census, not midway through the decade as numerous States have done recently.

Ms. Kagan, one of the court's three liberal justices, lamented a 2019 decision powered by the Conservative justices that helped supercharge this political practice – called gerrymandering – that polling shows most Americans oppose. That ruling, authored by Conservative Chief Justice John Roberts, declared that federal courts have no authority to curb gerrymandering done for partisan gain.

Ms. Kagan accused the court's Conservatives of having enabled increased political polarisation by not reining in partisan gerrymandering.

The record for Mr. Trump and his political allies has not been perfect at the court, however. The justices last month barred Missouri from using its redrawn pro-Republican congressional map. And while the court permitted Texas to implement its pro-Republican congressional map, it subsequently allowed California's pro-Democratic map.

Additionally, the court declined last month to let the U.S. Postal Service enforce a rule targeting mail-in ballots, following a June decision by the justices endorsing grace periods for mail voting, over Republican objections.

All told, however, the court's election-related rulings so far this cycle have favoured the election priorities of Mr. Trump and his party, reflecting a broader pattern, according to University of Illinois Chicago law professor Steve Schwinn.

"Court rulings this year and over the last decade have decidedly tilted the political playing field in favour of Republicans," Mr. Schwinn said.

THE PLAN

We make sure to kill the game in the PowerPlay, says Samson



ANI

You have different approaches when you have a really good start. We phrase it very differently, like PowerPlays are different, middle overs are different and the death (overs) are different. If we get off to a flyer, we make sure to kill the game in the PowerPlay itself — Sanju Samson about his blistering starts with Abhishek Sharma.

MATCH-WINNERS

This is just an example of the openers doing the job: Shreyas



AFP

They (Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma) know exactly what they're doing. Once they get going, it's just about the momentum they carry forward, and today (Thursday) was just an example of that. Once they click, they set up a game for us — India captain Shreyas Iyer lauding the openers.

PHILLIPS' TAKE

'The bounce is a bit more, but the Indian batters adjusted really well'



ANI

We had all our plans on the drawing board, but at the end of the day, you've got to execute them. The pitches are fantastic as well. The bounce is probably a little more than they're used to, and they (Indian batters) adjusted really well — Glenn Phillips, who top-scored for New Zealand with an unbeaten 82.

GAME-CHANGER

It was magnificent to see the way Dhir batted, says Shreyas



AP

He gives us a lot of options, particularly against left-hand batters (with his off-spin), even the right-handers, especially on this ground [Hagley Oval]. Bowling those two-three crucial overs can change the momentum. It was magnificent to see him bat... the way he showed calmness and composure — Shreyas Iyer on Naman Dhir.

Samson's onslaught sets up India's record chase

The opener smashes 67 off 33 balls while skipper Shreyas and Dhir chip in with vital cameos as the visiting side gets over the line with two deliveries to spare; Phillips' fireworks in vain

INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
CHRISTCHURCH

Sanju Samson maintained his remarkable run this calendar year with a sublime 33-ball 67 (8x4, 4x6) as India pulled off its highest chase in T20Is, overcoming a mid-innings stumble for a four-wicket win in the series-opener against New Zealand here on Thursday.

Put in to bat, Finn Allen (45, 24b, 5x4, 2x6) and Glenn Phillips (82 n.o., 40b, 8x4, 3x6) fired New Zealand to a steep 225 for four, highlighting India's struggles with the ball.

However, Samson ensured a flying start for the visitors before a collapse made the game interesting. Eventually, cameos from captain Shreyas Iyer (42, 28b, 1x4, 2x6) and Naman Dhir (42 n.o., 15b, 5x4, 2x6) helped India get over the line with two balls to spare.

The tie looked as good as done with India racing to 94 for one in the PowerPlay.



On the rampage: Samson took the attack to the Kiwi bowlers as India seized control of the chase. AP

However, the Men in Blue faltered against the spin duo of Mitchell Santner and Michael Bracewell in the middle overs, losing three wickets for seven runs to spice up the contest.

From 93 for no loss, India slipped to 122 for four in the 11th over.

The long boundaries here also came into play as the likes of Tilak Varma and Ishan Kishan perished trying to clear the ropes.

The middle-order failed to capitalise on the electric start provided by Samson. It was the 31-year-old's eighth fifty-plus score in 26 innings this year.

Samson mainly targeted the straight boundary and his standout hit was the flick off Lockie Ferguson that went sailing over long-on.

Abhishek Sharma (29, 12b, 2x4, 3x6) was happy to play second fiddle in the 93-run opening stand. He pulled Adam Milne for consecutive sixes in the fourth over. Following the quick wickets, Shreyas took the game deep and also had luck going his way. Finn Allen dropped a tough catch in the 15th over, leaving India to get 55 runs off the last 30 balls with five wickets in hand.

Batting alongside the skipper, Dhir came up with timely strikes to release pressure.

Earlier, the Indian attack looked toothless against a rampaging Allen and Phillips.

It was the joint-highest total against India and also New Zealand's highest on home soil.

SCOREBOARD

NEW ZEALAND
Tim Seifert c Samson b Mayank 24 *(17b, 3x4, 1x6)*, Finn Allen c Tilak b Axar 45 *(24b, 5x4, 2x6)*, Daryl Mitchell c Bhuvneshwar b Arshdeep 28 *(19b, 2x4, 1x6)*, Glenn Phillips (not out) 82 *(40b, 8x4, 3x6)*, Bevon Jacobs run out 31 *(16b, 3x6)*, Michael Bracewell (not out) 7 *(6b)*; Extras (nb-2, w-6): 8; Total (for four wkts. in 20 overs): 225.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-49 (Seifert, 4.6 overs), 2-80 (Allen, 7.4), 3-122 (Mitchell, 12.1), 4-195 (Jacobs, 17.3).

INDIA BOWLING
Bhuvneshwar 4-0-49-0, Arshdeep 4-0-45-1, Mayank 4-0-40-1, Axar 4-0-51-1, Nitish 4-0-40-0.

INDIA
Sanju Samson b Santner 67 *(33b, 8x4, 4x6)*, Abhishek Sharma c Milne b Bracewell 29 *(12b, 2x4, 3x6)*, Tilak Varma c Ferguson b Bracewell 6 *(11b)*, Shreyas Iyer c Santner b Milne 42 *(28b, 1x4, 2x6)*, Ishan Kishan c Allen b Santner 1 *(3b)*, Axar Patel c sub (Conway) b Ferguson 24 *(14b, 3x4, 1x6)*, Naman Dhir (not out) 42 *(15b, 5x4, 2x6)*, Nitish Kumar (not out) 2 *(3b)*; Extras (nb-1, w-16): 17; Total (for six wkts. in 19.4 overs): 230.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-93 (Abhishek, 5.5), 2-115 (Samson, 8.6), 3-117 (Tilak, 9.3), 4-122 (Kishan, 10.3), 5-167 (Axar, 14.3), 6-210 (Shreyas, 18.1).

NEW ZEALAND BOWLING
Henry 3.4-0-57-0, Milne 3-0-43-1, Ferguson 3-0-34-1, Bracewell 4-0-37-2, Santner 4-0-39-2, Smith 2-0-20-0.

Toss: India.
PoM: Samson.
India won by four wickets with two balls remaining to lead five-match series 1-0.
Second T20I: October 24, Christchurch, 12.30 p.m. IST.

Stat Attack

1 Five Indian bowlers conceded 40-plus runs in a T20I innings for the first time. It was the 13th occasion in men's T20Is

1 India registered its highest successful T20I chase, bettering the 209 against Australia (Visakhapatnam, 2023) and New Zealand (Raipur, 2026)

2 It was also the second-highest successful chase by a team against New Zealand in T20Is after the 244 by Australia at Auckland in 2018

3 Three batters (Daryl Mitchell, Bevon Jacobs and Abhishek Sharma) smashed the first ball they faced for a six, the joint-most in a men's T20I. The only other instance (full member teams) came during the New Zealand-England T20I at Hamilton in 2018 (Liam Dawson, Chris Jordan and Colin Munro)

4 India recorded its third highest PowerPlay total (94/1) in T20Is (100/0 vs. Afghanistan, 2026; 95/1 vs. England, 2025; 94/2 vs. New Zealand, 2026). It is also the Men in Blue's best PowerPlay away from home, eclipsing the 82 they scored against Scotland in Dubai in the 2021 T20 World Cup

5 Abhishek and Sanju Samson were involved in their fifth 50-plus opening stand this year, the joint-most for India in a calendar year after K.L. Rahul-Rohit Sharma (2021) and Abhishek-Shubman Gill (2025)

7 New Zealand has lost seven of its last eight home T20Is against India, the other one a tie (DLS method) at Napier in 2022

8 Samson made his eighth 50-plus score in 2026, the joint-third (with Ishan Kishan in 2026) in the list of Indians with most T20I half-centuries in a calendar year. Only Suryakumar Yadav (11 in 2022), Virat Kohli (9 in 2022) and Abhishek (9 in 2026) have more

42 Naman Dhir's unbeaten 15-ball 42 was the highest for India (No. 7 or lower batters) in a successful T20I chase, surpassing Irfan Pathan's unbeaten 16-ball 33 (vs. Sri Lanka, Colombo, 2009)

Compiled by **ANIRUDH VELAMURI**

India starts favourite as focus shifts to ODIs

ZIMBABWE IN INDIA

Lavanya L.
VADODARA

There's little that can dent the momentum of a high-flying Indian team at home, in its favourite format - One Day Internationals - hosting a side ranked 11 places below it: Zimbabwe. More so after a dominant 3-0 sweep of the T20I leg of a historic maiden bilateral engagement.

But one thing can: injuries. Fitness issues in India's seam resources have been a thorn in the side of the reigning 50-over World champion, and its resistance faces a setback with Renuka Singh ruled out courtesy of not building the required bowling volume for 50-over cricket at the BCCI CoE.

The Women's Premier League and changes (however slow) in prioritising pace at the domestic level have pushed a greater raw pool to the doors of the team which means this type of an absence won't sting as much as it would have a few years ago. But with the inaugural Women's Champions Trophy around the corner, India will sweat over Renuka's fitness and bowling rhythm.

The task for the present, however, is to replicate its T20I dominance over the Lady Chevrons in ODIs, too. And India's bulging batting muscle perhaps has that job in the bag com-



Smriti and Nandani... a lot to cheer about. X@BCCIWOMEN

fortably. Jemimah Rodrigues' absence due to injury means the door opens for someone like Yastika Bhatia, Tejal Hasabnis or Harleen Deol.

Josephine Nkomo's side is far from a pushover, and will hope to pose a tough question or two to the ODI behemoth.

The teams (from): India: Smriti Mandhana (Capt.), Deepti Sharma (Vice-capt.), Shafali Verma, Pratika Rawal, Harmanpreet Kaur, Harleen Deol, Tejal Hasabnis, Richa Ghosh (wk), Yastika Bhatia (wk), Vaishnavi Sharma, Nandani Sharma, Shree Charani, Kranti Gaud, Sayali Satghare, Jintimani Kalita.

Zimbabwe: Josephine Nkomo (Capt.), Kelis Ndhlovu, Beloved Biza, Chipo Mugeri-Tiripano, Chiedza Dhururu (wk), Nyasha Gwanzura, Modester Mupachikwa, Sharne Mayers, Loryn Phiri, Francisca Chipare, Kudzai Chigora, Nomvelo Sibanda, Olinder Chare, Michelle Mavunga, Tendai Makusha.

Match starts at 2 p.m.

Proteas level series in style

AUSTRALIA IN SA

Agence France-Presse
GQEBERHA

South Africa wrapped up a brilliant innings and 31-run win over Australia in the second Test at St. George's Park on Thursday, levelling the three-match series.

Despite another session being washed out on the fifth day of a rain-hit game, the Proteas took the remaining six second-innings wickets to bag the victory.

Travis Head's 121 and a 166-ball 40 from night-watchman Scott Boland held up the South African charge, as did persistent rain, but Wiaan Mulder removed both. While Kagiso Rabada finished with a four-wicket haul, Marco Jansen took the final scalp by dismissing Josh Hazlewood as the reigning world Test champion set up a series decider. The tourist was bowled out for 295 in its second innings.

The scores: South Africa 425/9 decl. bt Australia 99 & 295 in 107.1 overs (Head 121, Boland 40, Rabada 4/77). **PoM:** Bavuma.



Rabada. AP



Sensational effort: Liyanage blasted an unbeaten 27-ball 61 to power the Lankans home in a high-scoring thriller. AP

Sri Lanka pulls off second-highest ODI chase after Brook show

ODI TRI-SERIES

ANI
RAWALPINDI

Sri Lanka scripted a remarkable two-wicket win against England in the third match of the ODI tri-series on Thursday, hunting down a massive target of 430 with a ball to spare. Earlier, Harry Brook's record-breaking double century had powered the Englishmen to 429 for four.

Avishka Fernando (97, 83b, 11x4, 2x6), Pavan Rathnayake (130, 106b, 15x4, 3x6), Dasun Shanaka (97, 50b, 6x4, 8x6) and Janith Liyanage (61 n.o., 27b, 7x4, 3x6) were the architects of Sri Lanka's chase.

Brook smashed 202 off 116 balls (21x4, 10x6), eclipsing Shubman Gill's record (117 balls) for the fastest double century in ODIs.

Joe Root made 69 (66b, 8x4), becoming the first Englishman to reach the 8,000-run milestone in the 50-over format.

The highest ODI chase is South Africa's 438 (for nine) while pursuing Australia's 435 in Johannesburg in 2006.

The scores: England 429/4 in 50 overs (Tom Banton 50, Joe Root 69, Harry Brook 202, Will Jacks 66 n.o.) lost to Sri Lanka 430/8 in 49.5 overs (Avishka Fernando 97, Pavan Rathnayake 130, Dasun Shanaka 97, Janith Liyanage 61 n.o.). **PoM:** Rathnayake.



Brook... quickest double ton. AP

Ashmita stuns Yamaguchi to make quarters

FRENCH OPEN

Press Trust of India
PARIS

Ashmita Chaliha stole the show as she stunned World No. 2 and third seed Akane Yamaguchi of Japan to move into the French Open women's quarterfinals here on Thursday. P.V. Sindhu joined her compatriot in the last-eight stage after she beat another Japanese shuttler, Riko Gunji.

Unseeded Ashmita defeated Yamaguchi 21-19, 21-18 in a second-round match that lasted 37 minutes. Sindhu prevailed 21-12, 21-16 over Gunji while Tanvi Sharma bowed out with a 11-21, 14-21 defeat at the hands of World No. 1 and top seed An Se-young of South Korea.

In men's singles, Ayush Shetty forfeited his match against sixth seed Kodai Naraoka of Japan due to an undisclosed injury when trailing 17-21, 6-11.



Ashmita... in disbelief. BADMINTON PHOTO



Top class: Gold winners Toman and Sheetal (compound mixed), Shailesh (high jump) and Dharmaraj (long jump).

Sheetal earns double gold; Indians continue to shine in athletics

PARA ASIAN GAMES

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

Armless archer Sheetal Devi secured two gold medals in the space of two hours while the track-and-field contingent remained the biggest contributor to India's tally that swelled to 88 at the Asian Para Games here on Thursday.

India has 21 gold, 26 silver and 41 bronze as medals also came from swimming, badminton and table tennis. Sheetal combined with Toman Kumar to defend the mixed team gold against Indonesia's Teodora Audi Ayudia Ferelly and Ken Swagumilang 151-148.

She then overcame a four-point deficit to defeat Singapore's Alim Nur Syahidah 142-139 in a repeat of the 2023 individual final.

Suvarna Raj won women's F54 discus throw with 15.66m, the wheelchair-bound 44-year-old recording four efforts beyond 15m. Shailesh Kumar led the sweep of the men's T63 high jump event. Shailesh, who had bagged long jump bronze on Wednesday, leapt a Games record 1.89m. Varun Bhati took silver with a season's best of 1.84m while Rahul completed the podium with 1.81m.

Sprinters Anjanaben Bumbadiya (59.97s) and Dilip Mahadu Gavit (48.27s) won gold in their respective T47 400m competitions. Jayanti Behera (1:00.65) came second to Anajanaben. Long jumper Dharmaraj Solairaj defended his Games crown with an Asian record of 7.15m in the T44/T62/T64 combined event.

Teenaged swimmer Ravi Budigina (25.89s) completed a hat-trick of medals with a bronze in the men's S13 50m freestyle event.

SNAPSHOTS



Anahat stuns El Sherbini, reaches quarterfinals

World No. 15 Anahat Singh stunned the No. 3-ranked Nour El Sherbini 11-8, 11-8, 11-7 in the second round to storm into the women's quarterfinals of the Silicon Valley Open squash, a $143,500 PSA Gold event, in Redwood City (USA).

Bangalore Winter season to begin on November 1

The Bangalore Winter season will begin on November 1 and the concluding meeting will be on March 13, 2027 in the 24-day race season. The Zavaray S. Poonawalla Bangalore Derby will be held on January 26.

The race dates: November: 1, 8, 13, 20, 27, 28; **December:** 4, 11, 12, 18, 25: **January:** 2, 8, 9, 15, 25, 26; **February:** 5, 12, 13, 19, 27; **March:** 12, 13.

Marathon runner Aga banned for six years

One of the world's leading marathon runners, Ruti Aga, has been banned for six years after track and field's anti-doping investigators found she submitted a fake prescription to explain a failed drug test. The Ethiopian runner had won the Tokyo Marathon in 2019 and reached the podium at the Berlin and New York Marathons. She tested positive for the banned substance methylprednisolone after winning a half-marathon in China in March.

Tour de France will visit three nations

The 2027 Tour de France will visit three nations in the first three days before competitors put in the most time trial kilometers in 15 years. The Tour will start in Scotland capital Edinburgh on July 2. It will then go to England and Wales before moving to France, where it will be held till July 25. With reigning champion Tadej Pogacar bidding for a record-breaking sixth title, cycling's biggest race could be decided in the Pyrenees during the final week. Britain will also host the first three of the nine total stages in the women's race, won last year by Demi Vollering. It will begin in Leeds on July 30.



Cracking start: Chiara was rewarded for her positive intent.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Chiara's aggressive play hands her the early lead

The Swiss goes all out at the start, earning shots on three of her first four holes; Shannon, the only golfer to go bogey-free in the first round, sits tied-second; Pranavi and Avani joint fifth

INDIAN OPEN GOLF

Uthra Ganesan
GURUGRAM

Shannon Tan preferred consistency over flamboyance, playing a bogey-free opening round in her title defence of the Hero Women's Indian Open here on Thursday for a share of the second spot, even as Chiara Tamburlini rocked the DLF Golf and Country Club with aggressive play to go top of the leaderboard.

Chiara delivered a five-under 67 on a tricky course that has tested the best over the years, racking up seven birdies and dropping shots on the seventh and 15th holes to finish one stroke ahead of Shannon and Argentine Magdalena Simmermacher (tied on 68).

Pranavi Urs and Avani Prashanth led the Indian charge and were part of a five-way tie at fifth spot with two-under 70.

Shannon, playing a cautious game, was the only player to not drop a shot on the day, her four birdies – two each on the front and back nines – helping her stay close to the top.

The Singaporean later said that going "bogey-free" on the sloping, softer greens was good enough for a start.

"I hit it pretty well off the tee and in regulation. I actually missed a few shots out there, like the putts that didn't drop. But overall, I'm bogey-free, and I will take that any day, especially on this course."

The approach was a contrast to Chiara's, the Swiss beginning with a bang to earn shots on three of the first four holes. She added two more on consecutive holes – ninth and 10th – but bogeyed twice. Pranavi, meanwhile, was content with a sedate round that had her struggling at times to keep the ball in play, a bad stomach not helping matters.

Top scores: 67: Chiara Tamburlini (Sui); **68:** Shannon Tan (Sin), Magdalena Simmermacher (Arg); **69:** Sara Kouskova (Cze); **70:** Pranavi Urs, Lois Lau (Fra), Avani Prashanth, Eleanor Givens (Eng).

Challenging, but a lot of fun: Aussie umpire Treloar embraces Ranji Trophy stint

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

For Australian umpire Ben Treloar, the last week in India has been an enriching experience.

The 44-year-old, as part of an exchange programme for umpires between the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) and Cricket Australia, was in the national capital for the Ranji Trophy encounter between Delhi and Gujarat.

Treloar will officiate one more Ranji game, between Mumbai and Haryana next week, before returning home.

"Incredibly challenging to come into a new environment, one that's foreign to me, and umpire this high level of First Class cricket here in India," Treloar said of his first Ranji game.

"It's been challenging, but a lot of fun as well. The great thing about this opportunity is being able to learn, being put under pressure in different conditions, and just learning more about yourself, the game, and umpiring as well."



Treloar. R.V. MOORTHY

Though Treloar has stood in 30 First Class games in Australia, the docile strip at the Palam 'B' ground was very different to what he had encountered back home.

It resulted in a lot of overs on the field in the first innings of both teams, with Delhi piling up a mammoth 648 for six declared in 136.4 overs and Gujarat responding with 479 in 174.1 overs.

"The main difference for me this week has been the type of pitch that we played on. In more recent times, there has been quite a bit of moisture, grass, and significant bounce on the pitches at the big stadiums around Australia," he observed.

"To umpire on a black-soil pitch this week, where it was a little bit slower as the game moved on and didn't break up at all, was a really good challenge. It was the first time I've umpired an innings where a team scored 650 (sic). It might be flat, but that doesn't mean it's easy".

Saka's injury leaves Arsenal and Arteta 'concerned'

Agence France-Presse
MUNICH

Arsenal coach Mikel Arteta said he was "concerned" about the severity of the injury to winger Bakayo Saka after Wednesday's pulsating 2-2 Champions League draw against Bayern Munich.

Saka, Arsenal's joint top goal-scorer this season alongside Victor Gyokeres, went off early after falling to the turf grabbing his thigh.

He was replaced by Eberechi Eze, who the Gunners' opener before Declan Rice scored late to clinch a draw for last season's runner-up after Alphonso Davies' strike and Harry Kane's penalty for the hosts.

Arteta revealed that the medical staff were worried about the extent of Saka's injury. "They are a bit concerned about Saka. When a player has to come off with sharp pain, it is never good news. We have to wait and see," said the coach.



Saka limps off the field REUTERS

Arteta coach spoke glowingly of his side's efforts and praised the home side, too.

"Bayern batter every team, so I really value what the boys did," he said. "That's one of the highest levels we have played... the level of opposition and our level as well. It was two teams that wanted to attack and play."

Rice was thrilled with his late goal.

"I'm so happy. When you play against teams like Bayern that are man-to-man all over the pitch, you have to apply certain principles," said Rice. "I just kept running, lost my marker and I was in on goal to score".

Manvanth's emergence is a breath of fresh air for Karnataka cricket

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

Manvanth Kumar plays cricket with freedom and flair. He rarely tucks his shirt in, is loose-limbed, bowls and fields with frantic energy, and loves the big hits.

Against Saurashtra recently, in only his second First Class match, the 22-year-old conjured up an awe-inspiring 135 (214b, 11x4, 6x6) after coming in at No. 9, with the score at 187 for seven.

Karnataka collected just one point from the match, and has a lowly two from its opening two Ranji Trophy fixtures, but Manvanth's emergence – 223 runs in four innings – has been a breath of fresh air.

Interestingly, Manvanth first made a mark as a fast bowler. With 22 wickets, he was the leading wicket-taker in Hubli Tigers' title-win in the 2023 Maharaja Trophy KSCA T20. In Karnataka's 2023-24 Col. C.K. Nayudu (U-23) Trophy triumph, he took five for 36 in the final against Uttar Pradesh.

In a wonderful co-incidence, R. Vinay Kumar, Karnataka's current head coach, was Manvanth's mentor at Hubli Tigers. R. Smaran, under whom Manvanth made his First Class debut in Andhra ten days ago, captained him during the C.K. Nayudu triumph.



On fire: Manvanth says he doesn't wanted to be in a comfort zone and that cricket is the only thing on his mind. SUDHAKARA JAIN

"He's one of few players in the current crop who can make it big," said Vinay. "He is a stroke-maker, and my message to him is clear – express yourself. The kind of strength and reach he has, he can score those big 100s.

"He's a very good bowler too, and can easily touch 135-plus. We don't have that many good fast-bowling all-rounders in India. This guy can be there," the former India pacer added.

Like Vinay, Manvanth too hails from a modest background. He grew up in Mysuru, and his father was a Bengaluru Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMTC) bus driver, who now runs a travel agency.

Two years ago, Manvanth shifted to Bengaluru, lock, stock and barrel, having discontinued his studies at Maharaja's College, in pursuit of his cricketing dream.

"I never wanted to be in a comfort zone," Manvanth said. "I always wanted to build a career in Bengaluru. I have no distractions now. Cricket is the only thing on my mind."

Come Monday, he will line up against Tripura at the SDNR Wadiyar Stadium inside the University of Mysore campus.

Debutant Como schools Manchester United

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Manchester United was hammered 4-1 by Como in the Champions League on Wednesday as the pressure increased on beleaguered manager Michael Carrick, while a late Declan Rice equaliser earned Arsenal a 2-2 draw away to Bayern Munich.

Elsewhere, Real Madrid thumped RB Leipzig 4-1 and there were also notable victories for Inter Milan, Aston Villa and Real Betis.

The most remarkable scoreline, though, came in driving rain on the banks of Lake Como, where United suffered its joint-heaviest loss in the Champions League in the last 30 years.

Nico Paz scored twice for Cesc Fabregas's Como, with Tasos Douvikas and Jacobo Ramon getting the other goals. This was a second 4-1 home win in this season's competition for the tournament debutant.

Joshua Zirkzee pulled one back at the death for United, but it is now seven games without a win in all competitions.

Last season's beaten finalist Arsenal has seven from a possible nine after Rice struck in the 82nd minute to earn a draw in Munich.

Bukayo Saka went off injured early on but his replacement Eberechi Eze fired Arsenal into the lead, only for Alphonso Davies to level before the interval.



Impactful: Paz, centre, was the team's heartbeat with two goals and an assist. REUTERS

Harry Kane set up that goal with a magnificent pass and then gave Bayern the lead from a second-half penalty, his 10th strike this season in all competitions.

But Arsenal hit back as Bayern registered a second straight Champions League stalemate.

"We looked dangerous, we got the goal and we had a moment there where we could have killed off the game," Kane told broadcaster DAZN.

"Probably a draw was a fair result overall... There's a lot of games and we've got players with injuries, players missing tonight, so we take the point and move on."

Jose Mourinho's Real is one of five teams with three wins from three in this season's Champions League, as goals either side of half-time from Bernardo Silva and Arda Guler set it on its way at the Bernabeu.

Kylian Mbappe made it 12 goals in 12 games this season for Real before Tidiam Gomis pulled one back, but Yan Diomande completed Real's victory with a spectacular volley against his former club.

Villa also has a perfect record after three games, as it won 3-1 at home to Viking Stavanger with Ross Barkley's opener being followed by Emiliano Buendia's penalty and Henrik Heggheim's own goal.

Peter Christiansen got one back for the Norwegian champion which is still looking for its first win.

Inter had Alessandro Bastoni sent off midway through the second half before Carlos Augusto's late goal secured a 1-0 win at home to Shakhtar Donetsk.

Betis has maximum points as an Isco penalty handed it a 1-0 win over Feyenoord in Seville.

The results: Lille 2 (Diaoune 7, 39) lost to Galatasaray 4 (Akgun 2, Batrakov 44, Bentaleb 52-og, Osimhen 61); Como 4 (Paz 2, 57, Douvikas 49, Ramon 76) bt Manchester United 1 (Zirkzee 90+1).

Bayern Munich 2 (Davies 35, Kane 61-pen) drew with Arsenal 2 (Eze 25, Rice 82).

Real Madrid 4 (Silva 44, Guler 52, Mbappe 83, Diomande 87) bt RB Leipzig 1 (Gomis 85); Inter Milan 1 (Carlos Augusto 77) bt Shakhtar Donetsk 0.

Sporting 2 (Suarez 5-pen, 89) lost to LASK Linz 3 (Lang 15, Kalajdzic 63, Danek 68).

Aston Villa 3 (Barkley 23, Buendia 37-pen, Heggheim 62-og) bt Viking 1 (Christiansen 85); Club Brugge 3 (Vanaken 45+3, Seys 50, Forbs 72) bt Lens 0; Real Betis 1 (Isco 59-pen) bt Feyenoord 0.

Naman Dhir — teeing off in style

Nine international outings hardly constitute a significant or substantial sample size, and it is important not to get carried away and anoint Dhir the next big thing in Indian cricket, as has become a trend if not a habit

What has stood out in his brief foray at the highest level is his composure and calmness under pressure, and his ability to back his strengths and clear boundaries with consummate ease



AP

R. Kaushik

Naman Dhir loves a flourish. He has made only 110 international runs in six innings across the two white-ball formats, but 88 of those – a staggering 80% – have come through boundaries. The powerful right-hander has smashed 10 fours and eight sixes from the 49 deliveries he has faced in One-Day International and Twenty20 International cricket, which has helped him stack up impressive strike-rates of 142.85 and 285.71 respectively.

These are very early days for the 26-year-old from Ambala. Nine international outings hardly constitute a significant or substantial sample size, and it is important not to get carried away and anoint him the next big thing in Indian cricket, as has become a trend if not a habit. He will come up short, maybe even in his next fixture, but what has stood out in his brief foray at the highest level is his composure and calmness under pressure, and his ability to back his strengths and clear boundaries with consummate ease, no matter their length.

No surprise

Given his propensity to make a statement with the bat, it should have come as no surprise that he signalled India's victory in the first T20I against New Zealand in Christchurch with a six. Alright, so it came off a top edge as he tried to pull Matt Henry over mid-wicket and only managed to deposit it over the fine-leg fence, but that slice of luck was no more than he deserved as he played a stellar role in India mounting a record chase after New Zealand had motored away to 225 for four.

It was New Zealand's highest T20I total against India, and their joint sixth-highest overall, once again exposing the lack of bite in the visitors' bowling despite a first bowl in nearly four years for the country for Bhuvneshwar Kumar, the seasoned 36-year-old. There were periods, especially in the first half of the New Zealand innings, when the Indian bowlers kept things under check. But the hosts rattled along at nearly 13 an over in their second half on the back of a blistering unbeaten 82 from Glenn Phillips and a telling final kick from Bevon Jacobs.

For the first time in his fledgling T20I stint, Dhir did not get a bowl. His previous over, against West Indies in Hyderabad just over a week ago, went for 19, and Shreyas Iyer opted not to turn to the off-spinner, instead, using Nitish Kumar's full complement as the fifth bowler. Perhaps, the Indian captain's decision was influenced by the experienced Axar Patel's left-arm spin going for 51 in his four overs, but then again, with Nitish doing a reasonably tidy job - his economy of 10 an over was the joint best for an Indian on the night, alongside the rapid Mayank Yadav - Shreyas had no cause to turn to Dhir.

If he hasn't already, Dhir could soon supplant Washington as the preferred off-spinning all-rounder – Shreyas would be well advised to use his bowling nous too more often

Maybe, Shreyas knew - the benefit of hindsight? - that Dhir had something special to bring to the table on a cold, dewy Thursday night in the South Island. For India to mount a record chase in New Zealand, they needed many things to go their way - for the openers to lay a solid, fiery platform, for the middle-order to weigh in and for someone to take the game by the scruff of the knock and apply the finishing touches that often look so straightforward but are instead fraught with immense pressure and danger, especially after one or two dot balls.

Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma ticked the first box with a breathtaking opening salvo spanning a mere 35 deliveries, largely dominated by the right-hander from Kerala. It's not often that Abhishek gets so extraordinarily overshadowed that his contribution in an alliance of 93 is only 29, though in his favour is the fact that he got to face 23 deliveries fewer than Samson during that period. When the left-hander was dismissed by offie Michael Bracewell off the penultimate delivery of the PowerPlay, he had put India in the driver's seat, having struck two fours and three sixes during his 12-ball blitz.

Samson hammered 67 at better than two runs a ball but when he, Tilak Varma and Ishan Kishan - the two left-handers swapped places with the vice-captain moving up to No. 3 and the diminutive Kishan slotting in at No. 5 - were dismissed within seven runs of each other in the space of 10 deliveries, India were in a spot at 122 for four, needing a further 104 in 57 deliveries. As much as keeping in touch with the required rate was the pressing need to steady the ship and that's precisely what Shreyas and Axar did. Axar provided the impetus too with 24 off 14, exiting the scene to herald the arrival at the batting crease of Dhir.

The key

The consensus at the time, with victory 61 runs away and just 33 deliveries in which to be attained, was that Shreyas held the key, even though India batted deep with Dhir at No. 7 and Nitish at No. 8. Apart from being the captain, Shreyas' credentials are second to none and he has shown time and again that he is immune to the tension that comes with a stiff target ahead of him. But it couldn't be Shreyas alone who did the heavy lifting. India needed to score quickly from both ends with the required rate bordering on 12, which is when Dhir stepped up to deliver the knockout blows.

In domestic T20s, and in the IPL for Mumbai Indians, Dhir has shown himself to be a crisp ball-striker who is unafraid to hit in the air. In the position where he bats, at No. 6 or No. 7 (as was the case on this night), he is seldom required to do anything more than tee off from ball one. When he walked out to carry forward India's spirited chase, he couldn't have asked for a more dramatic script to leave his imprint.

Last Saturday in Bengaluru, in the final T20I against West Indies which eventually met a watery end, Dhir had reiterated the power and timing that nestles in his lithe, wiry frame. In a match reduced to nine overs a side due to inclement weather, India had reached 88 with 17 deliveries remaining when Dhir strode out at No. 6 to link up with Tilak. Over the next nine minutes and six balls, he made a spectacular impact. Nine minutes? Six balls? Spectacular impact? You've got to be kidding.

Ah, but we kid you not. Three of those six deliveries soared over the fence, propelled by strong forearms and impeccable timing. As he eased his left foot down the track and struck the ball over long-off, aesthetics and result grappled for attention. There was a certain nonchalance to his ball-smacking that reminded us - whisper, whisper - of a mirror image from a past era of another debonair batter from Punjab, who answers to the name of Yuvraj Singh. Dhir doesn't have the same swagger as Yuvi - it's unlikely that he, or anyone else, can replicate that - but there was an unmistakable air of authority that was cruelly, rudely washed away by the elements that ended India's innings, and the match, after 7.4 overs.

Dhir was unbeaten on 24, courtesy one four and three sixes, finishing with a strike rate of 400. Coming on the back of his 30 off 21 deliveries in his only bat in ODIs in New Chandigarh, his nominal home ground, last month, it suggested that here was a batter who, at No. 6 or No. 7, provided an additional power-hitting option to go with Shivam Dube and Nitish.

What Dhir did therefore at the Hagley Oval was not miraculous or completely out of the blue. New Zealand knew what he was capable of - several of the Kiwis have done battle with and against him in the IPL - and realised, even after Shreyas' fall with 20 needed off 11, that the game was far from over. Their worst fears came true with Dhir pummelling an unbeaten 42 off just 15 deliveries, propelled by five fours and two sixes.

Unflustered

Nitish's share in the unbroken seventh-wicket stand of 20 was just two, with Dhir contributing 18 in just six deliveries, among them two fours and a six. Unflustered in the middle, refusing to pre-meditate and backing himself not to blink in his first match for the country away from home, Dhir brought up victory with four deliveries to spare, ensuring that the breakneck opening stand didn't go in vain or that the mid-innings collapse did not pull the team down.

If he hasn't already, Dhir could soon supplant Washington Sundar as the preferred off-spinning all-rounder – Shreyas would be well advised to use his bowling nous too more often.

Dhir has five T20I scalps, but beware if you hit him for a six because each of those five wickets has come a ball after the batter has carted him beyond the boundary buntings.

Unless he bowls more often, he won't become more attuned to the challenges of the middle overs, and even though conditions in New Zealand may not encourage too many stints with the ball, Dhir will have his opportunities next month, when Sri Lanka come calling, and beyond.

To many, Dhir was the obvious choice for the Player-of-the-Match award which instead went to Samson for his tone-setting 33-ball 67. But especially at this stage of his career, Dhir is less interested in such 'mundane' things and more invested in setting himself up as a permanent choice. And in any case, team before self has been the mantra of Indian cricket for a while now, so why should Dhir be any different?

THE GIST

- In domestic T20s, and in the IPL for Mumbai Indians, Dhir has shown himself to be a crisp ball-striker who is unafraid to hit in the air
- Dhir's performance at the Hagley Oval on Thursday was not miraculous or completely out of the blue. New Zealand knew what he was capable of — several of the Kiwis have done battle with and against him in the IPL